

Ivanhoe



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF WALTER SCOTT

Walter Scott was the ninth of his parents' twelve children, only five of whom would survive infancy. A childhood bout of polio seriously sickened Scott, who walked with a pronounced limp for the rest of his life. Scott's father was a lawyer; by his early teens, Scott had begun both his studies at Edinburgh College and an apprenticeship in his father's office. Ultimately, he studied law and became a lawyer himself. His literary career began with translating German novels and collecting and editing traditional Scottish ballads. He would begin writing his own original poetry and novels in his mid-30s, around the same time he entered an editorial relationship and business partnership with printer and publisher James Ballantyne. In his 50s, Scott experienced a serious bout of ill health, followed by the bankruptcy of both his publisher and Ballantyne & Co, the printing firm in which he was also an investing partner. The only member of any of these organizations capable of generating a sizeable income, Scott agreed to take responsibility for not only his personal share of the debt but those of his partners and their companies, a debt of well over £10 million (\$13 million) in modern money. Nevertheless, he generated enough income from the six novels, two short stories, two plays, and 11 works of nonfiction he authored between 1826 and his death to pay off the debt in full within seven years. Sadly, Scott died, following a series of strokes, a year before the debt was cleared.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Two main historical contexts inform the action of *Ivanhoe*, which is set at the end of the 12th century. The political strife between Saxons like Cedric and the (unscrupulous and abusive) Norman aristocracy dates to the Norman Conquest, which took place about a century earlier. In 1066, William the Duke of Normandy invaded England, claiming to be the rightful heir to the throne through his cousin Edward the Confessor. Civil strife between rival English claimants to the throne enabled William and his forces to overthrow English resistance and for William to declare himself king of England, upon which he installed a Norman aristocratic ruling class imported from France. *Ivanhoe*'s King Richard is William's great-great-grandson. Only a few decades after the Norman Conquest, Pope Urban II declared the beginning of the First Crusade, a religiously inspired war through which European powers hoped to recapture Jerusalem and areas of Palestine they called the "Holy Land" from Muslim rule. The First Crusade culminated in the capture of Jerusalem and the establishment of a Christian

Kingdom of Jerusalem in 1099. In 1187, the brilliant sultan of Egypt and Syria, Saladin, recaptured Jerusalem, instigating the Third Crusade. European Crusader Armies, led by King Richard I of England, King Philip II of France, and Frederick I, emperor of Germany and Italy, successfully recaptured much of the territory Saladin occupied, but failed to recapture Jerusalem—a failure which Richard and *Ivanhoe* both lay at the feet of Templar Knights like Sir Brian. Following this embarrassing defeat, King Richard was captured by his enemies and prevented from returning to England until he could raise the necessary funds to pay his ransom.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

In the Dedicatory Epistle that begins the novel, Scott acknowledges his debt to the 18th and 19th century historians whose works he consulted for information about life in medieval England, including Robert Henry's *The History of Great Britain from the Invasion of it by the Romans Under Julius Caesar* and Sharon Turner's *The History of the Anglo-Saxons from the Earliest Period to the Norman Conquest*. He borrows literary elements from the work of Geoffrey Chaucer; elements of his characterization of Locksley, Prior Aymer, and the Cleric of Copmanhurst seem to borrow from descriptions of the Yeoman and the Monk in the *Canterbury Tales*. The vivid descriptions of the tournament field and the adventures of King Richard while in disguise as the Black Knight borrow themes and motifs from medieval romances including *Richard Coeur de Leon* and Chaucer's "Knight's Tale." Scott also clearly drew inspiration from the works of William Shakespeare, particularly the plays *King John* and [The Merchant of Venice](#), the latter of which examines the violent and extortionary treatment experienced by Jewish people in medieval and early modern Europe. Finally, the Dedicatory Epistle places *Ivanhoe* as a work of historical fiction that uses elements of medieval romance to comment on modern lives and events. A similar but more modern example of a book that uses a quasi-mythical medieval past to comment on modern issues is T.H. White's 20th-century [The Once and Future King](#).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Ivanhoe: A Romance*
- **When Written:** 1819
- **Where Written:** Edinburgh, Scotland
- **When Published:** 1820
- **Literary Period:** Romanticism
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** England in 1194

- **Climax:** Ivanhoe defeats Sir Brian in judicial combat, thus saving Rebecca from being burned at the stake, and Richard reveals himself and reclaims the English throne.
- **Antagonist:** Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Prince John, Lucas de Beaumanoir
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Masked Writer. Although he published his poetry under his own name, Walter Scott published his early novels, including *Ivanhoe*, under a pen name. This was in part because historical fiction was considered a second-rate genre at the time. Although many people guessed the true identity of “Lawrence Templeton,” Scott did not acknowledge his authorship of any of his incredibly popular works publicly until 1827.

Jilted. Perhaps the reason why Walter Scott’s jilted and unlucky lovers still resonate with readers today lies in his own personal experience. In his early 20s he fell in love with Williamina Belsches, a young woman of a much higher social class than himself. Although she and her parents tacitly allowed him to continue courting her for several years, she abruptly jilted Scott and married a much wealthier young man.



PLOT SUMMARY

The story opens at a moment near the end of the 11th century when England is divided into a ruling Norman aristocracy and an oppressed, native Saxon population. The absence of the rightful Norman king, Richard, amplifies the political upheaval: in Richard’s absence, his brother Prince John plots to seize the throne permanently, aided by unscrupulous and abusive Norman noblemen and advisors. In these troubled times, Wamba and Gurth are trying to collect the swine which belong to their master, Cedric the Saxon, when they hear approaching riders. Prior Aymer and Templar knight Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert ask for directions to Cedric’s home, where they expect to receive hospitality on their way to an upcoming tournament. Knowing that their Saxon master doesn’t like Norman nobles, Wamba misdirects them. But when they get lost, a mysterious Palmer shows them the way. Soon after they arrive, another traveler—a Jewish moneylender named Isaac—joins them. When the Palmer overhears Sir Brian’s plan to kidnap Isaac, he helps Isaac escape, in gratitude for which Isaac loans him enough money to get a horse and armor so that he can enter the tournament.

Soon, people from all around, including Isaac and his daughter Rebecca and Cedric, his ward Rowena, and his ally Athelstane of Coningsburgh, descend on the tournament grounds. Everyone watches in awe as the Palmer, now calling himself the Disinherited Knight, singlehandedly defeats all five challengers

(including Sir Brian) on the first day. He names Rowena the tournament’s Queen of Love and Beauty. He carries the field the second day as well, besting Sir Brian again with a little help from a mysterious Black Knight. When Prince John declares him the winner, the Disinherited Knight collapses from his injuries. Removing his helmet, the onlookers discover that he is none other than Ivanhoe, the son whom Cedric disinherited for falling in love with Rowena and for joining the court of the Norman King Richard. Made fearful by this evidence that Richard and his supporters are now in England, Prince John ends the tournament early and makes plans with his advisors, Maurice de Bracy and Waldemar Fitzurse, to complete their coup. Rebecca, a skilled physician, takes the wounded Ivanhoe into her care.

On the day following the tournament, Cedric, Rowena, Athelstane, and their party overtake Isaac, Rebecca, and Ivanhoe on the road. Soon after Cedric allows Isaac and Rebecca to join their traveling party, masked robbers ambush the group. Maurice de Bracy, having fallen in love with Rowena, plans to trick her into marrying him by kidnapping her in disguise, then pretending to rescue her. He and his friends carry most of the group to the Torquilstone, Ivanhoe’s rightful castle, which Prince John has given to Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, but Wamba and Gurth escape.

Inside Torquilstone, each member of the party faces peril in the castle. Athelstane worries he won’t get a good breakfast. De Bracy tries to woo Rowena. Sir Brian falls hopelessly in love with Rebecca and tries to convince her to become his mistress, but she steadfastly refuses. Front-de-Boeuf threatens to torture Isaac into relinquishing his treasure. Meanwhile, Wamba and Gurth join forces with woodsman Locksley, his friend the Cleric of Copmanhurst, and the Black Knight. They raise a motley but fierce army of angry Saxon peasants and skilled archers and, after a mighty battle, overrun the castle and rescue the captives.

As Torquilstone falls, Sir Brian puts Rebecca on a horse and rides with her to the Templar Preceptory at Templestowe, evidently killing Athelstane in the process; the Black Knight rescues Ivanhoe; the invading forces take De Bracy prisoner; and the Cleric of Copmanhurst releases Isaac from the dungeon. The next day, gathered under a large **oak** tree, Locksley and his men divide up the riches they managed to steal from the castle. Then the party disbands: the Black Knight reveals himself as King Richard to de Bracy, sending the knight with a warning to Prince John. Then he leaves on his own to finish rounding up an army. Cedric and Rowena depart to plan Athelstane’s funeral.

When Isaac realizes that Sir Brian has kidnapped Rebecca, he throws all his effort into ransoming and rescuing her. He rides at breakneck speed to Templestowe where, much to his dismay, the notoriously antisemitic Grand Master, Lucas de Beaumanoir, intercepts the letter he bears from Prior Aymer

encouraging Sir Brian to release Rebecca unharmed. Furious to learn that one of his knights has been consorting not just with a woman, but with a Jewish doctor—by implication, in his opinion, a witch—Beaumanoir declares his intention to try Rebecca as a witch and burn her at the stake when he finds her guilty.

Rebecca refuses to answer the trumped-up charges and coerced testimony of the witnesses at her trial, but at Sir Brian's urging, she does demand the right to judicial combat. Sir Brian had planned to fight on her behalf (in disguise, of course), but the other Templars demand that he stand as the champion for their side of the fight. Desperate, Rebecca sends a message begging Ivanhoe to help her. He has three days to appear. During this time, Sir Brian's conflicting feelings—his worldly ambition on the one hand and his hopeless love for Rebecca on the other—drive him nearly to distraction. He repeatedly begs Rebecca to run away with him to Palestine, but she refuses to accept or return his disorderly and violent love.

Meanwhile, Wamba and King Richard set off through the woods for Athelstane's funeral, temporarily distracted when Fitzurse attacks them in an assassination attempt. Soon, Gurth and Ivanhoe, recovering quickly from his wounds thanks to Rebecca's skill, catch up to them. Ivanhoe and Richard, still disguised, ride to Coningsburgh to pay their respects. After Richard reveals himself and reconciles Cedric with Ivanhoe, Athelstane returns as if from the dead. Sir Brian only knocked him unconscious, and a bunch of greedy monks have been faking his death to earn a large donation for performing his funeral rites. Athelstane relinquishes his claim on Rowena's love and the English throne and retires to rule happily over his own lands. While he tells his story to Cedric, Isaac appears and speaks briefly to Ivanhoe, who immediately leaves, followed by King Richard.

On the appointed day, at the final hour, Ivanhoe thunders up to the Preceptory of Templestowe to fight as Rebecca's champion. No one expects the exhausted, pale knight or his spent, sweaty horse to win, but at the mere touch of Ivanhoe's lance, Sir Brian falls from his horse, dead either by the hand of God or from the strain of his conflicted emotions. Soon everything else has been set to rights, too: Prince John surrenders to King Richard, who mercifully imprisons his brother rather than execute him, and Ivanhoe and Rowena marry. They will live happily together and Ivanhoe will achieve great renown during Richard's lifetime. Two days after their wedding, Rebecca visits Rowena to offer her congratulations and gifts, and to explain that she's leaving England forever.

brother of Prince John. In *Ivanhoe*, Richard is described as a tall, handsome, blue-eyed giant with great physical strength and a jovial attitude. He demonstrates his claim to the English throne not just through fighting skills that far outclass his cowardly brother John's but, more importantly, though the respect he shows for Saxon nobility like Cedric and Saxon commoners like the Cleric of Copmanhurst and Locksley. Unlike John and Sir Brian, Richard chooses to speak in Saxon, rather than Norman, when the occasion calls for it. He also shows that he cares more about building a reputation for personal excellence than one based on his royal blood when he joins the tournament and travels around England disguised as the Black Knight. Richard and Ivanhoe show mutual devotion; Richard repays Ivanhoe's loyal service abroad by backing him up in the tournament. And although he thirsts for revenge on his enemies, including John, Waldemar Fitzurse, Albert and Philip de Malvoisin, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, and Sir Brian, Richard shows himself to be a merciful and just man when he allows those with the properly repentant attitudes to be exiled or jailed rather than executed. Still, Richard has some character flaws. He prefers the life of a knight-errant to that of a responsible king; he risks his life needlessly in individual combat; and he seeks adventure when he should be on the throne protecting the rights of all his citizens. Moreover, once on the throne, his court is prone to indulgence and despotism, and his early death—at war in France trying to regain his inherited lands there—delays the hoped-for unification of England for generations to come.

Rebecca – Rebecca is the daughter of Isaac of York. She is an uncommonly beautiful woman, whose grace and noble bearing impress everyone from noble Ivanhoe to Prince John and King Richard, the putative rulers of England, to the notoriously antisemitic Grand Master of the Templar Order, Lucas de Beaumanoir. She is skilled in the medical arts and tends to everyone from lowly peasants like Higg to yeomen like Locksley and noble knights like Ivanhoe himself. Her beauty draws Prince John's attention at the tournament and she becomes Ivanhoe's doctor after he is wounded there; Sir Brian kidnaps her and falls in love with her while he keeps her imprisoned at Torquilstone; the accusation of witchcraft leveled against her by Albert of Malvoisin and Beaumanoir leads to the judicial combat that marks the climax of the third volume. Of all the characters in the book, Rebecca most fully embodies the moral and ethical imperatives of her religion, including charity and kindness, honesty, generosity, faith, and chastity. A lifetime of facing segregation, violence, and abuse have taught her to remain calm and courageous in the face of danger, and she, more than anyone else in the book, has mastery over her emotions. Although she clearly has feelings for Ivanhoe, she relinquishes them as impossible to fulfill. Unlike Ulrica, she prefers to face death rather than dishonor. And she allows herself to be scared by no man, even ones as potentially dangerous as Sir Brian and as cold-hearted as Lucas de Beaumanoir. However, in part to escape her feelings for



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

King Richard (the Black Knight) – Based on a historical figure, King Richard is the rightful heir to the English throne and

Ivanhoe and in part to escape the ongoing threat of violence she faces in England, Rebecca ultimately chooses a life of exile in Grenada where she plans to devote herself to the care of the poor and helpless.

Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight) –

Wilfred of Ivanhoe is the son of Cedric the Saxon, disowned and disinherited by his father for loving Rowena and supporting King Richard. Ivanhoe leaves England and follows Richard to Palestine in the Third Crusade, where his bravery and martial skill earn him a stellar reputation. He returns to England disguised first as a Palmer and then as the Disinherited Knight, waiting for his chance to reconcile with his father. In the tournament at Ashby, he single-handedly defeats Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Philip de Malvoisin, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Ralph de Vipont, and Hugh de Grantmesnil. Ivanhoe lives the values of chivalry, claiming that his life would be worthless without the fame that fighting and winning battles brings him. He loves Rowena loyally and remains faithful to her even after his father bars him from her presence. He acts with kindness and courtesy towards everyone he meets, including Isaac and Rebecca, and in this his actions contrast sharply with the racism and prejudice of most of his peers. In all of England, only he and King Richard are willing to fight to save the life of a Jewish woman after Rebecca is accused of witchcraft. Ultimately, having proved his mettle at the tournament and shown his virtue by defending Rebecca despite mortal danger to himself, Ivanhoe finds himself restored to his father's love, to his inheritance, and happily married to Rowena. He lives a happy and successful life, at least until Richard's untimely death.

Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert – Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert is a Templar Knight with incredibly worldly ambition and little regard for his Order's religious observance. He is allied with Prince John, Maurice de Bracy, and Prior Aymer, as well as Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Philip de Malvoisin, Ralph de Vipont, and Hugh de Grantmesnil, with whom he hosts the tournament at Ashby-de-la-Zouche. Sir Brian's time fighting in Palestine made him a famous and wealthy knight, and he returns to England in grand style, with fine, exotic, and expensive horses, gold and jewels, and personal servants. Despite having taken a vow of chastity, he doesn't feel scruples over kidnapping Rebecca and wants to make her his mistress. His cruelty and strength make him a terrifying opponent either in a tournament or in battle; of all the knights alive, only Wilfred of Ivanhoe and King Richard can hope to defeat him. Despite all of this, Sir Brian finds himself, much to his chagrin, completely powerless against the beauty, charm, and courageous spirit of Rebecca. He kidnaps her because he lusts after her beauty; her bravery in the face of this danger captivates him such that he falls deeply and irrevocably in love with her, even though his Templar vows and Christian prejudices make it impossible for him to have a relationship with a Jewish woman. His conflicted emotions over this state of affairs prey on him so severely that

he eventually dies of the strain.

Isaac – Isaac of York is a Jewish Englishman. He and his daughter Rebecca live a tenuous life in England, subject to racism, segregation, and prejudice for their cultural and religious identity. Much of Isaac's character in the book comes from medieval and modern cultural stereotypes about Jewish people. Isaac is a moneylender. The book describes him with caricatured Jewish features such as a hooked nose and a stooped posture. It shows him to be dishonest, frequently claiming poverty even though he is wealthy. It describes him more happily giving and receiving hospitality among other Jewish people, like Nathan Ben Samuel, than among Christians; he worries about sheltering the wounded Ivanhoe. The book charges him with greediness and opportunism—twice he struggles (and fails) to do the right thing when it will cost him money; he is quick to spot an opportunity to ingratiate himself with a powerful nobleman. However, the book humanizes Isaac by continued acknowledgements of the violence, oppression, extortion, and expulsion Jewish people in medieval Europe faced at the hands of Christian individuals who either wanted to avoid repaying their debts or who wanted to steal the Jewish community's wealth. Moreover, Isaac loves his daughter Rebecca deeply, and considers neither money nor his personal safety when it comes to her wellbeing. He also repays the kindness of Ivanhoe (in disguise as the Palmer) with help getting into the tournament, even though his "generosity" consists of lending Ivanhoe the money for a horse and arms without charging interest. He still expects the loan to be repaid in full by Gurth. In the end, however, England proves to be too dangerous, and Isaac plans to leave with Rebecca for the relative safety of the Muslim kingdom of Grenada.

Cedric – Known to his friends and neighbors as "Cedric the Saxon" because of his resolute and staunch support of the Saxon cause against the conquering Normans, Cedric is the Thane of Rotherwood, the father of Wilfred of Ivanhoe, the guardian of Rowena, and Athelstane's closest advisor. His household servants include the ever-faithful Gurth, the beloved Wamba, and the tiny Oswald. Cedric wants to unify the Saxons behind one person and lead them in rebellion against Prince John, King Richard, and the rest of the Norman aristocracy. He disowns and banishes his son Ivanhoe in an attempt to force the marriage of Athelstane and Rowena for the purpose of Saxon unification, and because he resents Ivanhoe's adoption of Norman dress and customs and choice to follow King Richard in the Third Crusade. Cedric can understand Norman although he refuses to speak it; he wears only identifiably "Saxon" clothes and decorates his home in Saxon style. However, despite his pride and wounded sense of cultural identity, he proves himself to be an upright, brave, and honorable man. Confronted with evidence of Ivanhoe's chivalric and personal virtue, he reconciles with his son; confronted with evidence of King Richard's love and concern

for all English subjects, Saxon and Norman, he eventually supports Richard's claim on the throne. Confronted by his beloved and faithful jester, Wamba, about his unfair treatment of swineherd Gurth, Cedric frees the faithful servant.

Athelstane of Coningsburgh – A direct descendant of the last Saxon kings of England, Athelstane is a strongly-built, relatively handsome, somewhat dull-witted and irresolute man. He respects his "uncle" Cedric and goes along with Cedric's plans for the restoration of the Saxon monarchy as long as they don't interfere too much with his general desire for comfortable lodgings, good food, and fine wine. In general, he lacks courage and conviction, although when his own honor is at stake—as when he mistakenly thinks that Sir Brian is kidnapping Athelstane's fiancée Rowena—he can be moved to rash actions, such as challenging much stronger knights than him to battle. After a near-death experience helps him to figure out what he really wants, he renounces any claim he might have exercised over the throne of England, pledges his loyal support to King Richard, gives up his courtship of the uninterested Rowena, and retires to his estates to prosecute his own personal crusade against corrupt churchmen.

Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer) – The yeoman archer, who later names himself Locksley, is *Ivanhoe's* version of traditional folk hero Robin Hood. He commands a band of robbers that includes the Cleric of Copmanhurst and Allan-a-Dale. He goes by other names in the book, too, including the King of Outlaws, the Outlaw, and Diccon Bend-the-Bow. In *Ivanhoe*, Locksley is a yeoman (middle-class Englishman) and a skilled archer who claims that he turned to highway robbery only in response to the abusive treatment he and other Saxons receive from the Normans. In contrast to Norman violence and corruption, Locksley offers an example of strong, fair leadership. His men follow his orders instantly and, although they make their livings through robbery, Locksley ensures that they divide up their booty fairly and that they set portions aside for the church and charity. To further prove his worth, Locksley shames Prince John at the tournament and instantly pledges his allegiance to King Richard upon that man's return to England. And he shows his unwavering support for the Saxon cause when he and his men rally to rescue Cedric, Athelstane, Rowena, and their friends from Torquilstone.

Maurice de Bracy – Maurice de Bracy is the leader of a band of European mercenaries in England to support Prince John's claim to the English throne. He and Waldemar Fitzurse are John's most important advisors. De Bracy models a certain kind of weak chivalry which the book characterizes as common among the effete Normans: he wears silly fashions, and although he tries to woo Rowena in the formalized language of courtly love, he becomes frustrated and abandons the task after just a little resistance from the lady herself. He shows cowardice when his own life is in danger, as when he tangles with King Richard (in disguise as the Black Knight), but he

refuses to dishonor his own personal promise once given. Fearful of Richard's wrath for his role in the uprising, Maurice de Bracy escapes to the continent.

Waldemar Fitzurse – Waldemar Fitzurse is a loyal supporter of Prince John and his rebellion. In contrast to the spiteful and impulsive prince, Fitzurse is calculating, calm, and a smooth political operator. He uses his skills to rally the Norman nobility behind the treacherous John and hopes to be rewarded with an important position in John's administration. Fitzurse has a strong sense of chivalry, but he ignores his scruples when it is politically expedient to do so, as when he agrees to commit secret treason by murdering King Richard so that John can ascend to the throne. Still, Richard takes pity on Fitzurse despite his attempted crime, punishing him with banishment rather than death.

Reginald Front-de-Boeuf – Reginald Front-de-Boeuf is a Norman baron who supports Prince John's usurpation of the English throne and who is friends with Prior Aymer, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Philip de Malvoisin, Ralph de Vipont, and Hugh de Grantmesnil. Earlier in his life, Ulrica convinced him to murder his own father, which allowed him to take over control of the castle of Torquilstone. Front-de-Boeuf is a huge man and a furious fighter, against whom few knights can prevail. His treatment of Isaac—threatening the man with torture and death in an attempt to extort money from him—demonstrates his coldhearted cruelty. Grievously wounded by King Richard in disguise as the Black Knight, Front-de-Boeuf dies in his bed when Ulrica sets his castle on fire.

Gurth – Gurth begins the book as Cedric's swineherd; when *Ivanhoe* returns from the Third Crusade in disguise as the Disinherited Knight, Gurth runs away from Cedric to serve as his son's squire. He is a careful and canny man, as he demonstrates when he negotiates *Ivanhoe's* debt with Isaac or escapes the clutches of Locksley and his bandits. He feels proud of his role as protector and servant to Cedric's family; when Cedric punishes him for helping *Ivanhoe*, an insulted Gurth contrives to run away. But as soon as Maurice de Bracy and his friends capture Cedric and his party, Gurth rushes to their defense. For his bravery and loyalty, Cedric ultimately grants him freedom.

Wamba – Wamba is Cedric's jester and his most beloved servant. The book describes him as a perpetually fidgety man whose attention jumps from one subject to another and whose body remains constantly in motion. Loyal no matter what, Wamba dresses up as a monk to sneak into Torquilstone and help his master escape. He also stands by friend and fellow servant Gurth and his master's son *Ivanhoe*. As a jester, he fulfils the traditional role of the clown in English literature (especially in Shakespeare), his alleged witlessness allowing him to make unusually wise and reasonable observations.

Prince John – A historical figure, Prince John is the younger brother of King Richard, who tries to steal the throne while his

brother is away on the Third Crusade. *Ivanhoe* paints Prince John as emblematic of Norman excesses and abuses, in contrast to Richard and the Saxons. John struggles to control his impulses—his fatal flaw, according to Templeton—which makes him unpredictable, reactive, distrustful, and often causes him to insult enemies like Cedric and friends like Waldemar Fitzurse alike. He is dishonest and prone to betrayal if it helps him consolidate power. And he has no real bravery; as soon as Richard returns to England, King John quickly surrenders and willingly goes into exile.

Lucas de Beaumanoir – Lucas de Beaumanoir is the Grand Master of the Templar Order to which Albert de Malvoisin and Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert belong. Though he is an old man, the hardness brought to his features by years of asceticism and warmongering cannot hide his inherent nobility and authority. Unlike most others in his Order, he scrupulously follows its commandments both as a knight and a monk; the sinfulness, greed, and pride of men like Albert and Sir Brian shocks and horrifies him. Zealous in his hatred and persecution of groups whom medieval Christianity branded as enemies—Jewish people and Muslim people—he initiates and presides over Rebecca’s witchcraft trial. Yet, he is a man of principles: when she demands judicial combat, he allows it, and when during that fight God seems to strike Sir Brian, he accepts the result as proof of her innocence and frees her.

Rowena – Rowena is the lovely young ward of Cedric the Saxon. Because her family has ties to ancient Saxon royalty, Cedric wants her to marry fellow royal descendant Athelstane of Coningsburgh, but she loves Cedric’s son, Wilfred of Ivanhoe, instead. Many men, including Prior Aymer, Sir Brian, and Prince John appreciate Rowena’s great beauty; Maurice de Bracy goes as far as kidnapping her in an attempt to force her into marrying him. Coddled and spoiled by Cedric, Rowena usually gets her way, which gives her a veneer of confidence that quickly crumbles when others frustrate her wishes; then she dissolves into irresolute and timid tears. Like Ivanhoe, whom she eventually marries, she treats Rebecca with far more respect and humanity than most everyone else in an era in which most Europeans despised and abused Jewish people.

Cleric of Copmanhurst – The Cleric of Copmanhurst, better known in stories about Robin Hood as “Friar Tuck,” is a monk-turned-outlaw member of Locksley’s band of woodsmen. A big, jovial man, he lives in a hermitage in the forest, where he spends his time not in prayer but in poaching deer and ransoming wealthy Norman nobles so he can redistribute their stolen wealth to Saxons in need. He entertains King Richard when Richard is in disguise as the Black Knight; the two share a love of good food, fine wine, and singing. In a fight, he’s good with his staff, and he even trades blows with the king (again while Richard is still in disguise). Unlike in the case of Prior Aymer, the book celebrates the Cleric’s worldliness rather than censures it, mostly because he is a Saxon.

Prior Aymer – Prior Aymer is a wealthy Norman monk allied with Prince John, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, and their friends and co-conspirators. He points to the corruption and materialism of the Norman nobility in contrast to the Saxon population they oppress. A worldly man, he wears clothes cut in the shape of a monk’s robes but made of fine wool and silk trimmed with fur. Instead of focusing on prayer and charity, he likes to hunt; instead of living a life of austere poverty, he loves drinking fine wine and feasting; instead of honoring his vow of chastity, he like to woo local ladies.

Ulrica (Dame Urfried) – Ulrica is the daughter of the late Saxon Thane of Torquilstone. When a Norman baron murdered her family and stole their land, he kept Ulrica as his mistress. Ashamed of allying herself with the Saxons’ enemies, Ulrica began calling herself “Urfried” to hide her identity and worked quiet vengeance within the castle, stirring up dissent and eventually convincing Reginald Front-de-Boeuf—the son of her captor and lover—to murder his father. She clears her conscience by helping Cedric, Athelstane, Rowena, and the rest escape Torquilstone by setting it on fire, and she dies as its walls collapse in flames.

Lawrence Templeton – Lawrence Templeton is the pen name under which Walter Scott published *Ivanhoe*. He is also a character in the book, the first chapter of which takes the form of a letter Templeton writes to his friend the Reverend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust explaining why he authored the book, excusing its flaws, and laying out his claim for the importance of historical fiction as a genre. He interrupts the novel with explanatory asides several times.

Philip de Malvoisin – Philip de Malvoisin is a friend and supporter of Prince John. As a Norman lord, he abuses the English subjects living near his lands. Along with Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Hugh de Grantmesnil, and Sir Ralph Vipont, he is one of the challengers of the tournament at Ashby-de-la-Zouche. King Richard I has Philip executed along with his brother Albert de Malvoisin for treason.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Reverend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust – Reverend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust is a clergyman and an academic, to whom Lawrence Templeton writes a letter explaining why he wrote *Ivanhoe*.

Albert de Malvoisin – Albert de Malvoisin, preceptor (leader) of the Templar Preceptory of Templestowe, is Philip de Malvoisin’s brother. A conniving, power-hungry, and mendacious man, he hides his love of vice under a veneer of obedience to his Order’s religious vows. King Richard has him executed alongside his brother Philip for treason.

Hugh de Grantmesnil – Hugh de Grantmesnil is a Norman noble who, along with Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Philip de Malvoisin, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, and Ralph de Vipont,

issues the initial challenge for the tournament at Ashby-de-la-Zouche.

Ralph de Vipont – Ralph de Vipont is a Norman noble who, along with Sir Brian de-Bois-Guilbert, Philip de Malvoisin, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, and Ralph de Vipont, issues the initial challenge for the tournament at Ashby-de-la-Zouche.

Higg – Higg is a disabled peasant who once received medical care from Rebecca; Beaumanoir and Albert de Malvoisin force him to testify against Rebecca during her witch trial, and afterwards he carries a message for her to Isaac.

Oswald – Oswald is Cedric's servant and cupbearer.

Alicia – Alicia is Waldemar Fitzurse's daughter.

Allan-a-Dale – Allan-a-Dale is a woodsman-minstrel and one of Locksley's most trusted lieutenants.

Nathan Ben Samuel – Nathan Ben Samuel is a Jewish physician and friend of Isaac.

Conrade Mountfitchet – Mountfitchet is a Templar and an especially valued friend and counselor of Lucas de Beaumanoir.

Ivanhoe, to defend the weak and persecuted, like Isaac and Rebecca. And it channels the potential for violence among a deeply divided nobility into the pageantry and display of tournaments rather than frequent civil wars. But on the other hand, its alleged values sometimes turn into vices: violence, pride, and ambition underwrite the entire system, leading to religious wars like the crusades; and underwriting abuses of power by men who, like Sir Brian and the Templars, believe their strength allows them to take what they want, from beautiful women to political power. Simply put, *Ivanhoe* argues that chivalry has merit as a set of ideals, but that the values are only as good (or bad) as the person who holds them. And, by portraying a genuine, unresolved debate about the merits of chivalry, the book suggests that a just and stable world requires ongoing, intentional debate and effort. No system—of government, of morals, of love ethics, or anything else—should be accepted blindly as the only solution to bringing order to the world.



DISGUISE AND DISCOVERY

As a book, *Ivanhoe* invests deeply in appearances. It describes in great detail the clothing and physical characteristics of its most important characters, in

many cases representing these as key to understanding the nature of each one—for example, in the way it associates Rebecca's beauty with her moral rectitude or Cedric's resolutely old-fashioned clothing with his proudly Saxon identity. Somewhat surprisingly, then, the book also features a long list of masked and disguised individuals. Wilfred of Ivanhoe and King Richard I travel around England disguised as the Disinherited Knight and the Black Knight, respectively; Locksley and his band of thieving woodsmen wear masks to conceal their identities; Maurice De Bracy, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, and their friends adopt woodsmen's costumes when they plot to kidnap Rowena and Cedric; Wamba and Cedric both impersonate monks.

Counterintuitively, these superficial disguises almost always allow rather than frustrate the revelation of the truth. King Richard's actions—befriending Cedric and Locksley, rescuing Athelstane and Rowena from Torquilstone, showing loyalty towards his friends and mercy towards his enemies—prove him to be the worthy and rightful king of England while he's still disguised as the Black Knight. Conversely, De Bracy shows himself to be a distinctly arrogant, uncaring man when he dresses up as an English yeoman thief to kidnap Rowena in hopes of forcing her to marry him. On a broader level, the masks donned by Locksley and his men point towards the corruption and lawless abuses practiced by the Norman nobility as they bleed English citizens of wealth and other resources. Moreover, the book portrays the few disguises which aim at real deception—such as Albert de Malvoisin's veneer of holiness—as incapable of hiding the truth. When



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



THE MERITS OF CHIVALRY

Set in medieval England—a time and place where society greatly valued knightly heroism—and borrowing from the conventions of medieval

chivalric romance, *Ivanhoe* spends a great deal of time examining the values of men like Wilfred of Ivanhoe, King Richard (the Black Knight), Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, and Maurice De Bracy. At one point or other, each one explains what he believes in and what he fights for. And although there are general points of agreement in their value systems—for example, showing courage and loyalty, honoring one's promises, and celebrating love as a high virtue—there are yet more points of disagreement. And sometimes supposedly good values, like religious faith, lead to bad outcomes like holy wars and religious persecution. By allowing its characters to debate the meaning and value of chivalry and by dramatizing its failures, the book develops a vivid and dynamic picture of chivalry that is neither wholly good nor wholly corrupt.

On the one hand, chivalry fosters noble values. It can encourage mercy, as when King Richard exiles and imprisons Prince John, De Bracy, and Waldemar Fitzurse rather than executing them. It encourages the powerful and virtuous, like

Richard reveals himself at the preceptory, he also uncovers the evil practiced by its Templar denizens. Thus, while characters in the book sometimes adopt disguises for a variety of reasons—to avoid being captured before raising an army in Richard’s case; to earn reconciliation with his father on Ivanhoe’s; to escape detection while carrying out crimes—their disguises all ultimately reveal the truth rather than hide it. Thus, the book argues, a person’s true nature will always make itself evident.



INHERITANCE AND DISPLACEMENT

Though the book is named after him, Wilfred of Ivanhoe begins the novel displaced. The Norman Conquest of 1066 cut him off from his Saxon roots when it replaced the native English nobility with a ruling class imported from France. His father Cedric disowned him for adopting Norman habits and fashions. And he has lost the land granted to him by his friend and patron, King Richard, because Richard’s treasonous brother Prince John gave the castle of Torquilstone and its associated land to his own follower, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf. But by the end of the book, Ivanhoe will be reconciled with his father, the usurping Front-de-Boeuf will have relinquished his castle in his death, and Richard I will be well on his way towards acknowledging and restoring the rights of the Saxon natives in his kingdom. In this series of restitutions, the book seems to suggest that, on the whole, people get what they deserve: the righteous are restored while the villainous are punished. The usurper moves aside and the righteous inherit the kingdom and its rewards.

However, the stories of Isaac and Rebecca, a Jewish father and daughter whose lives become deeply entangled with Ivanhoe’s, complicates this simple and supposedly happy ending. Subject to racism, prejudice, and persecution, the book realistically portrays the suffering which seemed to be the sad birthright of medieval European Jewish people. Yet, the beautiful, generous, kind, and courageous Rebecca possesses a nobility and moral clarity that make her the center of the book’s moral universe. Her story reminds readers that injustice and suffering are as much a part of life as just rewards, if not more. Still, her refusal to succumb to the abuse she suffers from Sir Brian, Lucas de Beaumanoir, and others, suggests the power of courage and integrity not just to bring rewards (as in Ivanhoe’s case) but to *be* their own rewards. Although she ends the story exiled from the England of her birth, she does so of her own free will. In this way, she claims both her right to exist and her right to make a way in the world on her own terms. And even though her ending lacks the simplicity of Ivanhoe’s—despite her virtue, she clearly isn’t properly rewarded—leaving England with her dignity intact allows the book to claim that ultimately, virtue is not only its own reward but the greatest inheritance a person can hope for.



THE VULNERABILITY AND POWER OF WOMEN

Near the middle of *Ivanhoe*, after having kidnapped Rowena with the intent to force her to marry him, Maurice de Bracy makes the surprising claim that he is Rowena’s prisoner, not the other way around. Likewise, after kidnapping Rebecca, Sir Brian repeatedly complains about his inability to resist her charms. Despite these claims of male helplessness, it is Rebecca and Rowena who are locked in tower rooms; they alone are vulnerable to violence and rape. They are pawns in the schemes of powerful men. Their shared plight suggests a very narrow range of opportunities for women in the world of *Ivanhoe*: dependent on men for protection, they can do little of importance on their own. But the novel actively subverts the idea of the elevated yet helpless damsel. Although it doesn’t give its women the same autonomy as its knights and princes (this would do violence to historical fact), the book nevertheless makes a powerful claim for the humanity and complexity of Rebecca, Rowena, and Ulrica.

Rowena is perhaps the least fleshed-out, but even she asserts her autonomy in her ongoing refusal to marry Athelstane, even against the wishes of her guardian Cedric. Ulrica, who initially seems almost completely victimized by her capture and rape at the hands of invading Normans, redeems and revenges herself by burning down Torquilstone and helping Cedric and his friends to escape. Rebecca is the book’s moral center and perhaps its most fully realized character. While acknowledging her beauty, the book places heavier emphasis on her medical skill and moral clarity. She most fully embodies the ethics of courage, steadfastness, humility, honesty, generosity, and faithfulness which the book’s Jewish and Christian characters espouse. She does not do this without struggle; she cannot fully tame her feelings for Ivanhoe, and she must draw on her inner resources for the courage necessary to face the possibility of being burned at the stake. By portraying her struggle, the book makes her a role model for all readers rather than an idealized caricature. And, because her power rises from her vulnerability as both a woman and a Jewish person, the book points to Rebecca as an example for all people—no matter their gender or beliefs—to live a humane, virtuous life.



HISTORY VS. ROMANCE

Ivanhoe begins with a “Dedicatory Epistle,” a letter written by its ostensible writer, Lawrence Templeton, to his friend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust. In it, Templeton suggests an opposition between “romance” or fiction and “history,” hinting that serious readers and thinkers will prefer the latter. Yet, ultimately, Templeton and the book itself argue for an amalgam between the two, claiming that one can—and, indeed, should—look to the past to understand the present. *Ivanhoe* was composed at a moment of political and social upheaval in England; it is not accidental, therefore, that

its medieval setting features political and social upheaval, too. By imagining its Saxon and Norman characters overcoming their differences and learning to live in harmony, the book hopefully suggests that the problems of its own day—and by extension, in the eras of all future readers down to the present day—can likewise be overcome.

In part, this faith in progress rests on the assertion that, no matter how distant in time, human beings are—and always have been, and always will be—human beings. Although habits, dress, and social customs differ across time and place, emotions like familial love, romantic love, the desire for respect, fear, anger, hatred, and more will remain the same. Even where Templeton intervenes to point out big differences between the past and the present—such as when witnesses present dubious evidence of Rebecca’s guilt on the charge of witchcraft—the actions of the characters in the story itself argue for greater continuity than division between past and present. The fact that Rebecca can see the racism and prejudice that animate the flimsy charges suggests the ability of any unprejudiced person, medieval or modern, to do the same—and indeed, Sir Brian also recognizes his peers’ “bigotry.” For this reason, the book supports Templeton’s assertion that a good historical romance uses its readers’ emotional involvement as a force for change and social progress. *Ivanhoe*’s unflinching portrayal of the antisemitism and violence Isaac and Rebecca face, for example, can make modern readers feel compassion for their fate; by extension, *Ivanhoe* claims, this compassion can be leveraged for progress in the modern world, too.

one day arise from the union of Normans and Saxons. The oak forms part of his project by linking the past to the present. By invoking it as a symbol of English identity, *Ivanhoe* continually reminds its original English readers of their rich history, and—importantly—of the ways their ancestors’ lives can show them how to live upright lives in the present and overcome strife and division wherever it rears its head.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin edition of *Ivanhoe* published in 2000.

Dedicatory Epistle Quotes

☞ What I have applied to language, is still more justly applicable to sentiments and manners. The passions, the sources from which these must spring in all their modifications, are generally the same in all ranks and conditions, all countries and ages; and it follows, as a matter of course, that the opinions, habits of thinking, and actions, however influenced by the particular state of society must still, upon the whole, bear a strong resemblance to each other. Our ancestors were not more distinct from us, surely, than Jews are from Christians; they had “eyes, hands, organs, dimensions, senses, affections, passions;” were “fed with the same food, hurt with the same weapons, subject to the same diseases, warmed and cooled by the same winter and summer” as ourselves. The tenor, therefore, of their affections and feelings must have borne the same general proportion to our own.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), Rebecca, Isaac, Reverend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 10

Explanation and Analysis

Ivanhoe begins with this letter, allegedly written by the book’s author, Lawrence Templeton, to his friend Dr. Dryasdust. The friend’s name clearly indicates that the fictional letter forms part of the novel itself. It allows Walter Scott, through the character of Templeton, to express some of his ideas about the value, benefits, and drawbacks to historical fiction, or in early 19th-century language, “historical romance.” This genre was, at the time, in its infancy, and Walter Scott’s work, including *Ivanhoe*, contributed greatly to an explosion of popularity and a subsequent reconsideration of the genre which took it much more seriously than before.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



OAK TREE

The oak tree in *Ivanhoe* symbolizes strength, resilience, freedom, and Englishness. Oppressed Saxons, including both the servants Wamba and Gurth and freemen like Locksley, the Cleric of Copmanhurst, and their compatriots, gather under or near oaks. Their connection to ancient druid practices links them to the deep prehistory of England, too. *Ivanhoe* hints at his English—and specifically Saxon—identity when in disguise as the Disinherited Knight, whose shield features an uprooted oak tree. The uprooted tree specifically suggests Cedric’s unfair act of disinheriting and disowning his son. It also points towards the political divisions and tensions the book dramatizes between the native (Saxon) English population and the Norman (French) ruling class that conquered the island in the late 11th century. Through Templeton’s dedicatory letter and frequent asides, the book anticipates the glorious future of the English people who will

In this passage, Templeton claims that more similarities than differences exist between the past and the present, especially when it comes to the way people think, feel, and behave. If this indeed the case, the Dedicatory Epistle goes on to argue, then the fictional part of historical fiction serves an important role in teaching people about the past because the compelling emotional dramas of a good story can generate much more empathy and interest than a dry, dusty history. In addition, a continuity of human emotion and experience allows people to gain insight about current issues when they look to the past. The years in which *Ivanhoe* was written and published, 1819-1820, were ones of considerable political upheaval in England, in which commoners agitated for better working conditions and an increased say in parliament. Against this backdrop, *Ivanhoe* presents the story of a divided England capably (if impermanently) unified by a strong and noble king.

Finally, in this passage, Templeton directly quotes William Shakespeare's play *The Merchant of Venice*, an important inspiration for *Ivanhoe*'s consideration of the antisemitism, prejudice, segregation, and violence Jewish people faced in medieval Europe and later. In this famous passage, Shakespeare's Jewish moneylender, Shylock, begs for mercy from a Christian court of law based on shared humanity, which he claims should matter more than his Jewish faith. In a way, this foreshadows the book's ongoing critique of its characters' prejudicial treatment of Isaac and Rebecca. But, by taking these famous lines out of their context and applying them to the English descendants of the Saxons and Normans who persecute Isaac and Rebecca throughout the story, the book also contributes to normalizing the mistreatment of Jewish people.

Volume 1, Chapter 1 Quotes

☛ “By St Dunstan,” answered Gurth, “thou speakest but sad truths; little is left to us but the air we breathe, and that appears to have been reserved with much hesitation, clearly for the purpose of enabling us to endure the tasks they lay upon our shoulders. The finest and fattest is for their board; the loveliest is for their couch; the best and bravest supply their foreign masters with soldiers, and whiten distant land with their bones, leaving few here who have either will or power to protect the unfortunate Saxon. God’s blessing on our master Cedric, he hath done the work of a man in standing in the gap; but Reginald Front-de-Boeuf is coming down to this country in person, and we shall soon see how little Cedric’s trouble will avail him.”

Related Characters: Gurth (speaker), King Richard (the

Black Knight), Cedric, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Wamba, Lawrence Templeton

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

The book opens with two of Cedric’s servants, Wamba and Gurth, ineffectually trying to herd Cedric’s pigs home through the forest. Their complaints, recorded in part in this passage, lay out the state of society in England in the 1190s: a minority of Norman colonizers who came to England from France a century before control the country, enriching themselves and oppressing the native (Saxon) population. When they came, the Normans brought their language, their customs and dress, and their ideas about the world, including the concept of “chivalry”—a set of social conventions ruling the behavior of knights in the Middle Ages. Chivalric ideals generally include generosity, protection of the weak and vulnerable, courage, Christian belief and support of Christians institutions and objectives, obedience to one’s leaders, and honoring one’s word. Yet, the alleged supporters of chivalric ideals, Norman nobles like Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, fail to follow these commandments, taking advantage of the weak, spurning their faith (Front-de-Boeuf will eventually die without receiving last rights), and selfishly taking advantage of the land and its bounty.

Gurth’s complaints also confirm the assertion Templeton makes earlier that this time saw almost complete division between Normans and Saxons—a division which the book will solve with the intervention of King Richard the Lionheart. In doing so, however, the book engages in a bit of historical revisionism. Yet, the Norman King Richard was himself guilty of, in Gurth’s poetic words, “whitening distant lands” with English bones; of his 10-year reign, he only spent about six months in England. The rest of the time, he was either on Crusade—a holy war with the purpose of seizing control of Palestine, the foundational seat of Christianity—or in Normandy (northern France) trying to solidify and expand his family’s land holdings there. But because he became a popular and mythologized figure in English history—due in part to his daring and gallant reputation as a knight—*Ivanhoe* follows other English myths (like Robin Hood) in burnishing Richard’s reputation so that he can serve as a symbol of English greatness.

Volume 1, Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ “I would soon have beat him into courtesy,” observed Brian; “I am accustomed to deal with such spirits: Our Turkish captives are as fierce and intractable as Odin himself could have been; yet two months in my household, under the management of my master of slaves, has made them humble, submissive, serviceable, and observant of your will. Marry, sir, you must beware of the poison and the dagger, for they use either with free will when you give them the slightest opportunity.”

“Aye, but,” answered Prior Aymer, “every land hath its own manners and fashions; and, besides that beating this fellow could procure us no information could respecting the road to Cedric’s house, it would have been sure to have established a quarrel betwixt you and him had we found our way thither.”

Related Characters: Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Prior Aymer (speaker), Cedric, Gurth, Wamba

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 29-30

Explanation and Analysis

After their encounter with Wamba and Gurth, Prior Aymer and Sir Brian ride on through the countryside, hoping to find a place to rest for the evening. The Norman Sir Brian expresses surprise at Gurth’s rudeness—either he’s been away for a long time, or he’s just arrived in England. This, Aymer assures him, is typical of the disgruntled Saxon populace.

In claiming that violent oppression is the best—and perhaps only—way to silence dissent, Sir Brian represents the abusive Norman lords who currently control England. His warning about poison and dagger suggests that an oppressed people may always find ways to rise up against their oppressors, and it foreshadows the Saxons’ uprisings and revolts later in the novel. And, by putting these harsh words into the mouth of a Templar knight—often the highest exemplars of chivalry in medieval tales—the book immediately points to one of its central questions: whether chivalry truly works as a social code or not.

Finally, this passage gives readers a clear image of Prior Aymer and the Templar. Aymer’s words show him to be observant and calculating; well aware of the tensions in the land, he refuses to do or say anything that might expose him to violence or danger—later, he will even deferentially speak with Cedric in Saxon instead of Norman. In addition to the tendency toward violence mentioned above, Sir Brian’s speech betrays a mean and arrogant man who values earthly power and wealth—the very idea of a monk

enslaving people suggests the depths of his corruption.

Volume 1, Chapter 5 Quotes

☞ While Isaac thus stood an outcast in the present society, like his people among the nations, looking in vain for welcome or resting place, the Pilgrim who sat by the chimney took compassion upon him, and resigned his seat, saying briefly, “Old man, my garments are dried, my hunger is appeased, thou art both wet and fasting.” So saying, he gathered together, and brought to a flame, the decaying brands which lay scattered on the ample hearth; took from the larger board a mess of pottage and seethed it, placed it upon the small table at which he himself had supped, and without waiting the Jew’s thanks, went to the other side of the hall;—whether from unwillingness to hold more close communication with the object of his benevolence, or from a wish to draw near to the upper end of the table, seemed uncertain.

Related Characters: Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Isaac, Cedric, Prior Aymer

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 48

Explanation and Analysis

In the great hall of Cedric the Saxon, visitors including Sir Brian, Prior Aymer, a mysterious Palmer (pilgrim) and a Jewish moneylender named Isaac gather to wait out a stormy night. This passage describes the cold reception Isaac receives. Medieval Christian theology and social custom discouraged Christians from mixing with Jewish people, whom Christianity cast as dangerous, deceitful, and devilish. They were at best tolerated and at worst subjected to individual and communal acts of violence and abuse. Thus, Sir Brian and Aymer don’t even want to share a room with Isaac. Cedric overrules them, more for the satisfaction he gets from opposing Norman wishes than from any real sense of generosity or hospitality—that he lets his household ignore Isaac with impunity makes this lacking generosity abundantly clear. Thus, first and foremost, the passage dramatizes the deep unwillingness of medieval Christians (Saxon and Norman alike) to socialize with Jewish people.

Only the Palmer—sitting by the fire because no one allowed him, a humble stranger rather than a celebrated Norman guest, to sit at the table—takes mercy on Isaac. And because the Palmer is really Ivanhoe in disguise, his act of kindness takes on deeper meaning in the context of the book’s debate

on the merits of chivalry. If the expectations of the good knight include generosity and showing concern for the weak and vulnerable, Ivanhoe has succeeded where Sir Brian failed. And, because the book highlights the animosity between Saxons and Normans, Ivanhoe doesn't just score a moral victory for true chivalry here, but one for Saxons, too. Yet, his generosity doesn't cross the line into friendship, reminding readers of the painful historical realities of life for medieval Jewish people.

Volume 1, Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ [T]here was no race existing on the earth, in the air, or the waters, who were the object of such unintermitting, general, and relentless persecution as the Jews of this period. Upon the slightest and most unreasonable pretences [...] or] absurd and groundless [accusations], their persons and property were exposed to every turn of popular fury; for Norman, Saxon, Dane, and Briton, however adverse these races were to each other, contended which should look with greatest detestation upon a people, whom it was accounted a point of religion to hate, to revile, to despise, to plunder, and to persecute. [...] It is a well-known story of King John that he confronted a wealthy Jew in one of the royal castles, and daily caused one of his teeth to be torn out, until, when the jaw of the unhappy Israelite was half disfurnished, he consented to pay a large sum, which was the tyrant's object to extort from him.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Rebecca, Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Isaac

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 61-62

Explanation and Analysis

Having overheard Sir Brian making plans to violently waylay Isaac, Ivanhoe (still disguised as the Palmer) helps Isaac escape Rotherwood safely. While he leads Isaac to the nearest town, Isaac's reflections on the dangers he faces transition into one of Lawrence Templeton's explanatory asides, in which he explains the situation of Jewish people in 12th-century England.

In its portrayal of Isaac and Rebecca, Ivanhoe does get many things right about the status of Jewish people in medieval Europe. They are clearly English natives (Rebecca speaks Saxon fluently, for instance), but people consistently treat them as outsiders or foreigners. For example, upon waking up in Rebecca's care, Ivanhoe has a hallucinatory sense that

he's back in Palestine. Thus, their status as lawful subjects remains insecure, subject to their currying favor with whoever will protect them in the moment. The story of the moneylender who faces torture at the hands of Prince John dramatizes this insecurity: he (and by implication, all other Jewish people) were only valued or protected insofar as someone powerful felt that they had something to gain from it. In fact, although *Ivanhoe* doesn't mention either event outright, two massive acts of violence against Jewish people clearly inform its narrative. A massacre of the sizeable Jewish community at York coincided with the coronation of King Richard I in 1189, only about five years before the events this story describes. And, in 1290, King Edward I would expel the entire Jewish population of England.

Volume 1, Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ The figure of Rebecca might indeed have compared with the proudest beauties of England. [...] Her form was exquisitely symmetrical, and was shewn to advantage by a sort of Eastern dress, which she wore according to the fashion of the females of her nation. Her turban of yellow silk suited well the darkness of her complexion. The brilliancy of her eyes, the superb arch of her eyebrows, her well-formed aquiline nose, her teeth as white as pearl and the profusion of her sable tresses[...]—all these constituted a combination of loveliness, which yielded not to the loveliest of the maidens who surrounded her. [...] The feather of an ostrich, fastened in her turban by an agraffe set with brilliants, was another distinction of the beautiful Jewess, scoffed and sneered at by the proud dames who sat above her, but secretly envied by those who affected to deride them.

Related Characters: Rebecca, Isaac, Cedric, Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Prince John, Rowena, Ulrica (Dame Urfried)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 71-72

Explanation and Analysis

On the opening day of the tournament at Ashby, Prince John catches sight of Rebecca sitting in the stands with her father, Isaac. Her beauty—which this passage describes in great detail—so captivates him that he tries to order Cedric, Athelstane, and their group to relinquish their better seats for the lovely young woman. First and foremost, it associates good looks (especially feminine beauty) with virtue. This sets up an economy in the book where the beautiful Rebecca and Rowena are as virtuous as the hideous Ulrica is complicit, guilty, and lascivious.

But emphasizing Rebecca's beauty makes readers into the

same kind of voyeurs as Prince John, a man who feels entitled to taking what he wants from the world. It reduces Rebecca, arguably *Ivanhoe*'s most fully realized and realistic character, to an object meant to please the powerful with its charm and allure. And it exoticizes Rebecca through her Jewishness. Rather than describing her as an English subject, this passage suggests her foreignness by comparing her directly to other (presumably more wholly) English beauties. This reinforces others' perception that she does not belong to her homeland. Considering her a stranger rather than a citizen has implications for the degree to which people will believe that English law and custom ought to protect her welfare. Further, in the context of the Crusades (a series of religiously motivated European wars of aggression aimed at conquering and colonizing Palestine), emphasizing Rebecca's exotic clothing and beauty aligns her with faraway lands. A desire to control her—disguised as appreciation—metaphorically suggests the violence and imperialist ambition of European crusaders.

Volume 1, Chapter 10 Quotes

☞☞ "Ay," answered Isaac, "but if the tyrant lays hold on them as he did to-day and compels me to smile while he is robbing me—O daughter, disinherited and wandering as we are, the worst evil that befalls our race is, that when we are wronged and plundered, all the world laughs around, and we are compelled to suppress our sense of injury and to smile tamely, when we should revenge bravely."

"Think not thus of it, my father," said Rebecca; "we also have advantages. These Gentiles, cruel and oppressive as they are, are in some sort dependent on the dispersed children of Zion, whom they despise and persecute. Without the aid of our wealth, they could neither furnish forth their hosts in war, nor their triumphs in peace; and the gold which we lend them returns with increase to our coffers."

Related Characters: Rebecca, Isaac (speaker), Cedric, Wamba, Prince John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

During the tournament's first day, an angered Prince John leered at Rebecca, insulted Isaac, and then stole his purse and gave its contents (50 gold coins) to Cedric's enslaved jester, Wamba. That night, Isaac complains at length about this abuse—and the general abuses to which broader

English society subjects Jewish people. John's actions, of course, point toward the corruption and self-serving actions that characterize the book's portrayal of Norman rule and the ill-suited prince's own corrupt government. But while Wamba's unexpected windfall hints at the ways in which the book's Saxon characters will find themselves restored and re-inherited in the end, this comes at Isaac's and Rebecca's expense.

Rebecca's reply indicates the difficult position of Jewish people in the Middle Ages, who were despised for the same reason they were tolerated: their utility as a quick source of cash for European princes and nobles. What's more, she suggests that her father's debtors have faced consequences for at least some of the abuse they've directed at Jewish people, since their interest payments enrich Isaac and Rebecca. But while this does allow Rebecca to claim power, it does so at the expense of leaning on antisemitic stereotypes about greedy Jewish moneylenders. While some medieval Jewish people did indeed work as moneylenders (and some even became rich), in general the figure of the Jewish usurer owes more to the racist narratives European aristocrats and Christian leaders created to justify their persecution of Jewish people. Rebecca's own actions—soon, she will return the repayment *Ivanhoe* sends to Isaac, even adding in some of her father's money as a gift—suggest reservations about the business of moneylending. Thus, as elsewhere, while the book casts its Jewish characters in a largely sympathetic light, it also reinforces the very stereotypes it criticizes.

Volume 1, Chapter 11 Quotes

☞☞ Meantime the clang of the blows, and the shouts of the combatants, mixed fearfully with the sound of the trumpets, and drowned the groans of those who fell, and lay rolling defenseless beneath the feet of the horses. The splendid armor of the combatants was now faced with dust and blood, and gave way at every stroke of the sword and battle-axe. The gay plumage, shorn from the crests, drifted upon the breeze like snow-flakes. All that was beautiful and graceful in the marital array had disappeared, and what was now visible was only calculated to awake terror or compassion.

Yet such is the force of habit, that not only the vulgar spectators, who are naturally attracted by sights of horror, but even the ladies who crowded the galleries, saw the conflict with thrilling interest certainly, but without a wish to withdraw their eyes from a sight so terrible.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Sir

Brian de Bois-Guilbert

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 112

Explanation and Analysis

The second day of the Ashby tournament features the “melee,” a general mock-battle of knights divided into two teams. This passage describes the violence with which these knights fight and the carnage that results. In doing so, *Ivanhoe* captures the very real violence and danger of medieval tournaments; although they were “games” and “diversions” as opposed to war, they were only slightly less dangerous.

First and foremost, then, this passage challenges the ideals of chivalry. It suggests an emptiness at the heart of the chivalric code, which uses pretty language, colorful costume, and high-minded ideals to provide cover for ultimately empty and destructive actions. Remember that Sir Brian, *Ivanhoe*, and others have just returned from the failed expedition of the Third Crusade. In an era where real wars were so costly and dangerous, the idea of soldiers potentially wasting their lives in tournaments—for the sole purpose of achieving fame and honor—calls into question whether chivalry encouraged upright behavior or simply licensed vanity.

This passage also describes the reactions of the crowd, which Templeton implies might shock modern readers—especially the bloodthirsty enthusiasm of the ladies in the audience. In the Dedicatory Epistle, he relates one of Dr. Dryasdust’s concerns about an English historical novel, namely that 19th-century British readers might reject any historical facts that show their ancestors in a poor light. The inclusion of these moments—some of which Templeton tries to excuse or explain away, others of which he lets stand on their own merits—flies in the face of this concern. Moreover, it contributes to the book’s subtle, socially conservative support for the British monarchy, suggesting that a certain bloody-mindedness is part of the national character that must be channeled into proper outlets, like participating in or watching a tournament.

Volume 1, Chapter 14 Quotes

☞ [I]t was the misfortune of this Prince, that his levity and petulance were perpetually breaking out, and undoing all that had been gained by his previous dissimulation.

Of this fickle temper he gave a memorable example in Ireland [...]. Upon this occasion, the Irish chieftains contended which should first offer to the young Prince their loyal homage and the kiss of peace. But, instead of receiving their salutations with courtesy, John and his petulant attendants could not resist the temptation of pulling the long beards of the Irish chieftains, a conduct which, as might have been expected, was highly resented by these insulted dignitaries, and produced fatal consequences to the English domination of Ireland.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Cedric, Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Prince John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

At the conclusion of the tournament’s second day, Prince John hosts a banquet to which he invites not just his Norman supporters and friends, but also important Saxon noblemen like Cedric and Athelstane. With reports that King Richard has returned to England, John cannot afford to alienate anyone if he wants to conduct his planned coup and seize the throne permanently. In this aside, Lawrence Templeton provides his 19th-century readers with important insights into the character of Prince John, adding context to the coming events. This description portrays John as an unprincipled, weak-willed man incapable of true leadership and inclined to vices like pettiness and insensitivity. By association, it implies that these same vices exist in almost all the unscrupulous and abusive Norman nobles who control England and oppress the Saxon population at this time.

This portrait of John contrasts sharply with the valorized descriptions of the gallant King Richard which come later in the book; for every one of John’s weaknesses, Richard has a corresponding strength that argues his personal superiority and clear claim on the throne. However, while it aligns with received opinions about John that were common through the 19th century, more modern historians have called into question descriptions of John as a weak and ineffective leader. These date back to 13th-century chronicles which tend to favor the gallant Richard; 19th-century historians judged John’s allegedly wicked character with acute

harshness. Modern 20th- and 21st-century assessments of John's reign consider him a hardworking if ineffective ruler, whose personality flaws did cause political trouble, though earlier accounts greatly exaggerated these personality flaws. But, because the book makes a strong argument about the importance of the monarchy and good leadership to national unity—and because King Richard was, in the common imagination, a much more popular and successful king than his brother—it depends on Richard to provide that leadership. And because it depends on Richard, it tends to overemphasize John's weaknesses and failures.

●● Cedric and Athelstane were both dressed in the ancient Saxon garb, which, although not unhandsome in itself [...] was so remote in shape and appearance from that of the other guests, that Prince John took great credit to himself [...] for refraining from laughter. [...] Yet, in the eye of sober judgement, that short close tunic and long mantle of the Saxons was a more graceful, as well as a more convenient dress, than the garb of the Normans, whose under garment was a long doublet, so loose as to resemble a shirt or waggoner's frock, covered by a cloak of scanty dimensions, neither fit to defend the wearer from cold or from rain, and the only purpose of which seemed to be to display as much fur, embroidery, and jewellery work, as the ingenuity of the tailor could contrive to lay upon it.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), Cedric, Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Prince John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

Cedric and Athelstane attend Prince John's post-tournament feast in self-consciously Saxon clothing, in line with their public commitment to the restoration of Saxon rule. Indeed, friends and enemies alike know Cedric as "Cedric the Saxon" for his political beliefs. John's barely repressed laughter continues the theme raised shortly before this passage by Templeton about his weakness of character and lack of suitability for rule. But this aside mostly gives Lawrence Templeton, in an editorializing aside, an opportunity to explain why *he* believes *Norman* fashion to be the more ridiculous.

Thus, as always, Templeton sides with the Saxons, highlighting the injustice of their oppression by describing the apparent superiority of their customs. In this view of history, the Saxons (who themselves derive from an earlier wave of fifth-century invaders) are simple, direct, and manly.

In contrast, their Norman counterparts care more about displaying wealth and position through fashion rather than proving one's mettle and worth directly (say, on the battlefield). In this way, *Ivanhoe* slowly builds up a claim that 19th-century England's superiority grows from an identifiably Saxon strain of culture that lends resilience and practicality to the national character.

Volume 2, Chapter 1 Quotes

●● No spider ever took more pains to repair the shattered meshes of his web, than did Waldemar Fitzurse to reunite and combine the scattered members of Prince John's cabal. Few of these were attached to him from inclination, and none from personal attachment. It was therefore necessary [...] to open to them new prospects of advantage, and remind them of those which they presently enjoyed. To the young and wild nobles, he held out the prospect of unpunished license and uncontrolled revelry; to the ambitions, that of power, and to the covetous, that of increased wealth and extended domains. The leaders of the mercenaries received a donation in gold; an argument most persuasive to their minds, and without which all others would have proved in vain. Promises were still more liberally distributed than money by this active agent; [...] nothing was left undone that could determine the wavering, or animate the disheartened.

Related Characters: King Richard (the Black Knight), Cedric, Waldemar Fitzurse, Prince John

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 133

Explanation and Analysis

Prince John's post-tournament banquet ends in disaster when Cedric drinks to the health of the absent King Richard and the collective confusion in the hall shows John that his so-called supporters may still harbor secret (or suppressed) preferences for his brother. This bodes ill for his plans to steal the throne permanently, thus necessitating the machinations which Waldemar Fitzurse, his primary counselor, undertakes in this passage. Disguise and dissimulation provide the means for John to stay in power; he betrays his true weakness in his attempt to cater to everyone's individual desires.

No one has a good reason for supporting the weak, ineffective, immoral, and untrustworthy Prince John. Therefore, the catalogue of reasons the nobles have for continuing to support him suggest the general lawlessness of the Norman ruling class, as well as listing its primary sins:

shamelessness, ambition, and the love of power, wealth, and domination. The generally vicious character of the Norman this passage paints suggests that the Normans may in fact use their stated chivalric values not as a tool for living a good life but as a smokescreen to cover up their sins. But in catering to his Norman friends at the expense of their Saxon subjects, John contributes to his low popularity and inadvertently opens the door for Richard's triumphant return.

Volume 2, Chapter 2 Quotes

☛☛ Beside this fountain were the ruins of a very small chapel, of which the roof had partly fallen in. [...] The ribs of two of these arches remained, though the roof had fallen down betwixt them; over the others it remained entire. The entrance to this ancient place of devotion was under a very low round arch, ornamented by several courses of that zig-zag moulding, resembling shark's teeth, which appears so often in the more ancient Saxon churches. A belfry rose above the porch on four small pillars, within which hung the green and weather-beaten bell [...].

The whole peaceful and quiet scene lay glimmering in twilight before the eyes of the traveller, giving him good assurance of lodging for the night; since it was a special duty of those hermits who dwelt in the woods to exercise hospitality toward benighted or bewildered passengers.

Related Characters: King Richard (the Black Knight), Cleric of Copmanhurst

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

After the tournament at Ashby, the Black Knight rides through the forest in search of adventure. Exhausted and starving, he eventually stumbles on a little chapel in a small clearing, which this passage describes in part. The Black Knight closely embodies the ideal of the chivalric knight-errant, in keeping with what the book tells readers (and which history mostly confirms) about King Richard's love of travel, adventure, and challenge. The episode in which he meets the Cleric of Copmanhurst seems to derive from a Middle English narrative poem (dating to the late Middle Ages), and that source material seems to imbue this passage with the flavor of a medieval romance, in which wandering knights frequently take shelter in isolated chapels.

In the world of *Ivanhoe*, however, the realistic description of

the chapel's disrepair suggests Norman overlords' mishandling of land and resources. Later, Richard will make it clear that this forest is a royal wood—meaning someone should thus be protecting and maintaining it for his benefit. Yet no one is. Additionally, by pointing out the allegedly Saxon elements of the chapel's decoration (notably, the book is incorrect on this point), the chapel's state of disrepair metaphorically suggests the oppression and abuse the Saxons suffered at the hands of the Normans. So, when King Richard (still disguised as the Black Knight) enters this chapel and befriends the Cleric—not just a Saxon, but a Saxon guilty of poaching on the king's land—their friendship will foreshadow the peaceful restoration of order at the book's conclusion and look forward to the glorious day when English identity will include the best that the Normans and the Saxons each have to offer.

Volume 2, Chapter 3 Quotes

☛☛ Joy to the fair! whose constant knight
Her favour fired to feats of might;
Unnoted shall she not remain
Where meet the bright and noble train;
Minstrel shall sing and herald tell—
'Mark yonder maid of beauty well,
'Tis she for whose bright eyes was won
The listed field at Ascalon!

'Note well her smile!—it edged the blade
Which fifty wives to widows made,
When, vain his strength and Mahound's spell,
Iconium's turban'd soldan fell.
See'st thou her locks, whose sunny glow
Half shows, half shades, her neck of snow?
Twines not of them one golden thread,
But for its sake a Paynim bled.'

Joy to the fair!—my name unknown,
Each deed, and all its praise, thine own;
Then, oh! Unbar this churlish gate,
The night-dew falls, the hour is late,
Inured to Syria's glowing breath,
I feel the north breeze chill as death;
Let grateful love quell maiden shame,
And grant him bliss who brings thee fame.

Related Characters: King Richard (the Black Knight) (speaker), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Rowena, Cleric of Copmanhurst

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 149-150

Explanation and Analysis

While King Richard (still disguised as the Black Knight) enjoys the Cleric of Copmanhurst's hospitality, they drink and begin to trade songs. The Cleric demands a Saxon ballad rather than a French *lai* or *verelai*, and the Black Knight offers the song, quoted in part in this passage, in response. Notably Richard's fluency in Saxon (widely emphasized in the book, but contrary to historical fact) shows him to be a friend to all his subjects, Saxon and Norman alike. Moreover, the fact that he learned it from a Saxon crusader and that it features a penniless (perhaps disinherited) knight who still hopes to win the love his lady suggests that the Black Knight may be telling part of Ivanhoe's story.

This song depicts many elements of courtly love, a stylized expression of romance popular in the Middle Ages and strongly associated with ideas about chivalry. It thus contributes a flavor of medieval romance to this 19th-century novel. It also illustrates the paradoxical power and vulnerability of women in the courtly and chivalric imagination. In courtly love, a man (usually a knight) falls in love with his lady to the extent that he will do anything for her; the literature of courtly love often casts the lady in the role of feudal lord or master and the knight in the role of willing vassal. The knight earns the right to claim her love by proving his own personal worth, often through warfare and occasionally through impossible quests which she assigns him. Then, once he's earned her love in return, he claims his right to take her as his lover, whether or not they are married. The song's final lines call on the lady to cast away any protectiveness she feels over her virginity and sexually reward the man who has worked so hard for her love. This final reversal, in which the knight all but demands sexual satisfaction from a woman whom he otherwise claims to have total power over him suggests that, although courtly love superficially granted ladies great power, gendered expectations greatly limited women's autonomy, nonetheless.

Volume 2, Chapter 5 Quotes

☞ Both the Saxon chiefs were made prisoners at the same moment, and each under circumstances expressive of his character. Cedric, the instant that an enemy appeared, launched at him his remaining javelin, which, taking better effect than that which he had hurled at Fangs, nailed the man against an oak-tree that happened to be close behind him. Thus far successful, Cedric spurred his horse against a second, drawing his sword at the same time, and striking with such inconsiderate fury, that his weapon encountered a thick branch which hung over him, and he was disarmed by the violence of his own blow. He was instantly made prisoner, and pulled from his horse by two or three of the banditti who crowded around him. Athelstane shared his captivity, his bridle having been sized, and he himself forcibly dismounted, long before he could draw his weapon, or assume any posture of effectual defense.

Related Characters: Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Cedric, Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Maurice de Bracy, Rowena

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 162

Explanation and Analysis

While Cedric, Athelstane, Rowena, and their attendants travel home after the tournament at Ashby, Maurice de Bracy, Sir Brian, and other Normans dressed as Saxon woodsmen-robbers ambush and capture them. De Bracy, taken with Rowena's beauty and wealth, wants to force her into marriage, and the very fact that he makes this plan to advance his interests points toward the abusive and unchivalrous nature of the Norman ruling class. This passage describes part of the ambush.

In the tradition of a realistic novel, which aims to portray characters in a detailed and true-to-life way, it uses the battle to characterize Athelstane and Cedric. Cedric's enthusiasm sometimes leads him astray. In contrast, Athelstane's evident disinterest in risking his life (or even defending himself) suggests that he would make an even worse ruler than the universally reviled Prince John, who at least finds impetus for action in his own self-interest. If Athelstane can't protect himself, the novel suggests, there's no way he can protect the interests of his people.

The Normans capture the pair under an oak tree, which symbolizes Englishness (and, by implication, Saxon identity, since the Saxons were well established in England long before the Norman Conquest). When Cedric's attack ends up getting stuck on the tree, this metaphorically suggests

that his narrow-minded insistence on a certain type of Saxon restoration—namely, uniting the Saxon parties with the marriage of Rowena and Athelstane, then installing Athelstane on the throne—limits rather than enables their opportunities for restoration. Excessive devotion to this idea led Cedric to disinherit his son, Ivanhoe, for embracing Norman styles and joining the court of Norman King Richard, even though Ivanhoe's actions do more to restore Saxon interest than Cedric's. Thus, this passage criticizes Cedric's shortsightedness and lays the groundwork for the compromise and forgiveness it highlights in its conclusion.

Volume 2, Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ “By the mass, thou meanest the fair Jewess,” said De Bracy. “And if I do,” said Bois-Guilbert, “who shall gainsay me?”

“No one that I know,” said De Bracy, “unless it be your vow of celibacy, or a check of conscience for an intrigue with a Jewess.”

“For my vow,” said the Templar, “our grand master hath granted me a dispensation. And for my conscience, a man that has slain three hundred Saracens, need not reckon up every little failing[...].”

“Thou knowest best thine own privileges,” said De Bracy. “Yet, I would have sworn thy thought had been more on the old usurer’s money bags [...].”

“I can admire both,” answered the Templar; “besides, the old Jew is but half prize. [...] I must have something that I can term exclusively my own by this foray of ours, and I have fixed on the lovely Jewess as my peculiar prize.”

Related Characters: Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Maurice de Bracy (speaker), Rebecca, Isaac, Rowena

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 172-173

Explanation and Analysis

After kidnapping Rowena and her friends, Maurice de Bracy fears that Sir Brian might try to seduce (or worse, rape) his prize, and he insists on accompanying the group all the way to Torquilstone before changing out of his disguise. In response, Sir Brian declares his interest in Rebecca, not Rowena, much to de Bracy's surprise.

First and foremost, this passage points towards the villainy, violence and selfishness that animate Sir Brian. In theory, Templar knights and other monastic-chivalric orders represented the pinnacle of chivalry. These warrior-monks

took traditional religious vows of poverty, chastity, and obedience, as well as taking on responsibility for dangerous and difficult tasks like maintaining the European claim on Jerusalem and other parts of Palestine between the Crusades and protecting travelers to Palestine. Sir Brian not only fails to live up to these ideals, but he also openly mocks them, suggesting that his position in the Order—which by the 12th century had become quite wealthy and powerful—places him above the need to worry about sin. He lies (or at the very least is disastrously mistaken) when he claims that the Order's Grand Master will look the other way on a few minor sexual sins—Lucas de Beaumanoir will later demand grave consequences for Sir Brian's actions.

Sir Brian's desire for a Jewish woman, despite the book's clear depiction of general antisemitic sentiment, provides more evidence of his bad character. Despite allegedly being bound to protect the weak and helpless, he chooses to prey on Rebecca specifically because she is the least protected and most helpless member of the party, vulnerable to violence both as a woman and because few people (if any) care to stand up against mistreatment of Jewish people. There's also a potential alignment between Sir Brian's desire to rape Rebecca and his goal—as a Templar Crusader—to claim and control Palestine for European rulers. In both cases, a foreign and exotic prize animates the knight's ambition and lust. And in both cases, he shows a marked disregard for the humanity of his victims, whether they are individual Jewish Englishwomen or hundreds of Muslim soldiers at a time.

☞ “It may be so [...] but I cannot look on that stained lattice without its awakening other reflections than those which concern the passing moment, or its privations. When that window was wrought, my dear friend, our hardy fathers knew not the art of making glass, or of staining it—The pride of Wolfgang's father brought an artist from Normandy to adorn his hall with this new species of emblazonment, that breaks the golden light of God's blessed day into so many fantastic hues. The foreigner came here, poor, beggarly, cringing, and subservient, ready to doff his cap to the meanest native of the household. He returned pampered and proud, to tell his rapacious countrymen of the wealth and the simplicity of the Saxon noble—a folly, oh Athelstane, foreboded of old, as well as foreseen, by those descendants of Hengist and his hardy tribes who retained the simplicity of their manners.

Related Characters: Cedric (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Maurice

de Bracy, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Prince John

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 176-177

Explanation and Analysis

Upon their capture by Maurice de Bracy and his alleged posse of bandits, Cedric, Athelstane, and their attendants find themselves imprisoned in Torquilstone. Torquilstone, once the estate of a Saxon thane, came into Norman control after the Conquest. King Richard's granting it to Ivanhoe contributed to Ivanhoe's breach with his father Cedric, who felt offended by the idea of a Norman king "giving" lands to a Saxon that belonged to him by birthright. And then, in Richard's and Ivanhoe's absence, Prince John seized the castle and gave it to one of his own cronies, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf. The castle itself thus becomes a tortured site of debate about the rights of Saxons and Normans to lay claim to land and rule England.

In his typical fashion, Cedric regards the conflict as a zero-sum fight between Normans and Saxons—with the Normans currently in ascendancy, he can only imagine replacing their entire ruling class with Saxons. Thus, he traces the downfall of his Saxon ancestors not to the Norman Conquest in 1066, but further back yet, to the moment when they compromised their culture by admitting Norman elements. Casting the Saxons as practical and strong and the Normans as pretentious and weak, Cedric even comes close to suggesting that Norman stained-glass windows offend God by breaking up the inherently perfect, clear light of day.

Yet, looking forward through history to the eventual blending of Normans and Saxons into one English identity, the book eventually rejects this worldview. The ridiculousness of Cedric's rant against stained glass windows humorously suggests that no matter how much the novel prefers Saxons and their ideals to Normans, it recognizes the impossibility of returning to some imagined, glorious Saxon past. Instead, it suggests a compromise and partnership, like the one Ivanhoe and Richard's friendship represents, as the only way to achieve a truly powerful and glorious English identity.

Volume 2, Chapter 9 Quotes

☞☞ "Alas! fair Rowena," returned De Bracy, "you are in the presence of your captive, not your jailor, and it is from your fair eyes that De Bracy must receive that doom which you fondly expect from him."

"I know you not, sir," said the lady, drawing herself up with all the pride of offended rank and beauty; "I know you not—and the insolent familiarity with which you apply to me the jargon of a troubadour, forms no apology for the violence of a robber."

"To thyself, fair maid [...] to thine own charms be ascribed what'er I have done which passed the respect due to her, whom I have chosen as queen of my heart and loadstar of my eyes."

"I repeat to you, Sir Knight, that I know you not, and that no man wearing chain and spurs ought thus to intrude himself upon the presence of an unprotected lady."

Related Characters: Maurice de Bracy, Rowena (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 187-188

Explanation and Analysis

After kidnapping Rowena and her friends and imprisoning them at the castle of Torquilstone, Maurice de Bracy changes from his robber's disguise into the foppish clothing of a Norman knight before going to woo Rowena. In this passage, he protests his love in words that draw from the courtly love traditions of medieval Europe. Although this tradition became common in European literature and lyric, many of its best examples come from medieval French romances and poetry. Rowena alludes to this history when she chides de Bracy for addressing her in the flowery language of a

"troubadour," using it to insult the group of warrior-poets whose late 11th-century poetry kicked off a renaissance of love lyric and a growing interest in refined ways of loving.

Moving aside from general considerations of courtly love as a marker of Norman identity (thus, Rowena rejects it), it's important to note that courtly love cast women into a doubled position. On the one hand, it elevated them to the position of seeming power over their lovers, who proclaimed themselves indebted to their ladies' wishes. De Bracy borrows from this motif when he insists that he is the captive and Rowena is the jailor. But, since medieval society generally limited female power and autonomy, knights could deploy these protestations of feminine power to provide cover over or distraction from male control. No matter what power Rowena holds over de Bracy's heart, he holds the

literal keys—and metaphorically putting her in charge does nothing to change that reality. Moreover, Rowena seizes on the opportunity to point out the ways in which de Bracy uses the languages and conventions of chivalry and courtly love to cover up his bad behavior. A true knight, she claims, would never capture a lady in this way. She thus points out how he abuses power and chivalry in a way the book casts as typical of the Norman ruling class.

Volume 2, Chapter 15 Quotes

☞ “Glory?” continued Rebecca; “alas, it is the rusted mail which hangs as a hatchment over the champion’s dim and mouldering tomb—is the defaced sculpture of the inscription with which the ignorant monk can hardly read to the inquiring pilgrim—are these sufficient rewards for the sacrifice of every kindly affection, for a life spent miserably that ye make others miserable? Or is there such virtue in the rude rhymes of a wandering bard, that domestic love, kindly affection, peace and happiness are so wildly bartered, to become the hero of these ballads which vagabond minstrels sing to drunken churls over their evening ale?”

[...] “Thou speakest, maiden of thou knowest not what. Thou wouldst quench the pure light of chivalry, which alone distinguishes the noble from the base, the gentle knight from the churl and the savage; which rates our life far, far beneath the pitch of our honor [...].”

Related Characters: Rebecca, Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight) (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Cedric, Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer), Maurice de Bracy, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Rowena, Cleric of Copmanhurst

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 249

Explanation and Analysis

In Torquilstone, Rebecca tends to Ivanhoe’s wounds as a troupe of Saxon peasants and woodsmen, led by the Black Knight, Locksley, and Cedric, storm the castle to rescue the remaining captives. She stands near a window and reports on the fighting to the bedridden Ivanhoe, and she wonders aloud at how excited the thought of battle makes him, despite his recently having nearly died of his wounds in the tournament. This passage records part of their debate about the nature and value of chivalry.

Until this moment, the debate about the value of chivalry

has played out in the actions of individual men. Sometimes, these actions argue in favor of chivalry (like when Ivanhoe successfully defeats Sir Brian and scores an important symbolic victory for the Saxon cause). At other times, the use of chivalric or courtly language to cover up and excuse crimes and abuses (like when Sir Brian and Maurice de Bracy kidnap Rebecca and Rowena with rapacious intent), suggests that chivalry mainly serves to give violent and ambitious actions the mere *appearance* of respectability. But now, Rebecca directly questions Ivanhoe, pressing him to clearly define chivalry and its importance. She points out chivalry’s inherent violence and the vanity which leads some men to great deeds in the hope of lasting fame.

To a certain extent, Rebecca makes a hollow argument (deliberately exaggerating something to argue against it) when she opposes familial life and chivalric adventure. But Ivanhoe doesn’t actually answer Rebecca’s question, either, rejecting it when he turns to simply reciting the virtues and values of the true knight. Later, when she continues to press him, he will claim that it’s chivalry a religious issue she’ll never understand because she is Jewish, not Christian. Although Ivanhoe’s own actions (and those of Richard) generally contribute to showing chivalry in a positive light, his inability to defend it on rational grounds suggests chivalry’s limitations as an organizing principle of life.

Volume 3, Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ At this moment the door of the apartment flew open, and the Templar presented himself [...]. “I have found thee,” he said to Rebecca; “thou shalt prove I will keep my word to share weal and woe with thee—There is but one path to safety [...] up, and instantly follow me.”

“Alone,” answered Rebecca, “I will not follow thee [...]—save my aged father—save this wounded knight.”

“A knight,” answered the Templar [...], “a knight [...] must encounter his fate [...], and who recks how or where a Jew meets with his?”

“Savage warrior,” replied Rebecca, “rather will I perish in the flames than accept safety from thee!”

“Thou shalt not chuse, Rebecca—once didst thou foil me, but never mortal did so twice.”

So saying, he seized on the terrified maiden, who filled the air with her shrieks, and bore her out of the room in his arms [...].

Related Characters: Rebecca, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert (speaker), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Isaac

Related Themes:



Page Number: 265-266

Explanation and Analysis

In the heat of the battle for Torquilstone, Sir Brian abandons his defensive position along the wall and prepares to escape with Rebecca. He finds her in the room where she has been tending to Ivanhoe and he carries her away over her objections. Although the language he uses here recalls marriage vows—promising to stand by her in weal (happiness) and woe—he earlier made it clear that he has no intention of marrying her, since this would constitute an unforgiveable breach of his monastic vows as a Templar knight. Yet, his words show how deeply Rebecca's fortitude and character have impressed him; in the space of a few short hours, he's moved from a simple desire to rape her to imagining a lifetime together.

But Sir Brian's actions belie his words in this moment. They also illustrate the hollowness and insufficient power of socially constructed value systems such as courtly love and chivalry to constrain or direct people's actions. On the one hand, Sir Brian declares himself entirely in Rebecca's power; on the other hand, he physically picks her up against her wishes and kidnaps her. She even appeals to his alleged chivalric virtues when she asks him to save Ivanhoe and her father, Isaac—by definition the kind of helpless and weak individuals good knights allegedly protect. But Sir Brian not only refuses but also insults Ivanhoe and Isaac, demonstrating how little regard he has for Rebecca and her own values.

Still, despite her inability to defend herself from Sir Brian, Rebecca continues to show the bravery and fortitude that arguably make her the book's moral center. Her vulnerability—as a woman, as a Jewish person, and as a captive—only highlights her strength. In a way, her actions argue for the values of chivalry—specifically, bravery and fortitude—even if the book overall refuses to settle the debate over chivalry's merit. By staying true to her beliefs and refusing to bow to her oppressors, Rebecca—more than perhaps anyone else—demonstrates what a truly strong English subject can look like.

Volume 3, Chapter 3 Quotes

“O, assuredly,” said Isaac. “I have trafficked with the good fathers, and bought wheat and barley, and fruits of the earth, and also much wool. O, it is a rich abbey-stede, and they do live up on the fat, and drink the sweet wine upon the lees, these good fathers of Jorvaulx. Ah, if an out-cast like me had such a home to go to, and such incomings by the year and by the term, I would pay much gold and silver to redeem my captivity.”

“Hound of a Jew!” exclaimed the Prior, “no one knows better than thy own cursed self, that our holy house of God is indebted for the finishing of our chance!”—

“And for the storing of your cellars in the last season with the due allowance of Gascon wine,” interrupted the Jew; “but it is small matters.”

Related Characters: Isaac, Prior Aymer (speaker), Cedric, Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer), Allan-a-Dale

Related Themes:



Page Number: 285

Explanation and Analysis

After the siege of Torquilstone, the Cleric of Copmanhurst rescues Isaac and takes him into custody, threatening to kill him if he doesn't convert to Christianity. Locksley declares that Isaac can go free if he pays a ransom. When Allan-a-Dale arrives with Prior Aymer in tow (whom the woodsmen caught returning home after spending the night in bed with a beautiful noblewoman), Locksley declares that Isaac and Aymer should each set the other's ransom. In this passage, Isaac carefully considers the amount of money Aymer will willingly pay to get back to his comfortable home.

Isaac describes the wealth and worldly comforts Prior Aymer and his fellow monks enjoy at Jorvaulx. Traditionally, many medieval convents and monasteries maintained gardens, fields, and livestock operations to finance their operations and to provide food and other necessary items (such as sheepskin for the parchment used to make books). Jorvaulx is a Cistercian foundation; the Cistercian Order, founded in France at the end of the 11th century, explicitly rejected what its founders saw as an excessive use and stockpiling of wealth among other religious orders, including the Benedictines.

In this passage, Isaac's words recall examples of medieval anticlerical sentiment that charge priests, monks, and other religious figures of using their position and faux spirituality to cover up their own sinfulness. Isaac's complaints relate to the book's depiction of Norman abuses of power and other excesses. Notably, the book levels no such accusations

against the Saxon convent of St. Withold. Although the abbot there offers Athelstane and Cedric good ale, this indulgence pales in comparison with Aymer's expensive imported wine.

Notably, here as elsewhere in the book, Isaac peppers his words liberally with phrases and language pulled from the Hebrew Bible—in this case, the “fat” and “sweet wine” the monks enjoy comes from Isaiah 25:6, which describes the good thing with which God will reward those who are faithful to him. However, Isaac insinuates, Aymer and his cronies will not be included in this group.

☞ “Nay, beshrew thee, man, up with thee! I am English-born, and love no such eastern prostrations—Kneel to God, and not to a poor sinner like me.”

“Ay, Jew,” said Prior Aymer, “kneel to God, as represented in the servant of his later, and who knoweth, with thy sincere repentance and due gifts to the shrine of Saint Robert, what grace thou mayest acquire for thyself and thy daughter Rebecca? I grieve for the maiden, for she is [beautiful...]. Also Brian de Bois-Guilbert is one with whom I may do much—bethink thee how thou canst deserve my good word with him.”

“Alas! alas!” said the Jew, “on every hand the spoilers arise against me [...].”

“And what else should be the lot of an accursed race?” answered the Prior; “for what saith holy writ [...]—I will give their women to strangers [...] and their treasures to others.”

Related Characters: Isaac, Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer), Prior Aymer (speaker), Rebecca, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 288

Explanation and Analysis

While in the woods with Locksley and his bandits, Isaac learns that Rebecca did not perish when Torquilstone burned but that Sir Brian carried her from the castle. Relieved that she's alive but worried about what Sir Brian intends to do with her, he pleads with Locksley for help. The reactions of Locksley and Aymer provide further examples of the virulent and widespread antisemitism Isaac and Rebecca face, but they also relate to themes of Norman abuse of power and the nature of English identity.

Interestingly, Locksley rejects Isaac's reverential posture as

an eastern innovation, associating what the book clearly casts as a Jewish posture of reverence with foreignness. Yet, the book repeatedly suggests that both Isaac and Rebecca are natives of England; their religious identity and cultural heritage do not inherently make them different to their fellow subjects. Only racial prejudices insist that they are not just different but alien.

If Locksley humbly protests the limitations of his earthly authority, Aymer feels no such compunction. Yet again, the reactions of a Saxon and a Norman in the same situation dramatize the differences between the two groups and add dimension to the book's initial claims about Norman arrogance, pride, and dominance. Notably, in terms of negative Norman character flaws, Aymer only quotes scripture here, attempting to bully Isaac into forgiving his debt. This suggests that he doesn't so much believe the tenets of the faith he professes as consider them useful tools for empowering himself.

Volume 3, Chapter 9 Quotes

☞ “Thus,” said Rebecca, “do men throw on fate the issue of their own wild passions. But I do forgive thee, Bois-Guilbert, though the author of my early death. There are noble things which cross over they powerful mind; but it is the garden of the sluggard, and the weeds have rushed up, and conspired to choak the fair and wholesome blossom.”

“Yet,” said the Templar, “I am, Rebecca, as thou hast spoken me, untaught, untamed—and proud, that, amidst a shoal of empty fools and crafty bigots, I have retained the pre-eminent fortitude that places me above them. I have been a child of battle from youth upward, high in my views, steady and inflexible in pursuing them. Such must I remain—proud, inflexible, and unchanging; and of this the world shall have proof.—But thou forgivest me, Rebecca?”

“As freely as ever victim forgave her executioner.”

Related Characters: Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert (speaker), Rebecca

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 345

Explanation and Analysis

On the eve of the judicial combat which will determine if Rebecca will be burned at the stake as a witch or not, her captor, Sir Brian, makes one final appeal to her to run away with him. Rebecca has come into this danger through Sir Brian's actions; he kidnapped her with the intent to rape

her, then he became infatuated with her when he realized the depths of her resilience and courage. This led him to kidnap her and attempt to hide her in the Templar preceptory, where he seems intent on keeping her as his perpetual mistress, which both goes against his vow of chastity and his Order's enmity against Jewish people based on religious and social prejudices. Still, despite all these wrongs committed against her, Rebecca demonstrates righteousness and forgiveness—key virtues in both the Jewish and Christian traditions.

In the end, as Rebecca perceptively realizes here, Sir Brian's beliefs are too shallow to support him through adversity. In one second, he claims that he's proud, inflexible, impervious; in the next, he begs Rebecca to forgive him for causing her death through his own sins and no fault of her own. Unable to choose between his feelings for her and his worldly ambition, he hoped to have the best of both worlds. In contrast, Rebecca willingly chooses death—even a painful and humiliating public execution—over compromising her values and giving in to Sir Brian's courtship.

Rebecca's comparison of his mind to a poorly maintained garden alludes to a verse from the Hebrew Bible (Proverbs 24:30-31) and suggests the key limitation of chivalry: no matter how lovely or high minded a person's ideals are, they are only as good in practice as that person is. Brian has good qualities, but his inability to control his passions or stick to his beliefs turns him into a bad man.

Volume 3, Chapter 11 Quotes

☛☛ “And Richard Plantagenet,” said the King, desires no more fame than his good lance and sword may acquire him—and Richard Plantagenet is prouder of achieving an adventure, with only his good sword, and his good arm to speed, than if he led to battle a host of an hundred thousand armed men.”

“But your kingdom, my lord,” said Ivanhoe, “your kingdom is threatened with dissolution and civil war—your subjects menaced by every species of evil, if deprived of their sovereign in some of these dangers which it is your daily pleasure to incur, and from which you have but this moment narrowly escaped.”

Related Characters: King Richard (the Black Knight), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight) (speaker), Athelstane of Coningsburgh, Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer), Waldemar Fitzurse, Wamba

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 364

Explanation and Analysis

Having rescued Ivanhoe from Torquilstone, King Richard deposits him at a convent to recover, then he rides with Wamba toward Coningsburgh for Athelstane's funeral. When Waldemar Fitzurse mounts an assassination attempt against him, Richard narrowly escapes thanks to Wamba's quick thinking and Locksley's help. Soon afterward, Ivanhoe arrives on the scene, dismayed to hear of the adventure and how close King Richard came to death.

The dangers King Richard faces in the forest remind readers that despite the principled nature of chivalric ideals, being a knight still involves a lot of danger. And Richard's chivalric spirit compromises his reign. Unsatisfied with being king, he wants adventure and renown, and so he risks his life—and the welfare of his people—to get them. Richard's participation in the Third Crusade demonstrates this both in the terms of the book and in historical fact—the campaign and his subsequent imprisonment subjected England to dangerous political instability and nearly cost the king his own life at several points.

Moreover, Ivanhoe has risked everything in following King Richard, from his father's love to his rightful property to his own life. He makes an eloquent case here that the king owes it to him (and his other followers and subjects) to place their interests above his own. In a roundabout way, Ivanhoe makes a chivalric argument for King Richard abandoning (or at least stepping back from) adventurous questing by highlighting the need of the most vulnerable subjects for the protection of a strong and present ruler.

☛☛ Novelty in society and in adventure was the zest of life to Richard Coeur de Lion, and it had its highest relish when enhanced by dangers encountered and surmounted. In the lion-hearted King, the brilliant, but useless character, of a knight of romance, was in great measure realized; and the personal glory which he acquired by his own deeds of arms, was far more dear to his excited imagination than that which a course of policy and wisdom would have spread around his government. Accordingly, his reign was like the course of a brilliant and rapid meteor [...]; his feats of chivalry furnishing themes for bards and minstrels, but affording none of those solid benefits to his country on which history loves to pause [...]. But in his present company Richard shewed to the greatest imaginable advantage. He was gay, good-humored, liberal, and fond of manhood in every rank of life.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer,

the Disinherited Knight), Locksley/Robin Hood (The Yeoman Archer), Waldemar Fitzurse

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 365

Explanation and Analysis

After Locksley and his merry men save King Richard from Waldemar Fitzurse's ambush, Richard reveals his identity and joins the woodsmen-bandits for a convivial feast. Coming close on the heels of Ivanhoe privately calling Richard to account for tending to choose the dangerous life of chivalric adventure over his royal responsibilities, Lawrence Templeton offers a lengthy aside in which he further enumerates and develops the king's character, commenting on how it affected Richard's reign.

This passage clearly comes down on the anti-chivalry side of the debate about that social system's merits, openly calling it "useless." Still, readers should note that, while definitive, this argument doesn't end the debate. Ivanhoe's subsequent attempt to save Rebecca's life against all odds suggests that there may, after all, be some redeeming virtue in the practice of chivalry. Moreover, despite Templeton's criticism of King Richard here, the book arguably places him as its central character—Richard certainly does far more than titular character Ivanhoe. And, more often than not, the book celebrates the very tendencies it so starkly disavows here.

It's important to remember that these comments are filtered through historical hindsight and editorializing, too. King Richard left England soon after his coronation to lead an army to Palestine in the Third Crusade, and it took him five years to come back. Soon after his return, he left again and led a series of futile campaigns in northern France, where he died a premature death as the result of a wound in battle. Succeeded by his brother John, whom many near-contemporary sources considered a failed king, Richard's selfish devotion to chivalric adventure (according to common historical wisdom in the early 19th century), did indeed expose his subjects to pain and suffering.

Volume 3, Chapter 12 Quotes

☞ I asked for wine—they gave me some, but it must have been highly medicated, for I slept yet more deeply than before, and wakened not for many hours. I found my arms swathed down—my feet tied so fast that mine ankles ache at the very remembrance—the place was utterly dark—the oubliette, as I suppose, of their accursed convent, and from the close, stifled, damp smell, I conceive it is also used as a place of sepulture. I had strange thoughts of what had befallen me, when the door of my dungeon creaked, and two villain monks entered. They would have persuaded me I was in purgatory, but I knew too well the pursy short-breathed voice of the Father Abbot.—Saint Jeremy! how different from that tone with which he used to ask me for another slice of the haunch!—the dog has feasted with me from Christmas to Twelfth-night.

Related Characters: Athelstane of Coningsburgh (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Wilfred of Ivanhoe (the Palmer, the Disinherited Knight), Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Cedric, Rowena

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 377

Explanation and Analysis

Athelstane returns to his own funeral feast as if from the dead; after the initial shock wears off, he relates his harrowing tale to King Richard, Ivanhoe, Cedric, and Rowena. Basically, when Sir Brian hit him over the head with the butt of his sword, Athelstane merely lost consciousness. He woke later in St. Edmund's monastery, which the monks, thinking Athelstane was dead, laid out for a funeral. Then, when Athelstane revived, instead of tending to him and assisting his recovery, the monks attempted to imprison him in their convent, perpetuating the story of his death out of their greedy desire for the money they stood to make from his funeral. In the medieval period, it was common for wealthy individuals to make large bequests to religious institutions on the understanding that the institution's monks or nuns would make regular prayers for the deceased to speed their journey to heaven.

The tale that Athelstane tells of being hidden in the convent's cellar and of the monks trying to convince him he was in purgatory borrows from later medieval literary traditions, including the French fabliaux. Indeed, the mention of purgatory here is slightly anachronistic. While Christian theologians were developing the idea of purgatory (an indeterminate place for Christians who have died in the faith and therefore don't deserve to go to hell, but who haven't yet done enough penance for the sins they

committed in life to get straight into heaven) throughout the final decades of the 12th century, it wasn't codified into doctrine until 1215.

Symbolically, Athelstane's death points toward the end of the Saxons' hopes for regaining the English throne; his resurrection suggests, however, that from the ashes of the Saxon kingdom will rise the glorious English race. King Richard himself, though aligned socially and culturally with his Norman heritage, did have royal Saxon ancestors, even if he wasn't directly descended from any of the old Saxon kings.

Volume 3, Chapter 13 Quotes

☝ It was a scene of bustle and life, as if the whole vicinage had poured forth its inhabitants to a village wake, or rural feast. But the evident desire to look on blood and death, is not peculiar to these dark ages; though in the gladiatorial exercise of single combat and general tourney, they were habituated to the blood spectacle of brave men falling by each other's hands. Even in our own days, when morals are better understood, an execution, a bruising match between two professors, a riot, or a meeting of radical reformers, collects at considerable hazard to themselves an immense crowd of spectators, otherwise little interested, excepting to see how matters are to be conducted, and whether the heroes of the day are, in the heroic language of insurgent tailors, *flints* or *dunghills*.

Related Characters: Lawrence Templeton (speaker), King Richard (the Black Knight), Rebecca, Lucas de Beaumanoir

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 382

Explanation and Analysis

On the appointed day of the judicial combat which will decide Rebecca's fate, the Preceptory of Templestowe bustles with excitement as great crowds of onlookers descend from the surrounding countryside to witness brutal combat between two challenging knights, if not the

burning at the stake of a convicted witch. Though Rebecca's life hangs in the balance, most everyone treats the day as a holiday, with violence as the main attraction rather than an unfortunate consequence. And while 21st-century readers might find this bloodthirstiness to belong to the category of barbaric customs long since abandoned by enlightened moderns, *Ivanhoe's* 19th-century readers would likely have felt less distance between themselves and their medieval ancestors in this regard; executions were public spectacles in England until 1866 and through the 1930s in the United States.

Templeton uses this moment to reflect further on political developments of the early 19th century, in line with his theory that compelling stories about the past can reflect and help modern audiences to better understand events in their own day. 1819, the year in which *Ivanhoe* was written, saw upheaval and political protest in England. A combination of natural disasters (a volcanic eruption in 1815 led to a "year without a summer" in Europe, destroying crops and leading to widespread famine) and economic uncertainty led to calls for Parliamentary reform which would have extended voting rights to a greater percentage of the (male) British population. The British cavalry charged one of these massive protests, killing more than a dozen people and injuring hundreds. Around this time, Walter Scott published three articles supporting the current government and censuring the protestors. This distrust of political agitators lies behind the passage's outing of "political reformers" as agents of chaos and violence.

Similarly, the passage points to early 19th century social upheaval with "flints" and "dunghills," belittling terms used in collective action on the part of apprenticed tailors to gain better working conditions from their employers. By equating political and economic protest with medieval customs (which are by implication barbaric and backward), the novel casually denies protestors' complaints, in line with its general valorization of King Richard and the idea of monarchy in general, even when an individual monarch has character flaws.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

DEDICATORY EPISTLE

Lawrence Templeton, naming himself as author of the following story, writes a letter to the Reverend Dr. Jonas Dryasdust explaining his literary project. Templeton worries that Dryasdust will consider the unworthy book as little better than an “idle novel [or] romance.” He recalls Dryasdust’s contention that a contest between an English historical novelist and a Scottish one would be unfairly weighted towards the Scot, since the interesting parts of English history lie too deep in the past to appeal to modern audiences and he doubts that English readers would willingly accept the idea of their ancestors practicing barbaric customs.

On the contrary, Templeton contends, although it may be harder to glean sufficient hints about the “private life of [English] ancestors” from “musty records and chronicles,” a sufficiently wide survey of the available materials can, indeed, paint a vivid picture of the past. And he feels confident that if he has painted a “true picture of old English manners,” his countrymen will accept it. Finally, he answers Dryasdust’s final argument—that scholars make bad storytellers—with a list of men accomplished in both spheres, among whom Templeton hopes to merit inclusion.

Templeton admits that he cannot claim complete and total accuracy in his depiction of medieval customs—doing so would render the work unreadable—but he notes that all good fiction makes careful choices to facilitate readers’ understanding and interest. Successful translations of exotic books like *The Arabian Nights* depend on a careful mixture of accuracy and literary license; moreover, the best historical fictions both highlight the strangeness of the past *and* acknowledging the similarities of “manners and sentiments” across eras. To prove this point, he notes how familiar the emotions and situations in, say, Chaucer, can seem to modern readers who muddle through the language. Strange though their customs may have been, people in the past were still people.

The book begins with a letter discussing the uses and limitations of historical fiction, a somewhat underrated genre in the era in which Ivanhoe was published. Still, the contemporaneous and enduring popularity of Walter Scott’s historical novels argues at least as eloquently as this letter. In general, Lawrence Templeton (both a character created by Scott, with his own backstory, and Scott’s pen name) considers a difference between the past and the present as historical fiction’s primary obstacle.



Part of Templeton’s claim rests on the idea that history is interesting in itself; the author of Ivanhoe clearly read a lot of medieval history and romance, and his background knowledge is apparent in lengthy passages describing the rules of a joust, medieval clothing, and the differences in décor between Norman and Saxon houses. Although modern historians have found many inaccuracies in Ivanhoe’s portrayal of the Middle Ages, the vivid and largely correct world of the book has inspired generations of readers.



The main reason Templeton gives for historical fiction’s importance—that by presenting fictional stories, the novelist humanizes the past in a way that cultivates the reader’s interest and empathy—points to the book’s enduring appeal over the two centuries since its publication. Some of the practices and attitudes it portrays might strike the modern reader as barbaric (for instance, the persistent and often violent antisemitism Rebecca and Isaac face throughout), yet the characters also model courage, compassion, and kindness.



In striking this balance, the writer faces a steeper challenge than other artists, since he must paint with words. And in this arena, Templeton admits his work may fall short of Dryasdust's exacting standards. While he carefully avoided the inaccurate use of modern ideas, he may have conflated different eras of the past to paint a vivid picture. But he expects only specialists, not general readers, to note these mistakes.

Templeton closes his letter by describing his primary source, a single manuscript he found in the possession of Sir Arthur Wardour. He expresses his hope that he has explained, if not vindicated, his attempt. Then, after a paragraph of personal considerations and social gossip, he bids Dryasdust farewell. A footnote complains that it took more than a year for the letter to reach Dryasdust thanks to the poor state of the postal service.

Templeton also anticipates the scholars nitpicking the tiny details he may get wrong—he openly admits to some anachronism (employing ideas or events or fashions from other eras) where it helps his readers to better understand his characters and the lessons their lives have to offer, or where doing so makes his book more compelling. He argues for the use of facts as long as they don't impede readers' enjoyment or their grasping of the novel's main claims.



Scott, through Templeton, gives a veneer of historical accuracy when he describes the manuscript in which Templeton allegedly found the story of Ivanhoe. And the letter's gossipy closing reminds readers of the era in which it was composed, anticipating a future in which the historicity of the novel would be doubly layered by the medieval past it invokes and the early 19th-century world in which it was composed.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 1

The story begins in a forest in central England, late in the reign of King Richard I. At this time, Templeton explains, Richard's subjects desperately want him to return and free them from the tyranny of the noble classes, but they have little hope of this happening any longer. The lower nobility, called the "Franklins" by their overlords, find themselves particularly pinched; the upper nobility harasses and oppresses those who remain independent, but those who place themselves under the protection of noble families can get sucked into their feuds and political jockeying.

The strife between the upper and lower nobility dates back to the invasion of England by the Normans (from France) led by Duke William of Normandy. Once in power, the Normans began to oppress the native Anglo-Saxon population. Four generations later, the Anglo-Saxons still have no love for their Norman oppressors, and the Normans haven't learned to treat their Anglo-Saxon subjects kindly. When they talk of "honour, of chivalry, and even of justice," people use French; Anglo-Saxon speech belongs to "rustics and hinds," although most people can communicate with a sort of patois blended of the two. This mixed speech forms the basis of modern English, as Templeton proudly notes in an aside. Still, in the period between the Norman invasion and the reign of Edward III, the social and cultural divisions between Saxons and Normans remain open wounds.

Ivanhoe was written at a time of social change and political upheaval in England. The novel portrays a similarly tumultuous time, but it ends happily with the triumphant return of King Richard. It thus holds up a mirror to its initial 19th-century British audience, reminding them that their nation has persevered through periods of political upheaval before and can do some again. The England of Scott's 19th-century audience suffers from social and racial divisions, yet from it, England will eventually emerge stronger and better than before.



The Norman Conquest effectively disinherits all Saxon natives and replaces their social and political world with that of the abusive Normans. And although the novel frequently alludes to a later English identity which rises from both Saxon and Norman elements, it clearly casts the Saxons as admirable and the Normans as effete, corrupt, and invasive villains. This passage suggests that speaking the language of nobility does not guarantee that a person lives a life of virtue. Ultimately, only Richard and Ivanhoe, men capable of moving smoothly between Norman and Saxon contexts, provide models for future Englishness.



Returning to the tale, two men, both clearly Saxons, occupy an ancient **oak** grove in the forest at sunset. The older of the two, Gurth, has a “stern, savage, and wild” expression. He wears simple, rustic, and well-worn clothing made of animal skins. He has a horn and a knife tucked into his wide leather belt and no head covering but his own thick and matted hair. He wears a brass necklace soldered around his neck, which bears his name and the name of his master, Cedric of Rotherwood. The second wears clothing similar in shape to Gurth’s but made of finer, more brightly colored material. It includes a purple jerkin, a short red cloak lined in yellow fabric, and a silver collar identifying him as Wamba. Wamba, clearly a jester, wears a fantastical belled cap. He has a wooden sword tucked into his belt.

Gurth looks at the ground. Wamba stares vacantly into the distance with “fidgety impatience.” Although they carry on their conversation in Anglo-Saxon, Templeton assures readers that he will translate it for their ease of understanding. Gurth curses the pigs lounging in the grove, because they refuse to gather when he blows his horn. Gurth’s dog, Fangs, only scatters the animals further by his incompetent (or possibly malicious) efforts.

Wamba refuses to help Gurth, unwilling to dirty his fine clothes in the muck, and he suggests leaving the pigs to face their destiny. Maybe, he muses, they will be turned into Normans by the morning. Gurth demands to know what Wamba means, and Wamba explains that the living animals are called by the Saxon word, “swine.” Dead, they become “pork,” a Norman word. Wamba dryly observes that things that require work are Saxon, while things for the wealthy to enjoy are Norman. Gurth grumbles that the Normans take advantage of everything they can; without men like Cedric opposing them, he fears they’d have taken the Saxons’ very air.

Wamba warns Gurth to still his treasonous words; he might get in trouble if someone other than a “fool” hears him. And he hears approaching horses. Grumbling that it’s just thunder, Gurth suggests they round up the pigs and get home before the rain begins.

The book lays out its concerns very clearly in this opening scene: readers find themselves in an oak grove (representative of English identity, but also of strength and perseverance) with not just two Saxons but two enslaved Saxons. Although much of the book will focus on the actions of wealthy and powerful men, this opening moment suggests that the true value of Englishness and England lies with the common people. Describing Wamba’s and Gurth’s outfits also introduces the men’s characters in a particularly vivid way: they’re both simple men yet feel no shame in their simplicity. Both are capable of defending themselves: Gurth with Strength, and Wamba—at least initially—with wit.



The difficulties and frustration Gurth expresses—he cannot get the pigs to heed his call—points to the larger disarray and disorder in England under Norman rule. The book suggests that without strong leadership (the kind King Richard—but not his brother Prince John—can provide), the world will fall apart.



Wamba’s linguistic joke here points to the history of the English language. In doing so he anticipates a moment in the future when all English subjects will speak one language rather than two—modern English does retain the Saxon and French words Wamba cites. But he also makes a broader point about the ways in which the Normans dispossess their Saxon victims, who provide the labor necessary to sate the Norman appetites for power and comfort.



Gurth’s worry about being overheard speaking treason against the conquering Normans points to the fraught political situation of medieval England at this moment in history; the native inhabitants of the land have no power and little safety.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 2

Wamba dawdles on the road until the riders—10 men—overtake him and Gurth. Two evidently wealthy men lead the train, each accompanied by some attendants. The first man (later identified as Aymer) wears clothes that look like the habit of a Cistercian monk, although the Cistercian rule forbids luxuries like the colorful, fur-lined garments he wears. A venal twinkle lights Aymer's eyes, the only unguarded part of his carefully composed expression. He and the other four monks ride on fine Spanish mules with ornamented saddle cloths and bridles.

The other head rider (later identified as Sir Brian) is a tall, muscular, middle-aged man with strong features and sun-tanned skin. A frightening temper seems to lie just below the calm surface of his expression, and one can tell from looking at him how many dangers he has faced—and survived. A scar runs across his forehead and one of his eyes. He wears the clothing of a Templar knight, a cross between a knight's armor and a monk's robes. He rides a workhorse, but one of his attendants leads a "gallant war-horse" dressed for battle and evidently bred in the East. His two squires bear his splendid weapons and armor. His two dark-skinned servants wear embroidered silk clothing and carry "Saracen"-style weapons which identify them as foreigners.

Ivanhoe's description of Prior Aymer draws on the portrait of the Monk from Chaucer's Canterbury Tales. Both Aymer and the Monk abuse their position as representatives of the Church to enrich themselves and sate their own appetites for good food and aristocratic diversions like hunting. By the time the Cistercian Order was founded in 1098, many other religious institutions had become wealthy and stopped living lives of poverty and self-denial. The Cistercians returned to this original ideal. By making Aymer a Cistercian, the book both draws on historical fact (the Order exploded in England in the 1120s) and further suggest the abuses of power and morality practiced by Normans like Aymer. This also points to the idea of disguise and discovery; in the book, noble characters use disguises, while ignoble ones usually cannot hide their vices from the world.



Sir Brian immediately pushes the limits of the book's idealization of knighthood—although he's clearly strong and brave, he lacks the moral rectitude of a chivalrous knight. Arrogance and anger rule his actions instead of kindness and justice. Members of the Templar Order (founded in 1118) promised to protect the city of Jerusalem and all the Christian Europeans who traveled there as pilgrims (religious tourists) or as part of the crusader armies which wanted to capture and colonize the land where many of the events described in the Christian Bible played out. He also took monastic vows, promising to serve God and the Roman Catholic Church with humility, obedience, and poverty. It's immediately clear, however, that Sir Brian isn't doing either. The book describes his servants as "Saracens," a medieval word for people coming from Muslim-majority countries between Syria and Arabia. Their being enslaved by a Templar knight points toward medieval European colonial ambitions in Palestine (and recalls the British colonial empire already well-established by the time Ivanhoe was written, thus linking past and present).



Wamba and Gurth immediately recognize Aymer, the Prior of nearby Jorvaulx Abbey. Most people like Aymer. He absolves penitents' sins without requiring much penance; he has familial ties to prominent Norman nobles; he admires the ladies; he enjoys the hunt; he preaches an impressive sermon; and he generously shares the priory's wealth with the poor. Thus no one says anything when he joins the hunt or indulges in fine food or sneaks back into the abbey early in the morning after a romantic rendezvous.

Aymer ungraciously demands directions to the nearest nobleman's house from Wamba and Gurth, who hesitate to direct the party to the home of their master, Cedric. Wamba points them towards nearby monasteries, but Aymer tactfully suggests his preference for a layman's charity. Sir Brian breaks in, demanding directions to Cedric the Saxon's home specifically. Ultimately, Wamba gives them incorrect directions in exchange for a silver coin. As the riders depart, Gurth notes that the knight would likely have provoked Cedric and that Aymer might have taken too much interest in "the lady Rowena."

On the road, Sir Brian asks Aymer about the insolent servants, and Aymer explains that the defeated Saxons' descendants, like Gurth and his master Cedric, still tend to be "savage, fierce, and intractable." Sir Brian testily replies that a good beating can tame the most savage slave. The two men discuss their bet about Rowena's beauty and the monk warns the knight to avoid betraying an interest in the girl. Rumor has it that Cedric banished his own son for falling in love with her.

Having reached the landmark where Wamba told them to turn, Sir Brian and Aymer begin to argue because neither can remember if they're supposed to turn left or right. They fight until Sir Brian notices—and has his squire poke—a man huddled there. The stranger, a Palmer, complains in French about their discourteous interruption of his meditation but agrees to show them the way to Cedric's house through the dark and boggy woodland. He identifies himself only as a pilgrim recently returned from Palestine, where—he acidly suggests—Sir Brian should have remained to defend Jerusalem. Soon the party reaches Rotherwood, a large house protected by a moat and double fence. As the rain begins, Sir Brian sounds his horn at the gate.

The list of Aymer's virtues toggles back and forth between religious and worldly concerns. And, apart from supporting the poor, even his religious "accomplishments" seem rather hollow: he preaches a rousing sermon but fails to set a good example; he lets people off the hook for their sins in a way that suggests a morally lax outlook. But mostly, he succumbs to his own appetites and desires. His vows of chastity and poverty don't keep him from having affairs or enjoying the rich life of a Norman nobleman. He thus participates in and perpetuates his kinsmen's abuse and displacement of the native Saxon population.



Aymer wants to stay at a nobleman's house, the book strongly implies, because it's there that he can expect a rich meal and fine wine. Religious houses which properly observe their vows of poverty can't entertain a corrupt and abusive Norman monk like him. Sir Brian's particular insistence on staying with Cedric, despite his well-known abhorrence of the Normans, further suggests his innate desire to harass and control others, and points to the Normans' general abuse of their power in England.



Although Aymer means his description of Gurth as an insult, the book shows a marked preference for rough and strong Saxon ways over refined and useless Norman inventions; thus, Aymer's insult functions more as a compliment, highlighting a quality Saxon blood provides to the English identity that the book celebrates. Sir Brian's desire to beat the servants points toward the cruelty that lies beneath his chivalric veneer.



Again, Sir Brian's arrogance and selfishness belie his Templar vows and raise questions about his membership in the order (only much later will he tell Rebecca what he truly hopes to gain as a Templar). The Palmer chides his betrayal of his vows, too: the Templars promised to defend Jerusalem with their lives, yet Muslim leader Saladin had taken the city a few years before the events in this story. Unlike the Saxons, the Palmer suggests, the Templars found themselves displaced through their own actions. But, instead of staying in Palestine and fighting to reclaim the city, Sir Brian has selfishly abandoned his responsibilities. Readers should note the ease with which the Palmer leads the party to Rotherwood, which hints that he may be none other than Cedric's disowned son, Ivanhoe.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 3

Years of woodsmoke from the drafty fireplaces have darkened the wide beams that support the thatched roof of Cedric's great hall. He has decorated the room in self-consciously "Saxon" style. It has a hard-packed dirt floor and plain walls; at one end, the head table sits on an elevated dais with a carpeted floor and tapestry-laden walls. Cedric sits in a large chair on the dais, growing increasingly impatient. He has an expressive face, quick to both anger and merriment. A lifetime of asserting his rights against the Normans has given him an alert, proud attitude. Even though he's nearly 60, most of his long hair remains blonde rather than gray.

Servants of various ranks attend to Cedric, and a pack of hunting dogs lounges around the hall as he mutters to himself and his servant Oswald about all the things contributing to his foul mood. Lady Rowena, caught in the storm, needs to change her wet clothes before the meal can begin. Gurth and the pigs haven't yet returned and may have fallen into the hands of local outlaws or the closest Norman baron. Cedric wants Wamba. Seizing the spear he keeps with him to use as a walking staff or a weapon, Cedric swears to avenge himself in combat if anyone has accosted his servants or taken his animals.

Then Cedric remembers another source of grief, his son Wilfred of Ivanhoe. Because Cedric banished his son for being unable to control his "unreasonable passions," he now faces his old age like a solitary **oak** standing alone against a tempest. The sound of a horn at the gate interrupts Cedric's sad thoughts, and a servant soon announces the arrival of Prior Aymer and Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, Templar knight, with their attendants. They request Cedric's hospitality as they travel to the upcoming tournament at Ashby-de-la-Zouche.

It isn't in Cedric's nature to deny anyone, even hated Normans, hospitality, although he refuses to show Sir Brian and Aymer the same deference he would extend to Saxon nobles. Cedric knows both by reputation; gossip of the Templar's valiance, bravery, cruelty, and worldliness have preceded the man to England. Cedric orders his servants to prepare drinks and tells a maid to suggest that Rowena skip gracing the hall that night. He'd like to order her away, but he can't. Because she descends from King Alfred, he treats her like a princess. The maid thinks Rowena, always anxious for news from Palestine, will come. Cedric must remind himself that he feels no more anxiety for his disowned son than any other crusader.

The description of Cedric's hall reminds readers of the novel's historical setting—but the strangeness of dress and décor only emphasize by contrast how recognizable his emotions—impatience, hunger, pride—are. And his life serves as a continual reminder of Norman abuses of power and Saxon displacement. Cedric steadfastly maintains his Saxon identity even where assimilation would make his life easier, and it's sacrifices like his, the book suggests, that preserve Saxon strength in later English character.



Cedric's habitual concern about the welfare and safety of his property (the pigs which contribute to his wealth) and the people in his household point both toward Norman abuses of power—no one can assume that their belongings or person are safe if Normans hold themselves above the laws and take what they want when they want it. But it also establishes his character as an able leader. Like King Richard (and unlike Prince John), he cares at least as much (if not more) about others than himself.



But Cedric isn't perfect; his anger and pride have cost him his only child and sole heir, Wilfred. When Cedric considers Ivanhoe's "unreasonable passions," he aligns his son with the immoral Norman characters readers have already met. Both Aymer and Sir Brian follow their passions and desires wherever they lead, rather than holding themselves accountable to live moral lives. Yet, readers will later learn more about Ivanhoe that will call Cedric's characterization into question.



Unlike the Normans, whose virtue seems dependent on their whims, Cedric sticks fast to his values, even when they cause him discomfort. He thus shows Saxon strength and contributes to the book's argument for the importance of the Saxon strand of English identity. It also says something about Cedric that the same pride that caused him to disown Ivanhoe (a decision he still clearly feels conflicted about) animates his decision to show hospitality to his avowed enemies.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 4

Aymer and Sir Brian dress grandly for dinner and sweep into the hall with their attendants. The Palmer trails behind them. Finding no room at the table, he warms and dries himself at the fireplace. Cedric receives his guests with dignified hospitality, although he refuses to speak Norman. Aymer graciously answers in Saxon, but Sir Brian gruffly says that *he* speaks only French, the language of King Richard and his nobles, but that he understands English well enough.

Cedric flushes with anger but, controlling himself, signals for the feast to begin. Then he sees Wamba and Gurth entering the hall. He chides them for their lateness, and Wamba offers a roundabout excuse blaming Sir Philip de Malvoisin's servant for laming Gurth's dog Fangs. Cedric vows to lame Malvoisin's servant...before remembering his guests and calming himself.

Then the steward announces the arrival of Lady Rowena. Cedric rises and escorts her to her place. As she passes, Sir Brian whispers to Aymer that the prior has won their bet. The knight can't take his eyes off the tall, fair Rowena. Her intelligent eyes and aristocratic features demonstrate her noble character. When she realizes how openly he stares at her, she pulls her veil modestly over her face in rebuke. He apologizes and says he hopes she will come to watch the tournament.

Cedric says he dislikes tournaments as much as the Normans like them. Aymer and Sir Brian offer to safely convey Cedric and his company thence, but Cedric gruffly replies that he has never been unable to protect himself in his own land. He and his guests quickly smooth over their differences with some friendly toasts. Sir Brian drinks to the Lady Rowena, who coldly ignores his compliments and instead asks for news from Palestine.

Sir Brian cites the rumored truce between the crusader army and Saladin; Wamba interrupts to declare that he must be at least 150, since he's lived to see three such truces, all of which were supposed to last for 50 years at least. Suddenly recognizing him as the man who gave them bad directions in the forest, Sir Brian promises Wamba that he will die of violence, rather than old age, if he keeps misdirecting travelers. A page interrupts their argument with an announcement: another visitor has come to the gate.

The Palmer's identity remains disguised, and without name or rank he cannot claim his place—or any place—at the table. His situation points to both Norman oppression generally and Ivanhoe's disinheritance specifically, adding to readers' suspicions about his identity. Earlier, Wamba made a joke that rested on the eventual melding of Saxon and Norman languages, but the tense conversation between Aymer, Sir Brian, and Cedric reminds readers that linguistic strife still exists at this point.



Cedric demonstrates the self-control that Aymer and Sir Brian (and, by implication, the Normans in general) lack. But it also points toward his minority position; it's dangerous for him to oppose the ruling class outright. The idea that another Norman baron has interfered with his property (Fangs) further highlights his oppressed state.



In this moment the book portrays Rowena both as powerful in her beauty and virtue, and as vulnerable to the desire and potential violence of men like Sir Brian, who openly stares at her. She can only criticize him indirectly, by veiling her face; should he want to force himself on her, this moment suggests, she would have little recourse. Thus, in an instant, Sir Brian displays typical Norman aggression, betrays his stunning lack of true virtue, and highlights women's vulnerable position in medieval society.



Although the Normans offer the Saxons protection, Cedric pointedly answers that he needs to be protected from the Norman nobility, not by it. Their abuses of power and theft of land pose a much greater threat than the Saxon highwaymen who have flourished in the absence of true authority since King Richard's absence.



The peace brokered between Muslim and Christian armies points yet again to the emptiness at the heart of Norman chivalry. Sir Brian abandoned Jerusalem rather than protect it, and King Richard has negotiated with the enemy. And, to prove the point, Sir Brian turns on Wamba and threatens him with violence for failing to show the proper deference.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 5

Oswald identifies the visitor as Isaac of York. Aymer and Sir Brian protest being made to share the hall with an “unbelieving” and “dog” Jewish person, but Cedric replies that their prejudices do not rule his hospitality. Still, he won’t force anyone to share a table with Isaac or to talk to him. Even Brian’s Muslim servants hate and scorn Jewish people.

Isaac enters the hall bowing deferentially. He would have been handsome, had he not been marked by the aquiline nose, piercing black eyes, and “mean and unamenable” character that mark him as belonging to a race that was detested and persecuted by vulgar peasants and noblemen alike during “these dark ages.” Cedric speaks coldly to Isaac, and none of his servants or guests makes room for him at the table. Only the Palmer takes pity on Isaac, inviting him to sit by the warm fire.

Aymer and Cedric’s conversation about hunting turns political when Sir Brian names French the natural language of “the chase [...] love [...] and war.” Cedric, in turn, claims that he hunts just as well in Saxon as Norman. When Cedric toasts the crusader armies, Sir Brian boasts about the Templars and Wamba points out that they failed at their job of protecting Jerusalem. Brian casts blame on others until the Palmer finally becomes impatient enough to interrupt.

As much as the book focuses on Cedric’s and the Saxons’ sense of displacement and abuse, the reception that greets Isaac shows that the Saxons are not by far the most oppressed group in medieval England. Enmity toward Jewish people in medieval Europe was a complex and multifaceted phenomenon, rooted in religious beliefs (expressed by Aymer), social prejudice (expressed by Brian) and stereotyping Jewish people as avaricious and unprincipled businessmen—stereotypes often perpetuated by powerful people for the purposes of extorting or seizing wealth from Jewish communities. In general, the way that others react toward Isaac will betray their underlying value systems. Abusive, unprincipled Normans reject him entirely; Cedric treats him with suspicious and cold hospitality, showing more fairness than his Norman overlords but no more tolerance than would be expected in his era.



Templeton offers an aside explaining how Jews were treated in “these dark ages,” thus distancing himself from some of the prejudice and racism of his medieval characters and as if the history he offers gives modern readers a chance to reflect on the differences between the past and the present. Yet, antisemitic stereotypes that were common in the Middle Ages persist to the modern era. His own tendency to blame the victims points to ongoing prejudice. Although he’s careful to acknowledge the role persecution plays in shaping Isaac’s actions, he still describes Isaac as “mean” and “unamenable.” In contrast to the others, the Palmer treats Isaac with civility and kindness, suggesting that he might know even more than Cedric about being oppressed, mistreated, and cast out.



Given the value placed on Norman French, which Templeton explained at the very beginning of the book, the disagreement between Sir Brian and Cedric about hunting terminology becomes an argument about who gets to lay claim to positions of authority in England. Sir Brian claims it’s the Normans, although Wamba’s retort pushes back by pointing out the ways in which their own lack of virtue disqualifies them from positions of authority.



The Palmer asserts that the English knights who followed King Richard I to Palestine outclassed everyone else. He recalls a tournament in which King Richard and five of his knights bested fifteen men—seven of whom were Templars, including Sir Brian. Sir Brian, humiliated and enraged, instinctively reaches for his sword as Cedric demands the names of the knights. The Palmer lists five of the six but claims to have forgotten the name of the last. Sir Brian hasn't: it was the Knight of Ivanhoe, a man he says he would gladly face again in hopes of revenge. The Palmer, who seems to know Ivanhoe somehow, promises the Templar that, if given the chance, Ivanhoe will gladly meet his challenge. He wagers a fine reliquary on it.

Prior Aymer takes the Palmer's and Sir Brian's pledges on his promised rematch into safekeeping, then he decides it's time for himself and Sir Brian to retire before high feelings in the hall lead to violence. As he passes by, Sir Brian accuses Isaac in unflattering terms of planning to practice usury at the tournament. Isaac protests that he goes there to ask other Jewish people for help raising funds for a fine imposed on him by the Exchequer of Jews. Declaring, "Beshrew thee for a false-hearted liar," the Templar pushes past Isaac and speaks briefly to his servants before leaving the hall.

The book shows respect for King Richard alone among its Norman characters, and in doing so follows a longstanding English reverence for Richard "the Lionheart," in large part due to the chivalric reputation the Palmer describes here. The success of Richard and his knights against Sir Brian and his Templar companions suggests not so much that might makes right as proves it; the fact that Richard I, Ivanhoe, and their fellows win a mock battle in which they are outnumbered three to one suggests that they are better men than then Templars. Based on Sir Brian's selfish, lustful, and decidedly un-chivalric behavior thus far, readers are likely to agree.



Yet again, when Sir Brian's true colors show, they suggest the limitations of a chivalric code or set of ideals to influence men of bad character. He accuses Isaac of practicing "usury," or making loans to people and then growing rich from charging (potentially excessive) interest, thus betraying his prejudice against Jewish people. Due to a range of factors, including religious conflict and Christian law, medieval European Jewish people were stereotypically cast as moneylenders, or people who enriched themselves off others' misery by offering loans and charging excessive interest rates.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 6

As a servant leads the Palmer away from the hall, Oswald promises him a cup of good mead if he will share news from Palestine with the household servants. When the Palmer declines, Oswald orders the servant to put him in a servant's stall, next to Isaac, rather than a better bedroom. Before he can do so, one of Rowena's maids summons the Palmer to her chamber because she wants more information about Ivanhoe. The Palmer says only that when he met him, Ivanhoe was recovering from ill health, that he escaped persecution from the Norman-allied, and that he planned to return home soon. Rowena, the Palmer says, knows better than he what kind of reception Ivanhoe will receive when he arrives. She offers him a piece of gold, then dismisses him.

Oswald's treatment of the Palmer emphasizes his lowly status; he has no power in the household, like the disowned and outcast Ivanhoe. This, in combination with his apparent knowledge of Ivanhoe's movements, again strongly suggests that he might be Ivanhoe in disguise. His patience in the face of abuse and suffering suggests both the inherent strength of the oppressed Saxon and the resilience of the knight. Moreover, the readiness of Norman-allied individuals to persecute the Saxon Ivanhoe and the Saxon-sympathetic King Richard, even when they should have been focused on winning the Third Crusade, points to the invading Normans' extreme abuse of power.



The servant takes the Palmer to a rustic but clean room between Gurth and Isaac. The Palmer falls asleep immediately. In the morning, he quietly sneaks into Isaac's room, where he finds the moneylender muttering in his sleep about persecution. He prods Isaac awake with a staff, warning the old man that he overheard Sir Brian ordering his servants to follow Isaac, capture him, and turn him over to one of the closest Norman nobles. The Palmer offers to guide him safely to Sheffield, where he can bribe someone else to help him get to the tournament. Still protesting his poverty, Isaac accepts. The Palmer wakes Gurth, whispers some secret words in his ear, and persuades him to help them leave in secret.

The Palmer leads Isaac through the countryside with such urgency that Isaac occasionally fears betrayal. In an aside, Templeton explains a little about the situation of the Jewish people in this era: they were universally despised in part out of religious prejudice, and in part because they often made themselves very rich from lending money at punishing interest rates to the wealthy. As they were the only source of ready cash, nobles and even kings had few other options. Thus, the powerful often retaliated by persecuting and extorting money from Jewish people in their lands.

The Palmer and Isaac reach an **oak** tree that marks the extent of the Norman nobles' properties and points out the road to Sheffield. Isaac realized the previous evening that the Palmer is a knight in disguise, and he wants to repay the man's kindness. He writes a note in Hebrew and hands it to the Palmer, telling him to visit a moneylender in Leicester who will lend him a horse and armor for the tournament as repayment. If he has earned enough in the tournament, he can buy the equipment afterwards; if he loses, Isaac promises to cover the cost—although he's certain the Palmer won't lose.

VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 7

The tournament in question happens at an unsettled moment in British history: enemies hold King Richard I captive abroad; at home, his younger brother Prince John plots and plans to extend Richard's imprisonment and seize the throne for himself; the aristocracy rule over their lands like "petty tyrants," and bands of rough outlaws rove the forests and the wastes. Between the bandits, the barons, and nature, the common people face extortion, violence, and endemic diseases. Thus, people happily flock to tournaments as a welcome distraction from the ongoing trials of their lives.

Although the book largely portrays Isaac and Rebecca in a sympathetic light and critiques other characters for their antisemitic and prejudicial treatment of the two, it also subtly confirms negative stereotypes about Jewish people with its ongoing hints that Isaac lies about his wealth and tries to take advantage of others' generosity through pretending to be poor and helpless. Still, it paints the Palmer in a good light for the ongoing generosity and concern he extends to Isaac.



Ivanhoe captures the situation of Jewish people in medieval Europe fairly accurately. And it correctly blames both religious and social factors for medieval antisemitism. But it also perpetuates these same racist stereotypes in its quiet but ongoing suggestion that Jewish people deserved censure for overcharging their customers. Readers can usefully compare the book's criticism of Isaac for taking money from the wealthy with the way it celebrates Locksley and his woodsmen-bandits for doing the same.



The book associates the Palmer with an oak tree; because it has previously tied the oak to Cedric and his servants, this continues to suggest that the Palmer might really be Ivanhoe. Certainly, Isaac sees through at least part of the Palmer's disguise, easily identifying him as a knight. This suggests that chivalry does have value to society, since it encourages people to behave in recognizable and recognizably pro-social ways (like helping Isaac with no hope of reward).



The book casts the medieval tournament as a medieval manifestation of the bread and circuses which Roman emperors once used to distract the downtrodden lower classes from their misery. And the fact that the tournament—a showcase of chivalric values such as bravery and martial skill—happens at such an unsettled moment in English history points toward the book's ongoing debate about the merits of chivalry. With Jerusalem in Saladin's hands, the rightful king imprisoned, and father turned against son in England, the book suggests that there might be more pressing issues than allowing a bunch of knights who are supposedly on the same side to injure and potentially kill one another for bragging rights.



The tournament grounds at Ashby lie in a lush, green valley (a natural amphitheater) ringed by ancient **oak** trees. At one end sit the pavilions of the five challenger knights. The central tent belongs to the most honored challenger, Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert. The other tents belong to Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, Philip de Malvoisin, Hugh de Grantmensisil, and Ralph de Vipont. At the other end of the field sits an enclosed area where knights who wish to meet the challenge of these men will gather. Next to this, an assortment of armorers, farriers, blacksmiths, and others set up stalls to service the knights' needs. A grandly decorated platform placed adjacent to the middle of the lists, or field, stands ready for the viewing pleasure of Prince John and his attendants. A seat there waits for the lady who will be chosen as the tournament's "Queen of Love and Beauty."

As spectators descend on the tournament grounds, tussles sometimes arise between one and another over prime seats. Isaac attends the festivities wearing his finest clothes—much better than the rags he wore at Rotherwood—because he fears little violence at the crowded tournament, especially since Prince John is currently negotiating a large loan from the Jews of York. His lovely daughter, Rebecca, accompanies him.

Prince John arrives amid much fanfare, accompanied by the sumptuously dressed Prior Aymer, representatives of the Templar Order, and the Knights of St. John. These crusader organizations sided with Prince John over his brother King Richard and, gossip suggests, conspired to undermine the king's efforts in Palestine to prevent him from returning to England. A great deal of enmity exists between Prince John and the few still-powerful Saxon families. A small commotion, caused by the indignation of men in the crowd over Isaac's presence, draws the prince's attention, and his eye immediately falls on the beautiful Rebecca, whose exotic, foreign manner of clothing only increases her appeal.

Prince John, keenly appreciating Rebecca's beauty, orders a group of "Saxon churls" to move so that she and Isaac may have their seats. The "churls" in question are Cedric and his ally and kinsman Athelstane of Coningsburgh. Most Saxon families hold Athelstane, a direct descendant of Edward the Confessor, in high regard, even though he has earned the moniker "the Unready" because of excessive drinking, habitual indecision, and stupidity. Confronted by the prince, Athelstane neither wishes to comply nor knows how to refuse. He stares openly at Prince John in disbelief—or confusion.

The fact that oak trees—symbolic of native (Saxon) Englishness—surround the tournament field suggests that the Norman challengers—especially Front-de-Boeuf and Malvoisin, who have been terrorizing the local area—will face defeat and rebuke for their abuse of power. The book's descriptions here capture the noise and excitement of a medieval tournament; the support staff required suggests the vastness of the undertaking and offers modern readers a reminder that tournaments, for all that they were considered games, were more akin to actual war.



Isaac and Rebecca, resplendent in their expensive and exotic clothing, confirm directly what the book only implied before: that Isaac lied about his poverty and helplessness at Rotherwood. Moments like this contribute to the antisemitic attitudes the book ostensibly criticizes in its medieval characters.



The alignment of the Templar Order with Prince John serves to underline the book's negative portrayal of the Normans and sympathetic portrait of King Richard. And the book continues to mix antisemitic tropes with a sympathetic portrayal of its Jewish characters when it describes Rebecca's physical beauty and the over-the-top opulence of her clothing and jewelry. This suggests that Isaac, in addition to enriching himself with Christian wealth, also enjoys flaunting it.



Prince John's demand that a group of Saxons allow Jewish people—the lowest of the low in this social hierarchy—to have their seats contributes to the book's negative portrayal of the Norman ruling class. It encapsulates the Saxons' feeling of disinheritance and dispossession in a single moment. However, despite its pro-Saxon sentiment, the book must follow history and see King Richard restored to the English throne; leaning into Athelstane's character flaws lays the groundwork for this restoration without denying the Saxons' rightful claim to sovereignty.



Prince John orders one of his companions, a mercenary named Maurice De Bracy, to poke Athelstane into compliance, but Cedric unsheathes his sword and cuts off the pointed barb on the mercenary's lance. Deeply affronted, the prince flushes with anger as the crowd gleefully cheers on Cedric. Prince John vents his frustration on a yeoman archer in the crowd, then, over Isaac's protests, orders him and Rebecca to move to the better seats, daring anyone to stop them. Wamba jumps up and brandishes a side of bacon like a shield in Isaac's face. Instinctively recoiling from food which his religion judges unclean, Isaac loses his footing and tumbles down the stairs, to the general glee of the crowd. Wamba demands a prize from Prince John for vanquishing his foe. The amused Prince orders Isaac to yield his seat to the jester, and he takes Isaac's purse as a "loan" to reward the victorious Wamba. 10100

VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 8

Suddenly, Prince John remembers that he should be picking the Queen of Love and Beauty. He suggests Rebecca, making Aymer blanch at the thought of elevating "a Jewess" to such honor. Aymer suggests Rowena, but Prince John retorts that he sees little difference between a "dog" Jew and a "hog" Saxon. Fortunately, his counselors dissuade him before he can draw the ire of the "Saxon churls" in the crowd. They suggest he allow the day's victor to select the queen. Noting the crowd's growing impatience, one advisor, Waldemar Fitzurse, encourages the prince to take his place and allow the festivities to begin.

A herald proclaims the tournament's rules. The five challengers will fight anyone who wishes to face them. Knights can choose which challenger to fight and can elect to use blunted or sharp weapons. When the five challenging knights fulfil their vow by each breaking five lances, Prince John will declare one the victor, and the victor will pick the Queen of Love and Beauty. The tournament's second day will feature a melee of all knights who wish to fight; the prince will declare a winner for the Queen of Love and Beauty to crown. Archery, bearbaiting, and other amusements will occupy the third day. Then the heralds shout "Largesse, largesse gallant knights," and the wealthy spectators toss gold and silver to them.

As if to confirm the lawlessness and vacuity at the heart of Norman rule, Prince John relies on the military support of mercenaries—soldiers who fight for the highest bidder. Because he leads from a place of weakness rather than strength, Prince John's attempt to show dominance through his proxy backfires. The crowd disrespects him both because the Saxons among it suffer at his hands and because everyone realizes he has no ability to hold the throne he so desperately wants. And yet again, despite emphasizing the humanity of Isaac, Rebecca, and Jewish people in general, the book continues to fall prey to its own prejudicial blind spots when it plays the Jewish religious prohibition against pork products for laughs.

Prince John continues to display the tyrannical and vicious Norman when he insists he sees little if any difference between the universally reviled Jewish people and the oppressed Saxons. Readers should note that, although the book and its characters typically treat Jewish people as foreigners, Isaac and Rebecca are, in fact, English subjects. As the book works to create a space of Englishness between the Saxons and the Normans, Isaac and Rebecca are left out of the equation despite an equal claim to citizenship.



Generosity, or "largesse," to use a word derived from French Norman, was one of the key traits of the nobility in medieval opinion. When the spectators toss coins to the heralds, they proclaim their chivalric values. The rules offer modern readers another reminder that, although this is not an actual war, the tournament presents very real dangers to its participants. This can be read either as supporting chivalric values—since knights who join demonstrate courage—or as an argument against a value system that regularly pitted knights who would otherwise belong to the same group against each other, leading to unnecessary injury and death in the name of proving one's military skill.



All the heralds except the two marshals of the field withdraw. By the time the crowd falls silent, knights wishing to face the challengers cram the staging area. The marshals select the first five by lot and allow them to enter the lists. Templeton assures readers that they were all splendidly dressed and that his source text (“the Wardour Manuscript”) describes their coats of arms in great detail. But he glosses over it because readers won’t recognize the names of once-honored knights who died long ago and whose castles have long since crumbled into dust. These five knights disappoint the spectators when each chooses to fight with blunted weapons; medieval spectators, Templeton opines, loved the violence of the spectacle.

The five knights prepare themselves and descend into the lists. At the sound of the trumpets, they charge. Over the first three rounds, although at least one opponent manages to break Ralph de Vipont’s lance, not one of the challengers falls from his horse. The losers straggle off the field to make arrangements for ransoming their horses and weapons—the spoils which go to the winners—back. On the fourth round, only three knights enter the lists; Sir Brian and Front-de-Boeuf stand unopposed. A long pause follows; it seems few knights remain anxious to test their luck against the challengers.

Cedric, taking each victory for the Norman challengers as a repeated triumph over the honor of true (Saxon) Englishmen, grows increasingly irate. He darts looks at Athelstane as if he wishes that man would stand for the honor of his country, but Athelstane shows no interest in meeting the challengers on the field. He plans to wait until the second day’s melee. The crowd grows restive, and Prince John begins to consider calling the end of the tournament early.

Then, a single knight, of medium build and bearing a shield decorated with an uprooted **oak** tree and the Spanish word “Desdichado,” or “disinherited” on it, rides into the arena. The Disinherited Knight salutes the crowd graciously as he rides down the lists on a splendid black horse to touch the point of his lance (signifying sharp weapons) on Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert’s shield. He and Sir Brian trade harsh words, then prepare to joust.

Templeton’s careful selection of detail to include in his modern edition of an alleged medieval story (remember that Templeton and the Wardour Manuscript are both part of the book’s fiction) contributes to his argument about the potential use (or misuse) of historical fiction. Choosing carefully what to include or exclude may miss important historical details, but it keeps readers interested and emotionally invested in the important characters—Ivanhoe, Richard, Prince John, and Rebecca.



In medieval tournaments, a victorious knight claimed as forfeit whatever horses, armor, and weapons his defeated challenger brought onto the field with him. Knights could choose to keep these valuable items or to ransom them back to their owners for quick cash. Tournaments thus provided a way for skilled-but-penniless knights (like Ivanhoe, recently returned from the disaster of the Third Crusade) to make quick money. Again, this fact makes an equivocal case for chivalry. On the one hand, it allows knights a clear victory without necessarily having to shed blood. But on the other hand, it cheapens the ideals of courage and valor by reducing them to spectacle and economic opportunism.



Cedric’s reactions remind readers that the tournament stands—at the very least for Sir Brian, Prince John, and Cedric—as a referendum on the Norman right to rule (and oppress) the Saxons. And Norman Sir Brian is clearly winning. In contrast, Athelstane proves his unworthiness for the throne, since he lacks any bravery or Saxon pride. The book thus continues to point to the power vacuum that only King Richard can fill.



Yet again, the oak on the Disinherited Knight’s shield connects to Saxon identity and Cedric’s household; the mysterious knight’s name and the symbolism of the uprooted tree should suggest to readers (if not the crowd at the tournament) that this knight is the doubly disinherited Saxon knight Ivanhoe. Still anonymous for the moment, however, the Disinherited Knight’s actions establish his clash with Sir Brian as a referendum on chivalry, with the Disinherited Knight representing bravery, strength, and nobility.



The crowd watches with excitement as the knights prepare to charge; although few expect the Disinherited Knight to win, they love his courage and gallantry. On the first charge, neither falls from his horse. In the second charge, although Sir Brian remains in the saddle, his horse falls to the ground. He springs to his feet and draws his sword before the field marshal intervenes, reminding the competitors that the tournament's rules prevent hand-to-hand combat. Disgraced and defeated, Sir Brian retreats to his tent while the Disinherited Knight addresses the crowd, calling this a victory for English honor against foreign tyrants. Then he bests Sir Front-de-Boeuf, Philip Malvoisin, De Grantmesnil, and Ralph de Vipont in turn to become the day's victor.

Although he's faced three challengers already, Sir Brian's strength and skill help him withstand the Disinherited Knight's charge. Although he loses the match when he falls from his horse, he remains unharmed and leaps to his feet, ready to continue the battle. But his thirst for blood and victory betrays him, pushing him beyond the bounds of knightly restraint. This not only embarrasses him, but it also reminds readers that a disregard for the rules characterizes the Norman bullies generally. Still, five of them cannot defeat the Disinherited Knight, suggesting the inherent superiority of the man behind the disguise.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 9

The field marshals congratulate the Disinherited Knight and ask him to show his face. He politely declines. Used to knights making all sorts of vows, including remaining incognito, the marshals don't argue. But Prince John, irritated that his champions have been embarrassed in the field, doesn't share their forgiving attitude. He demands that someone identify the knight. Waldemar Fitzurse guesses that he may be one of Richard I's companions, recently returned from Palestine. This sparks a rumor that the knight might be King Richard, although Fitzurse points out that he's far too short and slim to be the king himself.

The Disinherited Knight's refusal to show his face continues to suggest that he is, in fact, Ivanhoe. And the general acceptance of knights fighting incognito points to the capricious nature of medieval chivalry that might argue against its nobility. At best, disguises, no matter their reason, conceal the truth. Prince John doesn't care so much about potential dishonesty as he does about asserting his power. In this way, the Disinherited Knight's disguise becomes not just an act of self-preservation, but also one of defiance against Norman abuses of power.



During this argument, the marshals escort the Disinherited Knight into Prince John's presence to receive the prize war-horse and select the Queen of Love and Beauty. Prince John places a green and gold crown on the tip of the knight's lance, charging him with presenting it to the chosen lady. And if he needs a suggestion, the prince points to Fitzurse's daughter, Alicia—perhaps to drive from his companions' minds his recent praise for Rebecca, perhaps to flatter Alicia herself, perhaps so that the Disinherited Knight will anger Fitzurse if he chooses another lady.

Again, in suggesting Alicia, Prince John tries to assert his authority over the tournament as part of his attempt to lay claim to the throne. The Knight's refusal to play along demonstrates John's real lack of power, however. It also fails to endear him either to the Saxon population (which might naturally prefer Rowena) or to his advisors.



The Disinherited Knight rides around the lists, pausing beneath the seats of his most animated admirers—Cedric can hardly stand the excitement of watching so many hated Normans overthrown; Isaac recognizes the horse and armor he took responsibility for when he facilitated its loan for the Palmer and he worries that he will become responsible for its cost. After a moment's pause, the Disinherited Knight lowers his lance and crowns Rowena. Although some of the Norman ladies mutter to find a Saxon elevated to a position they covet, most of the audience cheers loudly for Rowena.

Isaac provides an important clue to the Disinherited Knight's identity when he confirms what readers may have already suspected: the Palmer and the Knight are the same man. This moment connects the Disinherited Knight to Rowena, hinting at romantic attachment (again pointing toward Ivanhoe), but it also objectifies feminine beauty, turning it into an arena of contest between men—the Prince who wanted to pick and the victor who gets to.



Prince John rides across the lists, pausing to comment loudly about the slight to Alicia in a clumsy (and failed) attempt to ingratiate himself with Fitzurse. Then he addresses Rowena in Norman. Cedric replies in Saxon that she doesn't understand the language; on behalf of her, himself, and Athelstane, he declines the invitation to dine with the prince that day, as does the Disinherited Knight. Cranky and offended, the prince rides off the lists, venting his ire on the same yeoman archer he exchanged words with earlier. With his departure, the crowds begin to disperse. The Disinherited Knight swiftly retreats to a pavilion offered to him by the field marshals. Here he rests through the night.

Waldemar Fitzurse becomes a deeply ambiguous character in the novel because of moments like this one: John's overreach offends Fitzurse's natural sense of aristocratic values, but although he chides the prince publicly, his craven desire for power overrules his better judgment and keeps him in league with this deeply flawed and ignoble man. On the other hand, Cedric's outright rejection of John's company emphasizes his lack of the real power and charisma necessary to unite the Saxons and the Normans.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 10

Attendants show the Disinherited Knight to a pavilion and, out of a mix of professionalism and curiosity, offer to help him doff his armor. He refuses the help of any but his own attendant, who turns out to be Gurth in disguise. Soon the squires of the five challengers come to the tent with their masters' forfeited horses and armor. The Disinherited Knight ransoms all but Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert's for 100 gold coins each; he tells Sir Brian's squire to remind his master that he and the Disinherited Knight have unfinished business since Sir Brian drew his sword against the Disinherited Knight in the lists. Then the Knight counts some of the coins into a purse and sends Gurth into town to repay his debt to Isaac.

Gurth's presence all but confirms that the Disinherited Knight is Ivanhoe, since no one else could have persuaded the loyal servant to abandon his master. Obeying the customs of chivalry, the challengers send their forfeited goods to the Knight, and he shows himself to be a man of principles when he ransoms the items at a reasonable rate and immediately sends Gurth to discharge his own debt. In contrast to Sir Brian's loss of control in the lists, the Knight proves himself responsible and in control of himself, suggesting yet again the inherent superiority of the Saxons to their Norman conquerors.



Isaac and Rebecca sit in the opulently decorated house of a Jewish family that lives in Ashby—Jewish people, Templeton informs readers, were as liberal in hosting each other as they were miserly towards Christians. Isaac paces, anxiously complaining about Prince John taking his purse of 50 gold coins. When Gurth appears, he bargains hard with the swineherd-turned-squire, settling the Disinherited Knight's debt at 80 coins plus the return of the horse. Isaac argues with himself while counting out the last ten coins, in a way that suggests that his avarice compels him to overcharge the Knight.

Again, the contrast between the helplessness and poverty Isaac claims whenever he's in the presence of powerful Saxon and Norman lords contrasts sharply with the opulence and riches he seems to command. In a way, this moment shows him taking advantage of a noble Saxon just as much as the despised Normans. The contrast between the two sides of Isaac feeds on and contributes to the antisemitic stereotypes which led to persecution and violence against Jewish people in the Middle Ages and beyond.



While Isaac counts the money, Rebecca slips from the room. When Gurth leaves, she appears at his elbow out of the dark and hands him a bag with 100 gold coins, telling him that he should return to the Disinherited Knight his payment of 80 and keep the rest himself. Gleeful at the prospect of earning 30 coins—ten from his master and now 20 from Rebecca—Gurth takes the purse, eagerly imagining the day he can buy his own freedom.

Rebecca's generosity aligns her (both in terms of values and in terms of where she puts her money and effort) more with the Christians noblemen than her Jewish father. Although she holds steadfastly to her Jewish faith throughout the novel and comes across as noble and exceptionally conscientious for truly living up to values that many others only pay lip service to (like justice, faith, honesty, and generosity) the contrast between her actions and her father's still serves to perpetuate antisemitic stereotypes that cast Jewish people as unnaturally greedy.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 11

Gurth tries to hurry back to the Disinherited Knight through the sounds of merriment and disorder in town, but he loses his way and stumbles into a lane overhung by a gnarled old **oak** tree. A band of robbers seizes him and drags him into a forest clearing. Gurth offers them his 30 gold coins in exchange for his life and his master's money, which they soon find in his purse. Gurth explains that he's the Disinherited Knight's squire, that the Knight ransomed all the challengers' arms except Sir Brian's, and that when he tried to repay his master's debt to Isaac, the Jewish man instead gave *him* 100 coins. The idea of a moneylender willingly parting from his money in this way astonishes the thieves.

As the thieves count the money in Gurth's purse, he takes advantage of their distracted attention to attack their leader, but they quickly subdue him once more. They discuss what to do among themselves. Their leader suggests they let Gurth and his money go, since they and the Disinherited Knight all oppose the likes of Sir Brian. One thief demands the right to fight Gurth first with wooden staves; and after a good fight, Gurth dispatches him with a solid blow to the head. The captain of the band of thieves congratulates Gurth and offers him safe passage, on the promise that he never try to ascertain their identities nor tell anyone that they let him escape. Some of the thieves take Gurth back towards the tournament grounds, where he relays his astonishing adventures to the Disinherited Knight.

The woodsmen-bandits meet at oak trees because the oak trees symbolize Englishness, and the woodsmen-bandits are primarily Saxons. But the trees also symbolize strength and resilience, and these bandits are borrowed from the mythology of Robin Hood and his merry men, who stole from the rich (Norman nobles) and gave to the poor (Saxon subjects) during the lawless interlude of King Richard's absence on crusade and Prince John's regency. They make a strong case against the Normans, suggesting that their lawbreaking arises as a direct result of Norman overreach and abuse. And, like other key anti-Norman players (like the Disinherited Knight or the Black Knight), they rely on disguises to hide their identities.



A shared antipathy toward Normans—especially cruel and greedy ones like Sir Brian—unites the Disinherited Knight and the woodsmen. The leader's willingness to return the Knight's money suggests that there may be honor among thieves. Knights aren't the only ones with a code to live up to; in the lawlessness and violence of a country that lacks a strong, unifying leader to uphold justice, people cobble together the best ethical and legal systems they can. Thus, though one of the thieves fights Gurth, the band doesn't hold it against him when he wins.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 12

On the second day of the tournament, knights jostle to join sides for the open battle, a more popular option than individual challenges, especially among knights who lack the confidence to face renowned challengers. Sir Brian captains one group which includes De Bracy and other followers of Prince John. Cedric discovers, much to his dismay, that Athelstane has opted to join Sir Brian. Athelstane refuses to admit his reason to Cedric, but he's upset that the Disinherited Knight paid attention to Rowena, whom Athelstane himself expects to marry, even though his indolent nature has prevented him from doing anything to gain her attention or affection.

Questions arise about the value of chivalry on the second day of the tournament, which attracts knights (including Athelstane) who are interested in glory but not brave enough to face the scrutiny of individual battles and a very public defeat. Further, he supports Sir Brian, who represents an ignoble form of Norman chivalry. Athelstane's possessive attitude toward Rowena, despite his lackluster attention to wooing her, points to the vulnerable, objectified position of women in this book.



When Rowena arrives, Prince John assumes the gallant, courteous attitude that comes easily when he's in a good mood. He escorts Rowena to her throne and other noble ladies vie for positions close to her. After a blast of trumpets, the heralds call for silence so they can proclaim the tournament's rules, designed to make the inherently dangerous enterprise somewhat safer and to ensure a fair fight—for example, knights on horseback cannot attack unhorsed combatants. Any vanquished knights forfeit their horses and arms to their vanquishers. Prince John will end the fight at his command, and any knights breaking the rules or the code of chivalry will be expelled and dishonored.

After surveying the arrayed knights and confirming that the two sides are even, the field marshal thunders “Laissez aller!” and the knights break into movement, clashing in the middle of the field so furiously that their cloud of dust initially obscures the battle. When it settles, all the lances have been shattered and many knights have been unhorsed. The battle rages fiercely, with Sir Brian's men rallying to the cry of “for the Temple” and the Disinherited Knight's chanting “Desdichado!” The ladies watch the combat with no less relish than the men, although occasionally they might cry out or pale a little if they see a brother, lover, or husband injured.

The general crush and confusion of the mock battle frustrates the early attempts of Sir Brian and the Disinherited Knight to single each other out. But when injury and forfeit have thinned the ranks, they cross their swords furiously, to the delight and excitement of all the onlookers. Sir Front-de-Boeuf and Athelstane simultaneously decide to ride to Sir Brian's aid, and they bear down on the Disinherited Knight from opposite directions. The shouts of the crowd alert him and he avoids the charge, yet still finds himself facing three furious opponents.

The outnumbered Disinherited Knight seems to face grave danger and people in the crowd begin to suggest that Prince John end the fight. He refuses, content to allow Sir Brian to get his revenge on the upstart stranger. But then, a mysterious knight in black armor (subsequently called the Black Knight), named “The Black Sluggard” by the crowd because he has not fought much yet, rides to the Disinherited Knight's aid. After dealing decisive blows to Athelstane and Front-de-Boeuf, he retreats, leaving the Knight to defeat Sir Brian. Only when his favored champion seems to be in grave danger does Prince John end the fight and declare the Black Sluggard the winner. The crowd objects loudly, but he insists, only declaring the Disinherited Knight the rightful winner when it becomes clear that the Black Sluggard has disappeared.

Although Prince John never dons an actual disguise, the book criticizes his disingenuous nature. While the disguises of the Black and Disinherited Knights showcase rather than hide the truth, Prince John's thin veneer of courtesy cannot hide his cowardice and weakness. The rules of the melee simultaneously highlight chivalric values like having a fair fight while also calling into question these values, since all the knights in the melee risk financial and physical ruin just to show off their fighting skills.



Tournaments feature fighting nearly as intense as outright war, raising questions about whether chivalric virtue provides a net benefit to society or not. The bloodthirsty attention of the ladies suggests that the violence chivalric virtue encourages might outweigh its more positive values. As on the tournament's first day, the second day's melee proves to be a testing ground for the claims of Norman vs. Saxon supremacy, embodied in Sir Brian and the Disinherited Knight.



In this Norman-on-Saxon contest, Saxon Athelstane joins with Norman Front-de-Boeuf and Sir Brian thanks to his injured sense of romantic pride. His misaligned priorities suggest that he is not a viable contender to the throne, even compared to the ill-suited Prince John. The rules of chivalry also don't prevent three knights from ganging up on the Disinherited Knight, suggesting the limits of chivalry as a value system.



Normans (plus Athelstane) press their advantage unfairly against the Disinherited Knight, and Prince John's initial refusal to follow the tournament rules (and the will of the audience) points toward Norman aggression and his inability to enforce the rule of law. He only gets involved when he fears one of his friends and necessary supporters might be injured, betraying his—and most of the Normans'—true motive: self-interest. Even then, he hesitates to crown the Disinherited Knight the victor, betraying not just selfishness but pettiness—he still holds it against the Disinherited Knight for embarrassing him the previous day when picking the queen. Although readers will later discover more about the Black Knight's reasons for obscuring his identity, his mask also shows humility—he fights for the glory of it and to protect Ivanhoe without needing any recognition from the crowd or the prince.



The field marshals conduct the victor to Prince John, who declares him the winner but insists that he remove his helmet for Rowena to crown him. Over his weak protests, the prince's attendants cut away the helmet to reveal the pale and blood-streaked yet handsome face of Cedric's disinherited son, Ivanhoe. No sooner has Rowena crowned him than he faints. The field marshals, removing his armor, discover that he has been wounded severely in battle.

Finally, the book confirms that the Disinherited Knight is Ivanhoe. Notably, despite Prince John's attempts to behave with chivalric decorum, Ivanhoe's unmasking is itself an act of aggression on the part of the Normans, who reveal him against his wishes. Even—or especially—in defeat, the Normans show themselves to be unprincipled bullies.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 13

Prince John has suspected since the day before that the mysterious knight was one of his enemies, like his brother King Richard's beloved friend Ivanhoe. De Bracy remarks that Front-de-Boeuf will be unhappy to have to relinquish his land, which Richard granted to Ivanhoe but which the prince gave to his own supporter during Richard I's absence. The Normans in the crowd support Prince John's right to dispose of English lands as he sees fit—since all of them either currently benefit from his largesse or hope to someday. Fitzurse, returning from the field, remarks that Ivanhoe poses little threat to Front-de-Boeuf as his wound may very well prove fatal. Although Ivanhoe represents a threat to the usurper Prince John, the rules of chivalry prevail, and the prince orders his own royal physicians to attend to Ivanhoe.

Ivanhoe's sudden appearance casts light on the Normans' abuse of power: not only has Prince John seized the throne in King Richard's absence, but he has taken the lands which Richard gave to his supporters—who evidently include Saxons as well as Normans—and redistributed them to his own supporters. Unable to lay claim to the throne through his own virtue, he must resort to such low handed bribery. And much of the country's lawlessness grows from this lack of morality on John's part, since it allows self-interest to flourish.



But Prince John's physicians won't be needed, Fitzurse explains; Ivanhoe's people have already taken him into their care. Fitzurse describes with appreciation the fortitude Rowena displayed upon discovering her beloved Ivanhoe in such a state. Prince John retorts that he'll cheer her sorrows by wedding her to a Norman (claiming his right as sovereign to have the final say in noble marriages), and he selects De Bracy as the lucky groom. De Bracy says he appreciates Rowena's beauty—and the large land holdings she will bring to her husband.

Although it seems like John's change of heart might point toward the value of chivalry as an organizing principle, the prince delays so long that his empty offer of help becomes moot. And he immediately turns back to oppressing the Normans around him, asserting his right to force Rowena to marry one of his supporters. Although this will further indebt de Bracy to Prince John, it's unlikely to endear him to the already-oppressed Saxon majority. And it denies Rowena the right to make her own choices in love.



Before Prince John can make immediately good on his threat, a messenger arrives with a sealed letter from the King of France warning him that "the devil is unchained." He shows the letter to De Bracy and Fitzurse, who encourage him to wrap up the tournament expeditiously so that they can withdraw to York and prepare for King Richard's return and the political showdown it will cause.

Prince John rules has displaced his brother with deceit; he cannot oppose King Richard in open contest because he lacks his brother's chivalric virtue. The King of France sends him a warning because, historically, Prince John and King Philip II of France did conspire to keep Richard imprisoned, knowing that he would overtake Prince John in England and then try to reconquer his family's territory in France if he were released.



Anxious to vent his frustration yet again, Prince John seizes the opportunity to pick on the yeoman archer (who now introduces himself as Locksley) who angered the prince on the previous day. John tells the crowd he will judge the archery contest before prematurely closing the tournament. Eight archers step forward, and Prince John compels Locksley to face the victor. Locksley easily bests the man, first by splitting an arrow he lodged in the bullseye, then by challenging him to hit a thin willow branch at 60 yards. Prince John declares Locksley the winner and invites him to join the royal guard, but Locksley declines, saying he has vowed to only serve King Richard.

Prince John, unable to assert himself against his brother King Richard, unleashes a petty attack on a middle-class Saxon, betraying his lack of leadership skills or moral sensibilities. But even this backfires on him, demonstrating yet again the inherent superiority of Saxons to their Norman oppressors. Locksley represents a proud band of Saxon nationalism similar to that of Cedric, which rejects the cruelty, pettiness, lawless ambition, and moral emptiness of the Normans, encapsulated in Prince John specifically.



Locksley escapes Prince John's full wrath only because other concerns distract the usurping monarch. As the prince prepares to retire from the lists, he sends a servant into town to borrow a large sum from Isaac.

Prince John's urgent message to Isaac once again suggests his impotence; he lacks the financial resources to face his brother, and he requires bribes of money and power to attract supporters.



VOLUME 1, CHAPTER 14

Prince John returns to the castle at Ashby which he has claimed as his own, even though it properly belongs to an absent crusader. In a show of largesse—and a desperate attempt to increase his low popularity among the people—the prince has invited not only his Norman supporters but also the most important Saxon families. Templeton explains to readers that Prince John cannot disguise his true feelings, even when it would be politic to do so. Still, he manages to keep his laughter to himself when he receives Athelstane and Cedric in their “ancient Saxon garb.” The Normans pass judgement on the Saxons during the meal for unwittingly breaching “several of the arbitrary rules” of Norman table manners and mock them, but jollity and excitement over the day's events generally keep things pleasant for all the guests.

It seems that almost everything Prince John owns comes to him via theft. The Crusaders left Europe on a mission which modern readers could interpret as an act of religious war and colonial aggression. But to medieval Europeans—and likely to most of the book's original audience—theirs was a noble, if futile effort. Therefore, the fact that John steals land and resources not just from oppressed Saxons but from men thought to be doing God's work on earth emphasizes his lawlessness, selfishness, and abuse of power. Likewise, despite the vulnerability of his position, especially when King Richard returns, he can't—or won't—control himself and his courtiers. As a result, they end up further alienating their Saxon guests.



When Prince John eventually proposes a toast to Wilfred of Ivanhoe, Cedric protests that he disinherited his disobedient son and is not yet content to be reconciled with him. He explains to Prince John that Ivanhoe disobeyed his father by joining the court of the Norman King Richard I and consenting to hold as a vassal an estate which his Saxon ancestors held free of oversight. Front-de-Boeuf offensively declares that he'd sooner be called a Saxon than let anyone take the land from him. Cedric replies that any Norman should be honored to be counted a Saxon. This inspires the prince to tell an anti-Saxon joke; Front-de-Boeuf, Malvoisin, Aymer, De Bracy, and Sir Brian join in. An irate Cedric icily declares that Saxons would never treat Norman guests so ungraciously. Besides, he points out, a single Saxon defeated Malvoisin, De Bracy, Brian, Front-de-Boeuf, and others that very day.

Cedric lists his reasons for disinheriting Ivanhoe, which boil down to disapproving of Ivanhoe's attempts to assimilate. Since the book anticipates a future where Norman and Saxon cultures will converge into an English identity, it doesn't judge Ivanhoe so harshly for his choice to serve Richard. Still, because the book also prefers the native Saxons to the interloping Normans, it portrays Cedric's choice to put politics over family sympathetically. And Ivanhoe's victory over four of the Normans' best knights also points to the Saxons' inherent superiority.



Prince John turns to his Norman guests and asks in a faux-astonished voice if they hadn't better get on ships now and return to France before the defeated Saxons get their fighting spirit up. He would continue, but Fitzurse counsels him to respect his guests' feelings. The prince drinks a toast to Cedric and one to Athelstane. But Prince John doesn't know when to stop. In return for his courtesy, he demands Cedric name a Norman to whose health he would drink. Cedric, still fuming over the insulting treatment he's received, drinks to the health of King Richard. In the consternation that follows, Cedric and Athelstane bid their host good night and depart.

When Prior Aymer tries to follow the Saxons, Prince John frets about his supporters abandoning him. Fitzurse follows the monk to convince him to remain by Prince John's side. The prince casts blame on his counselors for advising him poorly and expresses his fear over King Richard's impending return, as De Bracy and Fitzurse quietly bemoan the difficulties of advising such a cowardly and indecisive man.

Prince John, feeling comfortable thanks to the superior fighting force and economic might of the ruling Norman minority, continues to mock the Saxons. He might be a terrible ruler, but if he gives the Norman nobility what they want (which includes the rights to take what they want and mistreat native Saxons), they will support him. Only the return of his brother truly threatens his reign. And it's this very possibility that Cedric raises with his toast, naming the one Norman capable of earning the Saxons' trust.



Aymer demonstrates the weakness of Prince John's grasp on power: the loss of any one of his supporters may be fatal to his cause. And instead of taking responsibility for the flaws of his character or his political mistakes, John turns on his advisors. To whatever extent chivalry exists as a force for good in the world, John's selfish devotion to his own interests removes it from his reach.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 1

Waldemar Fitzurse spends the evening enticing all of Prince John's followers with the inducements—from money to promises of power to threats of the wrath of King Richard—necessary to ensure their support for the upstart monarch when he confronts his brother and attempts to consolidate his power. Late that night, worn out and exhausted, he returns to the Castle of Ashby, where he encounters De Bracy, dressed up in green like an English yeoman.

De Bracy confides in Fitzurse that he plans to get himself a wife "after the manner of the tribe of Benjamin," referring to a rather embellished version of a story from the Biblical book of Judges that Prior Aymer told the company the previous evening. In it, the Israelites kidnap hundreds of virgins to marry the young men of the tribe of Benjamin. De Bracy and Sir Brian plan to kidnap Rowena while disguised as Englishmen. Then, De Bracy will change his clothes and "rescue" Rowena from her captors, immediately marrying her.

Prince John, with no personal valor, justice, or leadership capabilities, has few qualifications for leading England, although he feels entitled to do so. In the same way, the Normans invade from France and then act as if it's their right to overrun the country and take its wealth and resources. Without qualifications, John resorts to bribery and wheedling. Although at some points Fitzurse represents what little chivalry exists in John's morally corrupt court, his desire for power overwhelms his better nature in moments like this—calling into question the power of chivalry as a social force.



De Bracy now adopts a disguise. Throughout the book, disguises tend to reveal the truth even as (or perhaps because) they obscure a person's identity—in dressing up as a Saxon woodsman, Fitzurse shows himself to be greedy, selfish, and domineering. Wanting to marry Rowena from some combination of her beauty and her wealth, he plans to kidnap and force her to wed him.



Fitzurse warns De Bracy that Sir Brian may not relinquish the beauty so quickly, even if his Templar vows technically require a monk's celibacy of him. And, he continues, Prince John can hardly afford to alienate important Saxon families and their supporters on the eve of conflict with King Richard. But De Bracy refuses to be dissuaded from his plan and he bids Fitzurse a hasty good night. Fitzurse mutters to himself about the difficulty of pursuing his own political agenda while assuaging such childish and impulsive men as De Bracy and Prince John.

Fitzurse creates dissent among the members of John's court as he points out the ways in which each fails to act nobly; both Sir Brian and Prince John will look to their own interests before they support de Bracy's attempt to steal himself a wife. It seems that the Norman brand of chivalry cares more about the appearance of virtue and deploying martial skill in the services of political ambition than in truly cultivating values like loyalty, generosity, justice, and protecting others.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 2

The story returns to the Black Knight, whom readers last saw fading into the crowd after helping Ivanhoe achieve his victory in the tournament. He had left the area early the next morning, but the winding paths of the country have frustrated his progress. When he drops the reins in frustration and fatigue, his horse carries him straightaway to an isolated hermitage and ruined chapel deep in the woods. Thanking St. Julian, the patron saint of travelers, the Black Knight dismounts and pounds on the hermitage door. The hermit within (who soon identifies himself as the Cleric of Copmanhurst) rebuffs the Black Knight's request for shelter. They argue back and forth with each becoming angrier until the Black Knight threatens to break down the door, and the hermit—and his dogs—promise to fend him off if he does.

The book turns immediately from bad examples of chivalry and its values (as the behavior of Sir Brian, Fitzurse, de Bracy demonstrates) to one of its best depictions of a good knight: the Black Knight. Like the Disinherited Knight, his identity remains a secret at this point, but readers know that he protects the vulnerable (saving Ivanhoe from likely death at the tournament), fights for honor rather than reward, and craves adventure—that's why he's riding deep into the woods. What's more, he doesn't seem to fear encountering any of the local bandits, suggesting his bravery and strength. The description and setting of the forest chapel pulls the book out of a more historical mode and into one drawn straight from medieval romance, a world where wandering knights rely on the kindness of hermits for shelter. But the Cleric's initially rude rebuff keeps the book from wandering too far from its realistic style.



Finally, the Cleric of Copmanhurst opens the door. He is a large, strongly-built man; he brandishes a club in one hand and a torch in the other. When he sees the Black Knight's armor, he checks his anger somewhat, calls off his dogs, and begs the knight's forgiveness for his churlish attitude, which he attributes to his fear of bandits. Inside the simple hut, the two men regard each other cautiously, each thinking that he's rarely seen a larger or stronger man than the other. Finally, the hermit shows the knight where he can put himself and his horse for the night, then hands him some beans for his supper.

Although he's not exactly in disguise (at no point does the book say that he isn't actually a monk), the Cleric's physical composition certainly suggests that there's more to his life than fasting and prayer. Thus, this initial meeting in the forest pits two disguised (or quasi-disguised) men against each other, and each sizes the other up carefully, looking for the truth that the disguise might reveal. At this moment, though, each can only see the other's strength, leading to a cautious stalemate.



In order to eat, the Black Knight must doff his helmet and reveal his face, which features bright blue eyes, a handsome moustache, and a look of intelligence and determination. In response, the Cleric pushes back his own hood, revealing a ruddy face and thick black hair. The Black Knight expresses his surprise that the hermit could have grown so hale and hearty on such plain fare, and the Cleric remarks that he might have some richer food in the house. From a hidden hole in the wall, the hermit retrieves a fine venison pastry, although he claims his “keeper”—the local nobleman—left it there two months earlier. With a twinkle in his eye, the Black Knight remarks that the venison seems fresh enough to have been killed within the week.

On the Black Knight’s invitation, the Cleric falls to eating the pastry with relish, and when they’ve had their fill, he retrieves wine from the hidden cupboard. He pours two cups and offers the knight a hearty, Saxon “waes hael!” Then the Black Knight suggests that a man as large and strong as the Cleric might make a good living for himself by poaching the deer in the forest. Affronted, the Cleric swears he would never engage in that illegal activity, which carries a death sentence for those found guilty. He warns the knight that he will defend himself if necessary and retrieves two swords from a second hiding place, where they lie with an assortment of swords and bows and one harp. Stooping to retrieve the instrument, the Black Knight apologizes for asking the Cleric impertinent questions and states his preference to compete in singing rather than fighting.

VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 3

With some difficulty, the Black Knight wrangles the harp back into tune, then asks the Cleric if he prefers a Southern French *sirvente*, a Northern French *lai*, or an English ballad. Protesting that he’s an Englishman through and through, the hermit opts for the last. And although the Black Knight is an amateur, his voice carries the mark of excellent instruction in the musical arts. He sings a song about a crusader returning from Palestine. This crusader stands beneath his lady’s window at twilight and tells her that he has returned bearing no treasure but his own weapons and intact honor. He tells her how his love for her inspired such brave fighting that foreign minstrels sing of her glory and her beauty, even though her knight remains anonymous. He begs her to open the gate and let him in and to reward him for his efforts.

The physical description of the Black Knight might provide readers familiar with British history and folklore with a hint about his identity, as this description recalls the features of Richard I—the currently dispossessed but rightful king. As if in answer to his necessary act of unveiling, the Cleric also reveals something about himself—not yet his identity, but his face, which proves definitively that he doesn’t live the ascetic life of a monk. Thus, it’s not fully surprising when he pulls good food and fine wine (and seems to have a store of weapons) in the house. Readers should begin to suspect that he may be connected with the local Saxon woodsmen-bandits.



The book has thus far avoided identifying the Black Knight as Saxon or Norman, but it becomes clear here that he understands Saxon, which implies a sympathy to their plight, if not membership in the group himself. The Cleric clearly poaches, or illegally hunts, deer in forests designated for royal or noble use. His willingness to defend himself sounds proud rather than abashed, as if he takes pleasure in stealing from the Normans because they are Norman. This points to the lawlessness and anarchy of England under Norman rule—especially Prince John’s.



The Black Knight’s love of singing—and his familiarity with the love-songs of France—again points toward King Richard, whose great-great grandfather was a famous southern French duke and poet and whose mother Eleanor of Aquitaine, patronized poets. If he is indeed the missing king, his familiarity with Saxon (incidentally, a historical fiction on the novel’s part as current understanding suggests that King Richard could not understand the language of the majority of his subjects) points to a much more positive attitude toward the native Saxons than his brother and his brother’s friends (like Sir Brian) have. The song he sings speaks of courtly love and chivalric value: in it, an unnamed knight (who may or may not represent Ivanhoe) returns from crusade penniless but with intact honor he offers as a gift to his beloved lady.



The Cleric listens with attention and appreciation, although he lightly criticizes the song for its chivalric—by implication Norman—theme of love and war. A Saxon song, he alleges, would see the knight returning to find that his sweetie had pragmatically given up on him rather than love him from afar. He takes the harp and sings a rousing song about a “Barefooted Friar” who entertains absent knights’ ladies and who receives rich hospitality, good food, and excellent wine wherever he goes. The Black Knight appreciates the song and teases the hermit about his own taste for “uncanonical pastimes.” The pair jovially exchange songs late into the night.

Although up to this point the Knight and the Cleric have been conversing in Saxon, the song betrays the Knight’s Norman identity. And as elsewhere, the book characterizes the Normans as excessively concerned with feelings, style, and aesthetics, while the Saxons are direct, practical, and manly. Although the Cleric seems to have many of the same vices as Prior Aymer, the book depicts him more positively since he has Saxon rather than Norman heritage and because he refuses to hide behind a veneer of holiness.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 4

Now the story returns to the household of Cedric, whose paternal instincts nearly lead him to cry out when Ivanhoe’s face is revealed at the tournament. He checks the impulse, unwilling to so publicly welcome his renounced and disinherited child. Still, he orders Oswald to see Ivanhoe carried safely to Ashby for medical care. But when the crowd disperses, Ivanhoe has disappeared. Oswald and Gurth search fruitlessly until witnesses tell them that some well-dressed servants of some unnamed lady bore the knight away. Confident in his son’s safety, Cedric can once again indulge the anger and pride that led him to cast Ivanhoe out in the first place. In a pique, he and Athelstane leave for Prince John’s banquet, which the book has already described.

Cedric’s feelings belie the harsh stance he takes toward his son, suggesting that even his stalwart support of the Saxon cause can be modified. Still, his pride (and the need for the Saxons to present a unified front if they are to prevail against their Norman oppressors) checks his impulse toward reconciliation. It’s becoming increasingly clear that the only path for England (or the domestic world of Cedric’s family) to return to order lies in a compromise between or unification of Norman and Saxon interests.



Upon his return from the banquet, in a fouler mood than when he left, Cedric finally notices Gurth, away from Rotherwood without his master’s permission. He orders his men to handcuff the swineherd, and the party prepares to travel to their evening accommodations at a nearby Saxon convent. The following morning, just as they set out, they encounter the bad omen—Templeton informs readers that the Saxons were much more superstitious than the Normans—of a black dog barking at the gates. Noting that it’s unlucky to travel after a “monk, a hare, or a howling dog” crosses one’s path (or possibly just wanting more of the convent’s fine ale), Athelstane suggests they tarry another day there.

Like Prince John, Cedric sometimes suffers from excessive pride that leads him to punish undeserving victims, in this case Gurth, who earned his wrath by serving the disinherited and disowned Ivanhoe. The bad omen at the gates suggests that Cedric won’t get away with his bad behavior. It also points to the superstition that distinguishes the medieval era from the 19th century, in Templeton’s opinion. Meanwhile, Athelstane again shows his unreadiness to fight for the throne. The joining of Saxon and Norman forces seems increasingly necessary to resolve these unsettled times.



Cedric recognizes the dog as Gurth’s hound Fangs. Enraged, he hurls his spear at the animal, narrowly missing him. Tears spring into Gurth’s eyes and Wamba, riding with him at the rear of the group, wipes them away. Finally, Gurth begs his friend the jester to take a message to Cedric renouncing his service. Gurth can no longer serve such a hard-hearted man in good conscience. Wamba refuses the task and tries to soothe Gurth’s wounded feelings instead.

The alarming dog, it turns out, has a very rational explanation and isn’t a bad omen at all. Gurth’s unfair punishment parallels the way that the Normans unfairly oppress the Saxons and suggests that allowing either group sole dominance won’t solve England’s problems. Wamba’s refusal to accept Gurth’s zero-sum solution suggests that compromise is the only way forward.



In the front of the train, Cedric and Athelstane eagerly discuss the feuds and quarrels of the Norman nobility and the chances of the Saxons revolting against their oppressors. Cedric wants nothing more, but it requires the Saxons to unite behind one leader. Cedric himself would make an excellent choice, but he bears no personal political ambitions, and prefers to advance the cause of Athelstane and Rowena, who descends from the popular Saxon king Alfred. Cedric wants to unite the Saxons behind both by achieving the marriage of his ward Rowena to Athelstane, but Ivanhoe's absence hasn't diminished the love she feels for him and she refuses to marry anyone else. Although Cedric could force the issue as her male guardian, he habitually defers to her desires and cannot bring himself to overrule her in this area.

Just as Cedric cannot beguile Rowena with the prospect of a queen's throne, he also fails to excite Athelstane to action. Although Athelstane relishes the respect of his Saxon underlings and fondly imagines his life as their ruler after they achieve independence, he has no interest in helping them to achieve it, no matter how hard Cedric presses him. When he tires of Athelstane's company and decides to try his luck with Rowena, he finds that lady and her favorite maid rehearsing Athelstane's poor performance in the lists. Thus, Cedric passes a frustrating day of riding.

VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 5

Having tarried too long over their midday meal, Cedric and his party find themselves on the verge of the bandit-plagued woods near nightfall. Still, they press on, trusting both in the sympathy of the mainly Saxon outlaws and their own strength. They hear cries of distress and soon come upon Isaac and Rebecca next to an abandoned horse litter. Isaac explains that he hired six bodyguards to convey himself, his daughter, and their injured friend through the woods, but when these bodyguards heard a report about a large band of armed outlaws, they took the horses and ran, abandoning Isaac and Rebecca to their fate. Isaac asks if they might join Cedric's party, and although Cedric denies them this boon, he does offer to have two of his men escort father and daughter to the nearest town.

Rowena seconds Cedric's plan until Rebecca appeals to her personally. Then Rowena insists that they be allowed to join the company and asks Rebecca to ride next to her. In the party's haste to rearrange themselves, Wamba loosens Gurth's bonds, and he quietly slips away into the woods. When Cedric's attendants notice his absence, they decide to let the bandits take care of him rather than look for him themselves.

Cedric plays a zero-sum game, hoping that the currently oppressed Saxons may one day emerge victorious over their Norman oppressors. But to achieve this, every member of the disempowered Saxon race must work together and willingly sacrifice their own interests for the group. Cedric modeled this devotion when he disowned Ivanhoe. But already readers should realize that neither Rowena nor Athelstane share Cedric's level of commitment. Thus, the book dooms the Saxon cause before it can try anything. Again, the book pushes toward compromise—and the fact that Cedric refuses to force Rowena into a marriage she disdains hints that he may have more capacity for compromise than it first appears.



Athelstane likes the attention he gets as the Saxon heir-apparent, but he obviously lacks the leadership skills, or even the foundational warrior virtues of courage, steadfastness, and honor necessary to become an effective ruler. In a backhanded way, his unreadiness makes a strong case for the value of chivalry, since his lackluster performance only makes the performance of the disgraced Ivanhoe and the Black Knight (whom the book strongly suggests is King Richard) look better.



Cedric's bravado contrasts sharply with Isaac's and Rebecca's concerns and reminds readers that while ignoble Normans oppress everyone in England who doesn't belong to their group, some people are more vulnerable than others. Cedric shows grudging charity toward the Jewish father once again, betraying the small-minded tribalism that earlier led him to disown his own son. At this point, Cedric cares only for those who are completely aligned with his own views and political agendas. Although he doesn't actively oppress anyone, he's only marginally better than the Normans. In this way, the book yet again points to the limitations of his views and gestures toward its preferred (and the historical) solution of merging the two groups together into a strong English identity.



When Rowena welcomes Rebecca into the group, her action instigates a long series of events that will slowly bring the domestic world of Cedric's family and the broader community of England back to order (although Rebecca herself, as readers will later see, won't fully benefit from these shifts). Gurth's escaping Cedric's wrongful imprisonment is the first of these events.



Soon the path narrows so significantly that the party can hardly ride two across, and where it narrows even further, a band of masked men wearing yeoman's green and shouting "For England!" jump from the undergrowth in attack. Cedric reacts quickly, but rashly, and although he pins his first attacker to an **oak** tree, he overswings his sword against a second and gets it—and himself—stuck in an oak tree. In contrast, the bandits surround and disarm Athelstane before he can even summon the energy to draw his sword. In the confusion, Wamba relieves one of Cedric's trembling servants of his sword, fends off several attackers, and escapes into the undergrowth where he quickly stumbles upon Gurth and Fangs.

Wamba describes the ambush to Gurth, who immediately proposes they rush to Cedric's aid—his anger at his former master as quickly forgotten as it was kindled. But while they debate their next steps, another man orders them to stop. Gurth recognizes the voice of the head bandit he encountered on the tournament's first night; Wamba recognizes the prizes won by the yeoman archer Locksley. The man refuses to identify himself, but he offers to reconnoiter the scene for the pair of Cedric's faithful servants. He returns after a few moments to report that his men cannot take on the bandits without reinforcements, but that the servants should not fear for their master's safety. Promising to help raise the necessary force, Locksley bids Gurth and Wamba to come with him.

VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 6

After a few hours of walking, Locksley, Gurth, and Wamba reach a wide clearing graced by an enormous **oak** tree. The yeomen resting under it snap to attention at the sound of approaching footsteps, dropping their bows only when they hear their leader's voice. He immediately orders the present bandits to rally everyone they can find by daybreak and dispatches two to follow the masquerading bandits and their captives to Front-le-Boeuf's castle, Torquilstone. Then he brings Gurth and Wamba with him to collect one he calls "the friar."

Only supreme confidence in their shared Saxon identity would lead Cedric and his party to risk such a natural ambush point; unfortunately for them, they're not attacked by Saxons but Normans, whose abuse of their power now includes trying to pin their own bad deeds on their Saxon subjects. And the book draws readers' attention to the excellent characterization of both Athelstane and Cedric it provides in this moment, as their actions perfectly encapsulate their personalities—one is too prone to fight, and the other is too slow to arms. Wamba also gets to show his true colors in this moment, revealing a braver (and more competent) man than readers have previously seen.



Deep in the woods, a Saxon rescue party begins to coalesce as Locksley—previously highlighted as the yeoman archer who stood up to Prince John and the gallant bandit who refused to steal from a fellow Saxon—joins Wamba and Gurth. Although the book primarily presents Norman oppression through the experiences of the elite—Rowena, Athelstane, Cedric, and (to a lesser extent) Ivanhoe—Locksley's banditry points to the ways that Norman greed affects all classes of society, even the medieval middle class. Their success or failure will foreshadow the success or failure of the Saxon cause in England.



As the meeting place of the predominantly Saxon would-be rescuers, the oak tree yet again shows up to suggest resilience and Englishness. The book draws a sharp contrast between the general anarchy of Norman oppression and the impressive discipline of Locksley's band. In contrast to the self-interested Prince John and his ambitious followers—or even to the uncompromising Cedric—Locksley shows what unifying leadership looks like.



The trio approaches the hermitage where Wamba expresses surprise to hear the Cleric and the Black Knight loudly singing drinking songs within. Gurth replies that everyone knows the Cleric of Copmanhurst as an accomplished poacher. Inside the hermitage, on hearing Locksley's knock at the door, the Black Knight and the Cleric hasten to disguise themselves and hide away the evidence of their carousing while the Cleric very loudly shouts out a prayer to cover the noise. Locksley identifies himself and the Cleric prepares to open the door.

Despite not knowing much about each other, it's clear that the Cleric and the Black Knight have become fast friends over their evening together, recognizing each other's character despite their mutual disguises. The book repeatedly suggests that a physical disguise cannot hide a person's character, and this affinity born of deception confirms that claim. This, combined with the suspicion that one is Norman while the other is clearly Saxon, suggests the possibility of reconciliation between the dispossessed and oppressor.



Only momentarily taken aback to find a stranger there too, Locksley tells the Cleric to grab his weapons and prepare to join the rest of the "merry men." Then, taking the Cleric aside, Locksley chides him for admitting a stranger into his confidence against the band's rules. The Black Knight interrupts to say that he compelled the Cleric to entertain him. While they talk, the Cleric quickly strips off his brown robe and changes it for a green yeoman's outfit, with Wamba's help. Locksley, meanwhile, recognizes the Black Knight as Ivanhoe's helper on the second day of the tournament. Locksley appeals to the Knight as a true Englishman—the knight promising there can be none truer—and a helper of the weak and asks him to join their party in freeing Cedric and his companions from Torquilstone.

Readers who are familiar with the folklore surrounding Robin Hood may have already recognized the use of Robin Hood's other name, "Locksley;" the reference to the famous robber's "merry men" here provides another hint to his identity, although his disguise has thus far prevented other characters from discerning it. Continuing the theme of vague, half-recognitions, Wamba remembers the Black Knight from the tournament, and when the Knight protests that he is the truest Englishman, he hints at his royal identity. And he announces his intention to join the fight by reference to his chivalric virtues, including defense of the weak.



The Black Knight agrees to join the party and, with the Cleric now dressed in green and washing his face in the fountain to sober up, Wamba wonders at the additions to their party. For his part, Gurth asserts, he would accept the help of the Devil himself to save Cedric and Rowena from their captors. Locksley silences the conversations and insists that they leave quickly; they must gather more forces if they wish to be successful against a man like Reginald Front-de-Boeuf. The Black Knight exclaims in surprise over learning that Torquilstone now belongs to that thieving, oppressive man. Grimly agreeing about the deficits of Front-de-Boeuf's character, Locksley leads the band away from the hermitage.

Although cagy about his identity, the Cleric only dons a disguise when he can no longer rely on the anonymity of the forest to protect him. But, like Locksley and the rest of the bandits, his disguise suggests a larger truth about Norman abuses of Saxon subjects. The Black Knight's surprise at the reappropriation of Torquilstone suggests that he's been away (perhaps on the Third Crusade, like Ivanhoe and Richard) for some time—yet another clue pointing toward his identity. And it also indicates the Norman malice that Prince John embodies.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 7

Now the tale returns to the unfortunate Cedric and his party, whose captors seem so unfamiliar with the countryside that they lose their way until after sunrise. At the head of the group, Sir Brian encourages De Bracy to go change for his role as the rescuing hero, but De Bracy demurs. He wants to escort Rowena all the way to Torquilstone. Sir Brian takes offense at De Bracy's suspicion that he will harm Rowena. The pair trade increasingly shrill, if politely worded, threats. Finally, Sir Brian exclaims that he prefers Rebecca.

The inability of the Norman "bandits" to make their way through the countryside betrays their identities through their disguises. The conflict between de Bracy and Sir Brian illustrates the often-precarious assurance that espoused chivalric virtues will in any meaningful way curb violence and greed. De Bracy admits that Sir Brian behaves, at least superficially, according to the moral and ethical codes of knighthood and his religious vocation as a Templar—but he doesn't trust Sir Brian to follow through.



Elsewhere in the procession, Cedric tries to gain the sympathy he expects in this allegedly English—in other words, Saxon—band of thieves. When he recognizes Torquilstone, the squat and old-fashioned castle currently occupied by Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, he realizes that his captors are disguised Normans. He curses them and begs them to spare Rowena's honor, but they ignore him. Inside the castle, the "bandits" separate Rowena and Rebecca from the rest of the group.

As soon as Cedric understands that his captors are Normans, not Saxons, he clearly expects them to rape Rowena—appeals for her "honor" refer to her virginity, since in both the medieval setting of the story and the early 19th century in which it was written, society explicitly connected a woman's virginity and sexual continence to her worth. But the Normans don't care for honor, and his pleas seem to fall on deaf ears.



Although Athelstane seems undisturbed by the loss of his freedom, except as far as it keeps him from breakfast, imprisonment in this well-known hall makes Cedric indignant. An important moment in the life of Harold, the last Saxon king, played out here as he threatened his rebellious brother, Tosti, with death. Now, Normans imprison Cedric and his Saxon companions in the same room. Even the stained-glass windows annoy Cedric since they point to the enervating influence of Norman style on the Saxons.

Athelstane again demonstrates his lack of connection to the Saxon cause when he frets more about eating than being imprisoned by Normans. Conversely, to Cedric, everything in the present points to the mistakes of the past. In his mind, the Norman invasion began long before 1066, when the Saxon lords began to adopt Norman habits and fashions. He suggests this compromised the Saxons' natural, unadorned power.



Athelstane replies to all of Cedric's complaints with his own querulous meditations on his empty stomach. Finally, Cedric upbraids him in disgust, bemoaning the fact that such a dull spirit occupies a big, strong body—and that the fate of English independence should hang on Athelstane. Just then, masked stewards bring the prisoners' breakfast. Cedric demands that Front-de-Boeuf name their ransom and Athelstane issues a challenge of combat to Front-de-Boeuf. Cedric, believing that at last he's roused Athelstane's fighting spirit, sits down to a hearty meal. While they eat, they hear several blasts of a horn at the gates, the reason for which they cannot discern.

Although not yet ready to drop his plan, Cedric must increasingly face the reality that Athelstane, despite his royal pedigree, makes a poor candidate for king. But Prince John has already shown that royal blood without personal virtue makes a bad king. Even Athelstane's challenge points to his shallow virtue since he doesn't seem to expect Front-de-Boeuf to accept it. Stylistically, Volume two follows each of the captives of Torquilstone in sequence even though the events it covers run in parallel. The recurring sound of a commotion at the gates links each narrative in time.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 8

Unhappy Isaac finds his imprisonment much less agreeable than the Saxons. Guards throw him into a deep, dank prison cell decorated with a rusty fire grate and the moldering bones of other unlucky captives. But, imprisoned, Isaac regains some of the calm he has lacked in other circumstances. Templeton speculates that the Jewish people, so harassed and oppressed on all sides in this era, eventually became used to a certain amount of violence and terror. Moreover, Isaac possesses the "unyielding obstinacy [...] unbending resolution" of his people. Carefully folding his clothing to protect himself from getting dirty, Isaac sits in a corner of the cell and waits with composure for more than three hours.

Templeton offers one of his explanatory asides to readers here, which yet again points toward the violence and abuse that medieval Europeans inflicted on the Jewish people. And while these asides seem to suggest that modern times are better, the book's tendency to blame Isaac individually and Jewish people generally for their mistreatment—even here his description of Jewish resilience shades into negative commentary in "unyielding obstinacy"—suggests that things may not have changed as much as Templeton would like to believe.



At the end of that period, Reginald Front-de-Boeuf and Sir Brian's two "Saracen slaves," dressed like butchers, enter the dungeon. Stripped of his armor and clad only in a simple leather jerkin, Front-de-Boeuf looks even more intimidating. The arrival of these three grim figures so terrifies Isaac that he cannot even offer the humble bow he knows he owes the baron. As one of the servants places a scale at Isaac's feet, Front-de-Boeuf demands 1,000 pounds sterling, or its equivalent in gold, as ransom for his freedom. He ignores Isaac's plea of poverty, citing common knowledge about Jewish people's wealth and their obstinate tendency to cling to their money. If Isaac refuses, the baron threatens, he will die a slow and painful death in that place.

At another command from Front-de-Boeuf, the two servants kindle a fire beneath the grate in the corner of the room, and Front-de-Boeuf threatens to have them roast Isaac alive. Front-de-Boeuf ignores Isaac's appeal to his humanity and pleas for mercy. He suggests that Isaac will soon regain his wealth through bilking other Christians. Finally, he signals to the servants to strip Isaac. Desperate, Isaac says he will raise the money. Front-de-Boeuf promises that he will remain imprisoned until every last ounce has been weighed out right there on the prison floor.

As Front-de-Boeuf doggedly presses Isaac for the ransom, Isaac tries to bargain for Cedric's and Rebecca's freedom. Suddenly, the baron interrupts, saying he assumed Rebecca was Isaac's concubine, so he gave her to Sir Brian as the spoils of conquest. Isaac's enraged and horrified cries fill the dungeon. He throws himself at Front-de-Boeuf's feet, begging the baron to take anything he wants as long as he protects Rebecca's honor. Front-de-Boeuf expresses astonishment over a Jewish man showing love for something other than his "money-bags," and he promises to remember that they love their children, too, in the future. For now, he claims, he can do nothing to change Rebecca's fate. A horrified Isaac swears he will not give Front-de-Boeuf so much as a penny unless his daughter is released unharmed.

Front-de-Boeuf asks if Isaac will even face death for Rebecca, and Isaac swears he will. The baron orders the servants to strip the old man and chain him to the grate. But before they can do so, they hear a commotion at the gate and voices within the castle calling for Front-de-Boeuf.

Sir Brian (hinted at here through his slaves) and Reginald Front-de-Boeuf most thoroughly embody the abuses and bad character which the book assigns to all Normans. And Normans are, the book suggests here, greedy, terrifying, and violent—more like butchers than like knights. The scales in this scene may allude to one of the book's sources, Shakespeare's Merchant of Venice, in which a Jewish moneylender named Shylock demands a pound of flesh as payment from a debtor. Although it's Front-de-Boeuf in this moment who represents avarice, his prejudicial beliefs about Jewish moneylenders and the financial abuse they practice against their Christian debtors underlie his demands.



The contrast between Cedric and Athelstane—both of whom are annoyed but not afraid in their imprisonment—and Isaac highlights the marginalized status of Jewish people in medieval Europe. Isaac's appeals to his humanity here echo those Shylock makes in Shakespeare's Merchant of Venice, but they do not move Front-de-Boeuf to mercy. Instead, the Norman hints that he's within his rights to extort money from Isaac, because Isaac has abused his Christian debtors to make his own fortunes.



Although all the women in Ivanhoe are vulnerable to male violence, Rebecca is doubly so because of her marginalized status as a Jewish woman. Dispossessed of her own nation or country, she depends entirely on the kindness of people who have been trained to hate her and her people. The casual disregard with which Front-de-Boeuf consigns her to her fate with Sir Brian suggests that he considers her far less than human. And his feigned surprise over the fact that Jewish people—like all other human beings—love their children yet again points to antisemitic stereotypes about Jewish greed, which the book seems to criticize and reinforce at the same time.



However much the book plays into antisemitic stereotypes at other points, in this moment, it allows Isaac the dignity to face his death with courage rather than capitulate to Front-de-Boeuf's arrogant and ignoble cruelty. The same trumpet blast that ended the previous chapter and closed the door on Cedric and Athelstane recurs; placing a pin in Isaac's torments, the book prepares to pick up another unlucky captive's story.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 9

Meanwhile, De Bracy finds Rowena pacing in the finest room this bachelor's castle has to offer. He has done himself up with all the dandifying care of the latest Norman fashions. She demands to know her doom as his prisoner; he proclaims that *he is her captive*, not her jailor. Objecting to being addressed in "the jargon of a troubadour," Rowena protests that she doesn't know him. They argue back and forth, De Bracy's affected, courtly style of language gradually falling away as he grows more annoyed with Rowena's lack of interest in his romantic protestations. Finally declaring that her own bad manners demand wooing by force rather than courtly language, he threatens that she will never leave the castle unless she agrees to become his wife.

Rowena declares that she will marry no man who disdains her Saxon upbringing. De Bracy replies that she will never hear Ivanhoe's proposal, since the wounded knight lies in De Bracy's power, too. This dismays Rowena, who somehow didn't recognize Isaac's and Rebecca's wounded friend. Seizing on his newfound advantage, De Bracy promises to protect Ivanhoe from Front-de-Boeuf—who has an interest in seeing the man whose land he occupies out of the way—if she agrees to marry him. Unused to having her will opposed, Rowena soon gives in to her helpless feminine nature, throws up her hands, and collapses into tears.

De Bracy feels some compassion but more consternation when faced with Rowena's tears; he recognizes that he's pushed her beyond his ability to reason with her, but he doesn't know how to calm her down. Faced with her grief, he feels his own resolve falter and he wishes he had more fortitude or that she'd been able to retain her haughty bearing. While he tries to console her, they hear the commotion at the castle gates, which De Bracy takes as a welcome excuse to disentangle himself from his botched courtship.

Norman not only in name but in sentiment, Maurice de Bracy tries to woo the Saxon Rowena in the terms of chivalry and courtly love. The social construct of courtly love initially seems to invert the gender hierarchy; in it, a powerful knight feels himself to fall under the possession and power of the woman he loves. He feels overwhelmed to the point of death with love for her, and he invests her with power over his life or death. This is why de Bracy proclaims himself Rowena's captive, not her jailor. But courtly love invests mostly fictional power in its ladies, as Rowena clearly realizes; in reality, de Bracy has almost all the power. Furthermore, she rejects not just de Bracy's individual suit but the entire idea of courtly love as a Norman innovation—the "troubadours" she maligns were strongly associated with the Normans, especially King Richard's mother, Eleanor of Aquitaine.



As if to prove Rowena's point that the power courtly love invests in a woman is fictional, as soon as she fails to follow courtly love conventions and fall in love with him, de Bracy reasserts his real authority and begins to threaten her and those she loves with violence. Abuse and coercion, it seems, are ever the Norman way, despite their appeals to chivalric virtue. And while Rowena doesn't exactly capitulate, the book depicts her as an essentially powerless woman as soon as someone opposes her will.



In her weakness, the book claims, Rowena finds power. First, she deviates from the courtly love script by refusing to fall in love with de Bracy; then she deviates from the oppressed Saxon script by refusing to capitulate in order to save Ivanhoe. Ultimately, her refusal to conform to de Bracy's expectations frustrates his courtship more than anything else she could have done. In this vignette, humorously, it's de Bracy whom the horns save from trouble, not his lovely captive.



At this point, Templeton says in an aside to readers, he must offer proof to support his portrait of these “valiant barons” of England as “such dreadful oppressors” who act contrary to the laws of “nature and humanity.” He cites a royal chronicle from the era of King Stephen, which describes Norman excesses including theft of lands, torture of English folks, and women having to disguise themselves as nuns to escape rape. These being well established historical facts, he stands by his book’s depiction as wholly reflective of this moment in English history.

To modern readers (both of Templeton’s own early 19th-century day and of later eras) to whom these abuses of feminine virtue might seem contrary to the laws of chivalrous conduct, Templeton offers another of his explanatory asides, justifying the unsavory elements of his story with historical precedent. This also seems to point toward Dr. Dryasdust’s contention, referenced in the Dedicatory Epistle, that English readers would abandon Templeton as soon as he portrayed their ancestors in a bad light. In this case, Templeton appeals to history to support his fiction, drawing from accounts of the reign of King Stephen (1135–1154) who ruled just prior to King Richard and Prince John’s father, Henry II.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 10

Meanwhile, Rebecca awaits her fate in an isolated turret room occupied by a wrinkled old crone called Dame Urfried. Muttering darkly that no one will hear her screams from this remote room, Urfried regards the beautiful young Rebecca and her foreign mode of dress, then demands to know if she’s an Egyptian or Saracen. Rebecca answers in English, but her accent or her words reveal her Jewishness. Urfried tells Rebecca to expect little mercy, if any, from Front-de-Boeuf. Before leaving Rebecca alone, Urfried describes her own experiences of Norman “courtesy”: theft, murder, and rape.

Rebecca’s experience in the tower will parallel Isaac’s. But, like her father before her, she faces not just more extreme but more likely physical danger, since her identity as a Jewish Englishwoman leaves her triply vulnerable: as a woman, as a subject of Norman rule, and as a Jewish person. To drive home the reality of this violence, Dame Urfried describes her own history with the Normans, who take what they want from their subjects without kindness, chivalry, or nobility.



Rebecca knows that she faces more danger than Rowena, since she doesn’t share her captors’ religion. But possessing a stronger character than her Saxon counterpart, she faces her fate with more equanimity. She carefully inspects the room to look for a means of escape. Finding none, she summons up the courage to face the expected danger. Still, she blanches when she hears someone ascending the stairs.

Despite the dangers and difficulties she faces, Rebecca possess true strength of character. She has greater reserves of courage and conviction than her father and almost everyone else in this world; the only others who come close to matching her fortitude are Ivanhoe and King Richard. It’s in her captivity that the book begins to allow her space to develop as a character, and she both demonstrates the true power of a virtuous and courageous woman and provides the book’s moral center from this point on.



A tall man enters the room, still dressed as a bandit. He stands silently, apparently unsure of what to say, as Rebecca offers her jewelry in exchange for her freedom and Isaac’s. The masked man replies that he values beauty over wealth and her eyes sparkle brighter than the diamonds she offers him. Then, abruptly switching from Saxon to Norman, he adds that he will accept only her “love and beauty” as ransom. Realizing her captor is a Norman, Rebecca demands his name; Sir Brian removes his mask.

Rebecca naturally assumes that, just like Front-de-Boeuf looks at her father as an excellent ransom opportunity, her captor wants her riches. But in terms far less stylized and more sincere than de Bracy offered Rowena, Sir Brian seems to confess a very genuine attraction to Rebecca. This suggests the dangerous power her beauty wields over men—power which exposes her to sexual violence.



Sir Brian tells Rebecca that, far from taking her jewelry, he longs to “hang [her] arms and neck with pearls and diamonds.” But he does not offer marriage, both because the law forbids the union of Christians and Jews and because his vows of chastity as a Templar prevent it. Marriage represents an “enduring crime” against those vows, but he expects easy absolution for the “lesser folly” of keeping a mistress. Besides, he maintains, his service to God in the Templar Order has earned him a few free sins. Rebecca criticizes him sharply for his self-serving twisting of scripture to justify his actions. He retorts that he will accept no dissent from his captive. She promises to tell the world if he rapes her, and he replies that she can only do that if she escapes the castle.

Sir Brian stalks towards Rebecca. She throws open the window and leaps to the sill, prepared to throw herself from the tower rather than suffer rape at his hands. Sir Brian pauses, moved more by her courage than he was by her distress. He promises by the only thing he values—his own word—not to harm her. She descends but remains near the window, content to trust the peace between them only if he keeps his distance. Somewhat cowed, Brian explains that he wasn’t naturally hard-hearted towards women; he only learned to be after one broke his heart. Then he joined the Templars, trading the “dearest rights of humanity”—a wife and children—for power.

Indeed, Sir Brian explains to Rebecca, the Templar Order offers a perfect arena for a man like himself to exercise his ambition; it has more wealth and power than any European monarch. In the “proud and powerful soul” of Rebecca, Sir Brian feels he’s found a partner worthy of himself. But before he can fully explain how the Templars have insinuated themselves into positions of power, he and Rebecca hear the commotion at the gates, and he goes to investigate.

Templar Knights took monastic vows of poverty, chastity, and obedience; they were knights and monks at the same time. Sir Brian’s disordered and unexpected feelings for Rebecca point toward the general corruption of the Norman nobles (and the elements of the Crusader Army that had become more interested in worldly power and wealth than their supposedly divine mission to claim and preserve the so-called Holy Land for Christianity). Prior Aymer shares this disorder in his actions, too. Moreover, his inability to practice self-control suggests that he cannot fully embody the chivalric virtues his society values. When Sir Brian threatens violence should Rebecca refuse him, he leans on the traditional playbook of the invading Norman ruling class, which has controlled its Saxon subjects with violence and coercion for decades.



Although both Rowena and Rebecca successfully thwart the advances of their admirers, the book allows Rebecca to do so in a much more assertive way and makes no reference to her “feminine weakness”; it thus places her as an admirable example for all to follow. And Rebecca’s courage and fortitude contribute to the book’s arguments in favor of chivalry as a value system, since she is just as stalwart and brave as other paragons of chivalric virtue, like the Black Knight and Ivanhoe. In contrast, Sir Brian betrays the shallowness of his value system when the only thing he can swear to is his own word—not to the God or the Order or the chivalric value system he allegedly represents. His weakness of will fails to make a convincing argument for chivalry, as does his thirst for power and his blaming others for his own character flaws.



Sir Brian’s confession provides an example of the book’s occasional historical anachronisms; although secrecy, great wealth, and political ambition became the foundational charges against the Order when it was dissolved in the early 14th century (and have been the basis of countless conspiracy theories about the Templars well into the 21st century), little historical fact supports them. More importantly for the book and its claims, Sir Brian’s ambitions belie the organizing principles of chivalric virtue, point toward the Normans’ hunger for power and domination, and provide the basis for his feelings for Rebecca. In her courage and steadfast commitment to her beliefs, he sees a natural partner for his aggressive and avowedly ambitious plans.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 11

De Bracy and Sir Brian meet at the door. Both complain about their ineffectual attempts at wooing their respective ladies. Front-de-Boeuf is slow to join them, and they speculate that the pained howls of a Jewish person giving up his money must drown out the commotion. Servants deliver a message in writing—in Saxon—from the gate. Sir Brian translates it for his friends: addressed from Wamba, Gurth, Locksley, and the Black Knight, it demands the immediate and unconditional release of Cedric, Rowena, Isaac, Rebecca, their injured charge, and everything and everyone else the Normans captured. De Bracy and Sir Brian laugh derisively. The news that at least 200 men lie outside the castle sobers them somewhat.

Still, De Bracy and Sir Brian arrogantly assert that either one of them can take on at least 20 English yeomen at a time. Front-de-Boeuf worries because most of their men—and the forces of their friends like Malvoisin—are far away. He sends his squire to fetch writing materials, then has Sir Brian write an answer to the challenge saying that they plan to execute their captives that afternoon and the brigands should send a priest to hear their confession before they die.

Underneath a venerable **oak** tree near the castle, hundreds of yeomen and Saxons with improvised weapons gather to storm the castle. Only the Black Knight proves capable of reading the Norman letter penned by Sir Brian, which he translates into Saxon. Together, the leaders of the rebel band decide to send Wamba, disguised as a monk, into the castle. Meanwhile, Locksley tightens the line of his forces around the castle to prevent its defenders from sending for reinforcements.

Of the Norman conquerors, only Sir Brian can understand Saxon—looking back to his earlier refusal to speak anything but Norman in Cedric's home, readers can now understand the aggression of that act more fully. The Normans' arrogant belief in their own strength disposes them to ignore the threat—they are abusive bullies, after all. But readers should remember that Cedric recently made a similar assumption and quickly found himself proved wrong when his Saxon strength did not protect him from kidnapping in the forest.



Front-de-Boeuf takes a more cautious view of the circumstances, likely because he has more to lose: the bandits and Saxon hordes are threatening his home. Still, he refuses to capitulate to the demands of a rabble of Saxons. He trusts that the other Normans—who face dangerous revolt if they break ranks—will support him.



Outside the castle walls, the Saxons meet under that grand symbol of English identity and strength, the oak tree. Readers should have no difficulty predicting their successful attack on Torquilstone, even though the book will build tension through its drawn-out descriptions of the fight. And although he's clearly been conversing with the woodsmen in fluent Saxon, the Black Knight's ability to read (since very few people in this era were literate) and write in Norman suggests that he himself is a Norman lord.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 12

Disguised as a Franciscan monk, Wamba presents himself at the castle gates. The warden fetches Front-de-Boeuf, who admits the alleged friar to the castle. The baron asks how many men stand poised to attack the castle and Wamba claims at least 500. Sir Brian suggests that after the monk visits the prisoners, the castle defenders should make him carry a message to De Bracy's band of mercenaries asking for help.

Continuing the book's theme of disguises, Wamba now dresses as a Franciscan monk. Unlike the other disguises in the book, his (which he will soon transfer to Cedric) serves more of a utilitarian role than a symbolic one. It sheds no light on the world, but it does allow him to make right the injustice of Cedric's imprisonment.



In the former great hall, Wamba reveals himself to Athelstane and Cedric. He offers to trade clothing with Cedric—but not Athelstane—in order to allow his master to escape to join the growing band of would-be rescuers gathering outside. Cedric dons the monk’s habit, then pauses, fearing he doesn’t know enough Norman to pass muster. Wamba tells him to answer all queries in Latin, saying “pax vobiscum” no matter what anyone asks. Promising to either rescue the faithful Wamba and the others or to avenge their cruel deaths, Cedric slips from the room. Almost immediately he encounters Urfried and Rebecca, who wants him to bring news and comfort to the wounded knight (Ivanhoe).

Wamba’s refusal to help Athelstane before Cedric continues to point toward Athelstane’s basic inability to adequately represent or lead the Saxons. Moreover, Cedric’s refusal to learn basic Norman now seems detrimental. From Templeton’s perspective, the conflict ends in the eventual merging of Saxon and Norman cultures, and Cedric’s complete rejection of Norman culture dooms him to eventual irrelevance. “Pax vobiscum” means “peace be with you,” an ironic password considering how Normans and Saxons feel about each other and the violence to come.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 13

Urfried shepherds Rebecca back into a castle room, then leads the monk—the disguised Cedric—to another little chamber. After locking the door, she begs him, as a fellow Saxon, to hear her woeful tale. Her name is Ulrica, not Urfried, and although everyone thought that she died with her father, the Thane of Torquilstone, she survived her family’s massacre and lived for many years as the lover of Front-de-Boeuf’s father. For playing paramour to her family’s murderer, she feels unbearable guilt. Cedric agrees she should, and curses her for failing to kill herself before sharing a Norman’s bed.

The story of the unfortunate Ulrica aligns with the dangers that Maurice de Bracy and Sir Brian pose to Rowen and Rebecca, respectively. Interestingly, however, the book protects its main female protagonists by displacing the violence they could suffer into the past. Ulrica’s story speaks to the Normans’ bloodthirsty violence and abuse of power. Unlike Rebecca, she did not have the fortitude to kill herself rather than face sexual assault, and although Cedric criticizes this as a weakness, more forgiving readers can accept her survival instinct.



Disgusted by what he considers her betrayal of the Saxon cause, Cedric tells Ulrica to as God, not him, for forgiveness. She threatens him that she can easily tell Front-de-Boeuf about his escape. Cedric retorts that he would rather face Front-de-Boeuf’s wrath than sully himself by remaining in her presence. Fine, she replies. She will take her revenge on the Normans herself. This mollifies Cedric somewhat. He pauses long enough for Ulrica to promise that she will create a diversion in the castle. The attackers should charge when a red flag flies from the eastern turret.

Although Cedric wants to discount Ulrica as a weak—and treacherous—woman, she still has great power in this situation, and she’s not afraid to use it. It seems that she may have learned a thing or two about seizing, using, and even abusing power from her Norman captors. But in the end, she refuses to side with them, and her tragic story serves as a powerful indictment against their ignoble and self-serving ways.



Ulrica vanishes through a hidden door just as Front-de-Boeuf enters the apartment, demanding to know whether the priest has finished hearing his prisoners’ confessions. In halting Norman, Cedric says he has. Noting his Saxon accent, Front-de-Boeuf promises to spare the friar from coming Norman violence if he will agree to take a message to Philip de Malvoisin.

Despite his earlier concerns, Cedric’s costume serves well enough to shield him from detection by Front-de-Boeuf. Meanwhile, Front-de-Boeuf continues to draw straight from the Norman playbook of abuse, threat, and violence.



After escorting Cedric from the castle walls, Front-de-Boeuf returns to his hall and orders his servants to bring him Athelstane and Cedric. He doesn't realize that "Cedric" is really Wamba in disguise until the jester opens his mouth to speak. Front-de-Boeuf pulls back Wamba's hood as De Bracy enters the room and recognizes "Cedric's fool." Slowly, it dawns on Front-de-Boeuf and De Bracy that Cedric has escaped. Realizing that they've inadvertently betrayed their plans to their enemies, the defenders know they will face the impending attack alone.

De Bracy, Front-de-Boeuf, and Sir Brian belatedly try to negotiate a ransom of 1,000 marks for Athelstane and the minor members of Cedric's party, but they refuse to consider releasing Isaac, Rebecca, Wamba, or Rowena. Athelstane could not care less about Isaac and Rebecca, but he refuses to leave his fiancée Rowena or his uncle Cedric's beloved servant Wamba. Furthermore, he demands to be kept in a manner befitting his noble rank and he reissues his challenge of armed combat to Front-de-Boeuf. Front-de-Boeuf casually replies that he doesn't duel with his prisoners, but he will accept a challenge from Athelstane if he ever has the luck to escape.

A monk with a message from Aymer interrupts the negotiations. The prior has also been captured by Saxons and wants Front-de-Boeuf to pay his ransom or rescue him. Front-de-Boeuf refuses, declaring that he's too busy with his own problems. This reminds the monk that, in all the excitement of delivering his message, he forgot to warn the baron that he saw the Saxon forces building ramps to scale the walls on his way to the castle. From the window, De Bracy confirms the monk's news. Front-de-Boeuf shouts for Sir Brian and De Bracy to defend the castle walls as they realize that the Black Knight leads the Saxon forces with the skill of an experienced general. All the better, Front-de-Boeuf exclaims—now they can get their revenge on him for his part in the tournament.

It turns out that Cedric's disguise works in part because Front-de-Boeuf (in, it implies, typically Norman arrogance) hasn't cared enough to figure out what the most powerful Saxon nobles in the area look like. In contrast, de Bracy (who met Cedric, Athelstane, and Wamba at the Tournament) instantly realizes the deception. But it's too late; Norman arrogance has planted the seeds of the castle's fall.



Athelstane shows a remarkable lack of insight when he offers to pay a large ransom on the verge of being rescued. Like Prince John, he shows himself to be a shallow, petty tyrant, more focused on his own creature comforts than the needs of his people. And his hollow challenge to Front-de-Boeuf serves to underline his weakness of character rather than counteract it. Front-de-Boeuf's casual dismissal of it—he clearly doesn't take it seriously—encourages readers to discount it as well.



Aymer's capture, unrelated to events at the castle, seems unimportant at first but will become a key factor in the book's third main adventure. For the moment, it further illustrates the increasingly precarious position of the arrogant and self-assured Normans. Too many years of underestimating their Saxon subjects have left them vulnerable to attack. The main conflict of the first volume pitted Saxon (Ivanhoe) against Norman (Sir Brian). The main conflict of the second volume will pit ignoble Normans (Front-de-Boeuf, de Bracy, Sir Brian) against the shining example of Norman chivalry, the Black Knight, who leads the attacking forces.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 14

At this point, the story backtracks slightly to explain how Ivanhoe came to be in Isaac's and Rebecca's care. Rebecca wanted to help the knight; despite his naturally kind and grateful temperament, Isaac worries that sheltering a Christian disobeys Jewish law. And, no good will come to them if anyone discovers that a Christian knight died in their care. But eventually he relents. Templeton notes that, although medieval romances frequently cast knights' ladies as their physicians, the Jewish people in that era were particularly well-trained in the medical arts. Moreover, they augmented their skill, he claims, with the power of "cabalistical" or "supernatural arts." And even among her people, Rebecca is a particularly well-regarded doctor.

Rebecca examines Ivanhoe at Ashby, dressing his wound and declaring him stable enough to take back to York with herself and Isaac the next day. Isaac greets this pronouncement with shock; he didn't expect Rebecca to extend their charity that far. But Rebecca convinces him, in part by arguing that Isaac will need the protection of someone as close to Richard I as Ivanhoe, if the king returns to discover that Isaac has been financing Prince John.

Later that same evening, Ivanhoe recovers consciousness. He finds himself in a room whose "oriental costume" makes him think for a moment that he's back in Palestine. Rebecca's entrance only reinforces this feeling. He draws his breath to speak, but she silences him while she skillfully tends his wound. She gives brief instructions in Hebrew to two servants, and Ivanhoe reflects on the "romantic and pleasing effect" of her mellifluous voice. Only after the servants leave does he dare address Rebecca. He chooses the language he learned in Palestine but, to his surprise, she answers in English. She introduces herself as Rebecca, the humble daughter of Isaac of York. Templeton suspects that Rowena might not have been entirely pleased by the way that Ivanhoe appreciates Rebecca's beauty. But by highlighting her Jewish identity, Rebecca immediately lowers herself safely below Ivanhoe's romantic interest.

The conflict between Rebecca and Isaac shows that the book's Jewish characters are no more hegemonic than its Saxons or Normans and suggests that future stability requires compromise among factions—a thoroughly modern moral. Templeton's aside illuminates a few aspects of medieval history and courtly love ideology that play a key role in coming chapters: first, Jewish people were not just moneylenders—in many parts of Europe (particularly Italy and Spain) they were also respected medical professionals. Second, in courtly love ideology, a knight's physician and his love interest are often one and the same. This generates some of the sexual tension that will arise between Ivanhoe and Rebecca, mainly on Rebecca's side.



Having just established Rebecca's skills as a physician the book then slyly suggests that there's more at stake here than just her professional opinion; she seems already to have taken a particular interest in the noble and virtuous Ivanhoe. Moreover, she's just as politically aware and savvy as her father, and she recognizes the utility of having someone of Ivanhoe's stature on their side.



Because the love interest and the physician are frequently aligned in medieval romances and courtly love ideology, Ivanhoe feels an initial flash of romantic interest in Rebecca, inspired not just by her tender care but by her beauty, as well. However, his ardor cools as soon as she notes her Jewish identity; despite his good qualities, Ivanhoe expresses the same prejudices as his society. And while Ivanhoe responds to Rebecca's perceived foreignness (first with attraction, then with disgust) she immediately reminds him (and readers) that although the other characters treat her and her father as dangerous outsiders, they are English natives themselves. Thus, Rebecca and her father's disinheritance and displacement rise from social prejudice alone.



Rebecca watches the desire in Ivanhoe's eyes instantly turn to disdain, but she declines to hold the prejudices of the age against the noble young knight. Treating him with the same gracious courtesy as before, she explains the necessity of bringing him with herself and Isaac back to York; although there he might find shelter in many a noble house or Christian convent, no one else can offer him the same medical skill as Rebecca. She promises he need not stay in despised Jewish company for long; eight days in her care will bring him to full recovery. If she can accomplish this, Ivanhoe promises to richly reward her, but Rebecca only wants the knight to believe that "a Jew may do good service to a Christian" without looking for financial gain.

Ivanhoe agrees and places himself completely in Rebecca's care. He asks what happened after he fainted. She tells him that Prince John ended the tournament early. Gossip says he's preparing to claim the throne. She further reports that Cedric, Athelstane, and Rowena are on their way home with Gurth in their custody. Ivanhoe curses the fate that endangers his friends, from Gurth the swineherd to King Richard. But Rebecca suggests that perhaps divine providence has brought him back to England purposefully at the hour of his friends' greatest need.

Ivanhoe has enough strength to undergo the journey the following morning, despite the punishing pace Isaac sets to avoid robbers. But their speed frustrates his hired Saxon bodyguards into deserting. This brings the story back to the point where Cedric and his group stumble on the trio on the forest road. During the attack of the Norman "bandits," De Bracy discovers Ivanhoe, whom he secretly conveys into the castle. He fears leaving a rival for Rowena's affection at large yet dares not dishonor himself by killing a defenseless knight. There, after Front-de-Boeuf learns that two of De Bracy's men are tending to a wounded "companion" rather than preparing to defend the castle, he assigns Ivanhoe to Ulrica, who recruits Rebecca as nurse. Thus, Ivanhoe ends up back in Rebecca's care.

Ever the book's shining example of good character, Rebecca doesn't take it personally when Ivanhoe's demeanor changes. She takes care of him out of the goodness of her heart because it is the right thing to do and not out of hope for reward (romantic or otherwise). And in exchange, she only wants him to recognize her humanity in the same way she recognizes his. She models the foundation of a truly just society, and her actions sharply contrast the self-interest and self-dealing typical among the power-hungry Norman ruling class.



Despite his injuries, Ivanhoe's knightly heart impels him to the protection of his friends above all other considerations. In this way, he proves to be a shining example of chivalric virtue. Yet, because his injuries (incurred while proving his knightly worth in a tournament) prevent him from acting on these desires, his position makes an ambivalent contribution to the book's debate about the value of chivalry. His attitude suggests its importance, while his inactivity hints at its practical limitations.



Maurice de Bracy's actions contribute to the book's debate about chivalric virtue, too. On the one hand, some sort of knightly code prevents him from killing the wounded and vulnerable Ivanhoe on the spot when he discovers him. On the other, as a rival for Rowena's hand, he feels no compunction about kidnapping Ivanhoe with what seems to be a half-formed idea of using him as leverage. His ambivalent actions suggest that while chivalry might provide a positive framework to channel the energies and ambition of young, bold noblemen, in practice, a knight's chivalry tends to reflect rather than direct his natural inclination toward good or evil.



VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 15

Despite—or perhaps because of—the grave danger they face, Rebecca feels a “keen sensation of pleasure” at being reunited with Ivanhoe. She examines his wound, her touch betraying deeper feelings than she would voluntarily admit. When Ivanhoe asks, “Is it you, gentle maiden?” a scarcely audible sigh escapes her lips. Her heart jumps when he calls her by name, but she reminds herself sternly that he regards her, a Jewish woman, as less valuable than a horse or a dog. She gives him a brief history of the party’s capture, then tells him that a priest has arrived who might have more news. And that’s how she and Ulrica come to lie in wait for Cedric.

The priest never arrives, and presently Ivanhoe and Rebecca hear the clamor of knights preparing for battle. Intent on keeping Ivanhoe still and in bed, Rebecca says she will go to the window and keep him informed about the fight. Ivanhoe frets that she risks injury or death and begs her to take down a shield from the wall for protection. Displaying her usual courage, Rebecca takes up her post at the window, which gives her an excellent view. She sees hundreds of archers lurking in the shadow of the nearby forest and reports that the attackers seem to be under the command of a Black Knight whom Ivanhoe doesn’t recognize.

As Rebecca watches, the Saxon forces charge at the castle and the archers loose their arrows in a deadly barrage. When Rebecca peeps through the window again, she sees the Black Knight fighting toward the gate. She describes the attackers breaching the wall and Front-de-Boeuf meeting them. She tells Ivanhoe when Front-de-Boeuf briefly overpowers the Black Knight and when the Black Knight regains the upper hand. Defenders drag the injured Front-de-Boeuf inside as the advantage turns from the attackers to the defenders and back again and men die in droves. Ivanhoe grows more and more excited.

Readers can see that Rebecca isn't being entirely honest with herself—the thrill she feels in Ivanhoe's presence comes at least in part from her feelings for him. But because she cannot ever act on them, separated as they are by the gulf of their differing religions, she transfers her excitement to the present dangers. She shows all the symptoms of love. But, in sharp contrast to the man who claims to love her, Sir Brian, she takes control of her actions even when she cannot tell her heart what to do.



Sir Brian earlier claimed that part of his attraction to Rebecca arose from their similar temperaments. Yet, she and Ivanhoe seem to have more in common—first and foremost, they're both courageous and calm in the face of danger. In this moment, Ivanhoe betrays his chivalric attention to the safety of the vulnerable (women) when he insists that Rebecca shield herself. But he also betrays his knightly thirst for glory in the keen interest he shows in the battle. Rebecca's description of the fighting provides the context for one of the book's most detailed explorations of chivalry and its value.



Rebecca, standing at the window, quickly understands that bloodshed and violence lie at the root of chivalry, no matter how pretty the language used to describe it, or strict the rules and values used to contain and direct it. While there's something undoubtedly impressive about the strength and courage the Black Knight and Front-de-Boeuf show, there's also something wasteful in their contest, since one of them likely faces death.



Soon, Rebecca reports that the Black Knight is taking his axe to the gate. Ivanhoe can think of only one man who would dare such a thing and he again asks Rebecca if she can see any other distinguishing features on the man. She can discern nothing except the magnitude of his martial spirit—she says he rushes to battle as if it were a feast and he were starving. She finds watching him fight both marvelous and horrifying. Ivanhoe swears he would endure 10 years' captivity to fight by such a man for just one day, and Rebecca asks how he can be so hungry for battle, having so recently been a victim of its violence. He explains that victory, honor, and the love of battle nourish all true knights. Nothing more and nothing less than eternal glory will satisfy them.

Rebecca can't understand this bloodlust and Ivanhoe retorts that only a Christian can feel the true power of chivalry. Somewhat chastened, Rebecca nevertheless knows that she and her people possess vast reserves of courage, even if Ivanhoe doesn't believe it. She turns to find that Ivanhoe has exhausted himself in his excitement and fainted. She looks on his handsome face, then forces herself to imagine it in old age and death as she berates herself for caring more about him than she does about Isaac. Vowing to tear her foolish affection from her heart, she wraps herself in her veil and turns her face away from the slumbering knight.

VOLUME 2, CHAPTER 16

During a lull in the battle, Sir Brian and De Bracy meet in the castle hall. Front-de-Boeuf lies dying, felled by the Black Knight's powerful blows. Sir Brian's forces lost control of their wall and the attackers may well soon be inside the castle. De Bracy suggests turning over their prisoners, but Sir Brian refuses; admitting defeat would deal far too great a blow to his honor. Swearing to show himself to be a "gentleman of blood and lineage," De Bracy prepares to return to battle alongside Sir Brian. They fear that the attackers plan to concentrate their force on the now vulnerable postern, or inner castle gate, which they prepare to defend with their lives.

Ivanhoe clearly has suspicions about the Black Knight's true identity, based in part on his physical characteristics (his tall height, his broad shoulders) but mostly based on his courageous attitude in battle. Like Ivanhoe, the Black Knight becomes one of the most compelling arguments for the value of chivalry in the book, insofar as his expertise and skill as a knight frequently do serve to protect the powerless, rescue the helpless, and chastise the arrogant. When Rebecca questions Ivanhoe directly about what chivalry has gotten him other than pain and suffering, he points to glory and honor. But his argument never reaches beyond internal justifications—chivalry defines success in war as glory, then excuses violence as the path toward glory. Ivanhoe's answer skips over Rebecca's real question about how to measure chivalry against other values like romantic and familial love or social cohesion.



When Rebecca presses Ivanhoe further, he shuts down the debate by citing their irreconcilable religious differences—and then he falls asleep. The question remains unsettled; readers must judge for themselves whether they agree with Ivanhoe or Rebecca. However, the book unquestionably values the courage, self-control, and personal mastery Rebecca shows by controlling her impossible romantic feelings, in sharp contrast to Sir Brian.



In the contest between Normans and Saxons, the Saxons seem poised to score a critical victory. When de Bracy's courage momentarily fails, Sir Brian rouses him to valorous action by reminding him of his honor—the centerpiece of chivalry. Yet still, honor is an ambivalent motivation; it can inspire a knight like Ivanhoe to challenge a bully like Sir Brian, but it can also inspire bullies like Sir Brian and de Bracy to unnecessarily extend bloodshed rather than admit their impending defeat.



Reginald Front-de-Boeuf lies in bed in mental and physical agony. Unlike most other knights in this superstitious period, his greed has kept him from assuaging his guilty conscience by making large donations to the Church for the remission of his sins. Now, he fears dying unforgiven and he cries out for a priest. A shrill voice rises from his bedside identifying itself as his “evil angel.” The voice encourages him to think on his sins: rebellion, murder, and rape. Front-de-Boeuf declares he isn’t responsible for Prince John’s rebellion, nor does he feel guilt over the “infidel Jew” or “Saxon porkers” who have died by his hand. Then the voice asks about the murder of his father. After a pause he lays the blame for that event squarely on Ulrica.

Front-de-Boeuf’s death points to the emptiness of the Normans’ moral universe; motivated only by self-interest, he has neglected every other responsibility, including his duty to support the church and even his family ties. The book paints him as the ultimate vicious Norman villain, implying that his personal sins reflect the broader misdeeds of the entire ruling class. Ulrica leads him through a perverse mockery of confession; she points out sins she knows only too well, having witnessed or abetted most of them. But, because he lacks any meaningful moral code, religious or secular (like chivalry), he refuses to accept responsibility.



Ulrica steps from the shadows and taunts Front-de-Boeuf with the specter of his castle falling to the Saxon hordes. She promises him a slow, ignominious, and painful death by burning; she’s set the castle’s fuel magazine on fire. With a foreboding farewell, she leaves, locking the door behind her and abandoning Front-de-Boeuf to cry helplessly for his servants. Thick, choking smoke fills the room as if the Devil himself has come from hell to claim Front-de-Boeuf’s soul. Laughing giddily, he cries out with his final words that at least he will take De Bracy, Sir Brian, Ulrica, and his prisoners with him.

Notably—and in a moment of poetic justice—Front-de-Boeuf dies in a fire, the same way he threatened to kill Isaac. And because he gained his power and clout through intimidation, violence, and threats—rather than earning it through knightly valor or good leadership—Front-de-Boeuf cannot call anyone to his aid. He can’t even foist his fate on de Bracy or Sir Brian, both of whom will soon escape the castle. His end thus foreshadows the reinstitution of justice and law when King Richard returns, which will have punishing consequences for all abusive members of the Norman nobility.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 1

The tale steps back in time to the point where Cedric escaped the castle. He immediately encourages Locksley, the Black Knight, and the Cleric of Copmanhurst to prepare for the attack. All four agree on the importance of rescuing the Saxons, especially Rowena and Wamba. Then, they begin the first attack, which the book has already described from the perspective of those within the castle. During the lull, the Black Knight and his troops make a raft bridge for crossing the moat. Then, anxious to complete the assault before the day ends (or reinforcements arrive), they prepare a diversion to cover their attempt to breach the inner castle walls.

The reasons given for rescuing the others left in the castle align with each character’s values: Cedric wants Athelstane safe because of his royal Saxon blood; as a chivalric knight errant, the Black Knight wants to protect the honor of a lady like Rowena; Locksley recognizes the human value of his fellow non-noble, Wamba. Notably, no one mentions or seems worried about Rebecca and Isaac. The attack plays out as a contest between Saxon and Norman Englishfolk, in which Jewish subjects are at best, onlookers—and at worst, unremembered victims.



Unarmed and unarmored, Cedric follows the Black Knight through the outer wall and onto a bridge exposed to missiles and arrows from the defenders on the walls. As Locksley catches sight of Ulrica’s promised red flag on the battlements, he shouts encouragement, and his archers renew their attack. Men fall dead on all sides of De Bracy, who stands on the wall to direct the defense. De Bracy himself fights valiantly until Sir Brian arrives; his news, that the castle is in flames, panics De Bracy. Keeping a cool head, Sir Brian takes charge of the defense, sketching out a quick plan of attack for De Bracy and his forces to push the attackers back to the outer wall.

Although he rejects the refined and stylized form of Norman-influenced chivalry, Cedric and the Black Knight show that enough common ground exists between Saxons and Normans to imagine a unified country: both fight bravely and put the good of their causes (Saxon restitution in Cedric’s case, and upholding the values of chivalry in the Knight’s case) above their own safety. And while the knights within the castle also fight well, their abusive oppression and lack of true virtue dooms their cause to failure.



Yet, De Bracy and his men cannot hold off the furious Black Knight, who soon demands De Bracy's surrender. When De Bracy refuses to surrender to an unknown man, the Black Knight whispers his true name into the Norman's ear. De Bracy not only yields but tells the Black Knight where to find Ivanhoe.

The Black Knight's whispered name remains inaudible to readers but adds yet more evidence to the theory that he's King Richard, who would have a vested interest in protecting Ivanhoe and punishing his brother's supporters.



Meanwhile, Ivanhoe and Rebecca are becoming increasingly aware of the smoke and cries for water. Ivanhoe tells Rebecca to save herself, but she refuses to leave him. While they argue, Sir Brian bursts in, intent on rescuing Rebecca. She refuses to go willingly unless he also saves Isaac and Ivanhoe. Coolly replying that he doesn't care at all about the death of a Jewish man, Sir Brian picks her up and carries her from the room over her protests. Ivanhoe shouts in impotent rage and the Black Knight bursts into the room, scooping him up with as much ease as Sir Brian bore Rebecca.

Even as he protests his powerlessness over his feelings for Rebecca, Sir Brian remains calm and collected generally. And she remains literally powerless against his superior strength. This, in combination with the fact that he refuses to honor her wishes, suggests that perhaps his feelings aren't as deep or as real as he claims—or that the power courtly love allegedly gives the lady merely provides cover for male violence and control. It's impossible to separate his tortured love for Rebecca from his ambitious desire for world domination—and it is possible to interpret his fascination with a Jewish woman as a projection of his feelings about the Templars losing control of Jerusalem and its Jewish Temple.



A fierce battle rages in the castle's lower floors, which the fire has yet to penetrate. Cedric and Gurth push through this confusion of strife and death until they find Rowena. Cedric charges Gurth with getting her out of the castle, while he continues the search for Athelstane. Soon, Wamba's cries alert him to the room where the last Saxon royal and Cedric's faithful jester wait.

At several points, the book suggests that Cedric cannot resist the whims of Rowena, whom he has spoiled; in this moment, it becomes clear that her feminine power over her male guardian remains limited and subject to his broader aims, like Saxon restitution. He's more interested in rescuing Athelstane than her.



Athelstane sees Sir Brian preparing to flee the castle with Rebecca—whom Athelstane mistakes for Rowena. Vowing to save his love, and over Wamba's objections that he has misidentified the lady, he seizes the nearest weapon and charges the Templar, who fells the great Saxon with one blow to the head. Then Sir Brian retreats, intent on reaching the safety of his Templar preceptory—especially after De Bracy enigmatically warns him that “hawks are abroad.”

The fact that Athelstane can't tell the blonde Rowena from the dark-haired Rebecca suggests that he may not really be in love with his fiancée—or at least that he's barely paid attention to her thus far. His act of rushing to her rescue, while it does show some otherwise uncharacteristic bravery, thus suggests that, like Cedric, he is more in love with the idea of himself as king than anything else.



Ulrica appears high on the castle walls, her long disheveled hair whipping in the wind. She sings a furious Saxon battle song that invokes heroes and encourages warriors to fight with fury in hopes of reaching Valhalla. She reigns as “empress of the conflagration” until her tower collapses.

Importantly for the book's historical thrust toward a mixed, Saxon and Norman English identity, the castle falls as the result both of the Norman Black Knight's actions outside the castle, and the Saxon Ulrica's inside the castle. This suggests that only together can the Normans and Saxons make England truly powerful.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 2

Locksley's band of thieves gathers at another of their great **oak** meeting-trees to divvy up the riches they stole from the burning castle. Locksley sits as king of his forest realm, with the Black Knight on his right hand and Cedric on his left. Cedric refuses his half of the booty. He did not, he says, fight for riches. And he has enough wealth to reward those Saxons who came to his aid. With tears in his eyes, he mourns the end of the Saxon royal line with the death of Athelstane. And he expresses undying gratitude to the faithful Wamba. In reward, Wamba begs Cedric to forgive and free the equally faithful Gurth.

Lady Rowena, cleaned up and splendidly dressed, rides into the clearing. If her imprisonment distressed her, the knowledge that Ivanhoe still lives and that Athelstane will never again court her buoys her spirits. She courteously thanks Locksley for his role in her rescue. As she waits for Cedric, De Bracy begs her forgiveness and promises that he knows how to serve her "in nobler ways." She forgives him, but only out of a sense of Christian duty.

Cedric invites the Black Knight to Rotherwood. Swearing that Cedric has taught him "the value of Saxon virtue," the Knight says that his own affairs must occupy him first, but that he will soon accept Cedric's invitation and need his aid. After the Saxons depart, Locksley offers the Black Knight his pick of the castle's spoils. The Knight wants only Maurice De Bracy, whom he frees, on condition that he never attempt to take revenge for his capture. The woodsmen jeer as De Bracy selects a horse and beats a hasty retreat. Locksley gives the Black Knight the bugle which he won at the tournament, promising his and his men's support should the Black Knight ever need it. If he plays the bugle, they will appear.

Then Locksley distributes the treasure with judicious fairness that impresses the Black Knight. After setting aside portions for the church, the band's general fund, and the widows and dependents of the fallen, Locksley impartially hands out the remainder in accord with each man's just deserts. Just as the Black Knight and Locksley notice the Cleric of Copmanhurst's absence and presumed death, the jolly hermit bursts into the clearing, with Isaac in tow!

Thus far, the book has only shown readers Prince John's treasonous and self-interested reign, and strongly suggested the indolent and slow-witted Athelstane's basic inability to rule. King Richard hasn't asserted himself yet. In this vacuum, Locksley, "king" of the outlaws, provides a shining example of the benefits of a healthy monarchy—a key part of the book's argument about the political and cultural greatness of England. Volume three sees the restoration of order and inheritance in the book, and the forgiveness and freeing of Gurth represents an important first step on this path: one freed Saxon hints at greater freedom for all Saxons in the future.



Despite having embarrassed himself with a failed courtship of Rowena and a devastating loss at Torquilstone, de Bracy continues to play the debased lover-knight. Unsurprisingly, his protestations of love move Rowena even less now that he's literally tied up as a captive.



Despite being a Norman, the Black Knight expresses frank admiration for the Saxons' valor and honesty. This bodes well for their future prospects in England, especially since, as the book has strongly hinted, the Knight may in fact be Richard. He continues to showcase the chivalric virtue when he extends mercy to the captive de Bracy and in his refusal to mock a man whose honor has already been compromised. The woodsmen's promise of aid, no less than Cedric's promise of hospitality, shows that the Black Knight can earn Saxon respect and love.



The lawful order and equitable division of booty in the forest contrasts sharply with the lawlessness and rapacious greed of the Normans. In this moment, the book doesn't so much suggest that Saxons are better at governance than Normans than it makes a claim for the necessity of a strong, ethically sound ruler—his fair division of the booty prevents his followers from giving into greed or ambition.



The Cleric explains that, while he searched for the castle's wine cellar, he found and freed Isaac instead. The collapsing walls cut off their escape, and although the Cleric initially thought he had better kill Isaac (to keep himself from dying in the company of a Jewish person), he decided to convert Isaac to Christianity instead. That morning, while some of Locksley's men combed through the rubble, they found the pair unharmed. Isaac protests that he did not agree to convert, at which the Cleric threatens him with "penance" and raises his sword. When the Black Knight intervenes, he and the Cleric come to good-natured blows, which cease when Locksley receives another prisoner—Prior Aymer.

The cleric makes apparently real threats against Isaac's life to force his conversion; to modern readers he seems little better than Reginald Front-de-Boeuf, who also threatened violence to get what he wanted (in that case, money) out of Isaac. Once again, despite regularly pointing out the inherent wrongness of the racist and prejudicial treatment that Jewish people suffered in the Middle Ages, the book's generally sympathetic portrayal of the Cleric subtly validates his antisemitic views. This scene also points toward historic violence against Jewish people in medieval Europe, who were occasionally converted at the end of a sword; the entire point of the crusades was the conversion of Palestine into a Christian kingdom.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 3

Terrified yet still proud, Prior Aymer complains about the treatment he received from his guard Allan-a-Dale. Locksley tells the priest he must pay a large ransom to escape with his life. One of the woodsmen suggests that Isaac and Aymer should each set the other's ransom. Isaac sets Aymer's at 600 crowns—having loaned the convent money, he knows how easily they can repay such a sum. In return, noting that "foul usuries" have allowed Isaac to fill his coffers with Christian silver and gold, Aymer sets Isaac's ransom at 1,000 crowns. Thus, the woodsmen note, their fellow Christian treats them more generously than the stingy Jewish Isaac.

Aymer's capture, although incidental to the fall of Torquilstone, continues the theme of Norman comeuppance. Something in the kingdom has shifted, and although King Richard hasn't yet returned, it is becoming increasingly clear Prince John's amoral and abusive brand of Norman domination will end soon. Isaac's ransom, which takes into account the riches owned by the priory, points to the reason these Normans must be replaced: they are selfish, greedy, and worldly. Even their religious leaders care more about eating and drinking than about saving people's souls. In contrast, the ransom Aymer sets is a vindictive, abusive ransom for Isaac, based solely on anti-Jewish sentiment and stereotypical beliefs about Jewish wealth.



Isaac begs for mercy since, as he assumes, his only child just died in the castle. But one of the woodsmen describes how Sir Brian rode away from the castle with Rebecca. Isaac's very real grief over the prospect of her rape at the Templar's hand moves Locksley, who lowers Isaac's ransom to 500 crowns so that he will still have enough to ransom her from captivity. Privately, Locksley advises Isaac to cultivate peace with Aymer, who desperately needs the ready cash that Isaac can provide him. Besides, Locksley insinuates, he knows all too well where Isaac keeps his vast treasure. Isaac bribes Locksley for his silence on this knowledge.

By rights, Isaac shouldn't be ransomed at all, since he was a captive at Torquilstone, too, and should have been rescued by Locksley's men. The book ignores this fact—and instead highlights Isaac's wealth, thus casting him into the role of a stereotypically wealthy, conniving Jewish moneylender. Once more, the book participates in the prejudice it at other times criticizes. Thus, it casts Locksley's lowering of the ransom as a sharp rebuke of Prior Aymer and his greed. And Isaac's bribe means that Locksley essentially gets part of his forgiven ransom back anyway.



Locksley brokers the deal between Isaac and Aymer: Isaac will give Aymer the money he needs for his immediate ransom, and Aymer will use his influence for Rebecca's safe release. Aymer agrees on the condition that Isaac donates to the convent's new dormitory. Isaac struggles yet again to check his avaricious impulses, even for the safety of his daughter, but eventually agrees. Aymer borrows Isaac's writing tablet to draw up the letter to Sir Brian. When he refuses to use a Jewish man's pen, one of the woodsmen shoots a goose flying overhead and fashions an unpolluted quill. Aymer writes his letter, and a receipt for the loan of 600 crowns from Isaac. Finally, the woodsmen agree to let Aymer, his two companions, and their animals—but not their jewels and other valuable possessions—go free.

Finally, Isaac departs, having first sent a message asking one of his relatives to deliver his own and Aymer's ransom to Locksley. The Black Knight notes with surprise how civilly these so-called "outlaws" handle their business. Locksley replies that he's sorry to be a thief at all, but that desperate times have driven many to desperate measures. Neither yet proves willing to reveal his true identity, but the Black Knight and Locksley shake hands and part as friends.

Much earlier in the book, Isaac struggled with his conscience when he tried to take 10 coins off Ivanhoe's debt but couldn't bring himself to. The book leans even harder into the antisemitic trope of the money-obsessed Jewish moneylender when it shows Isaac struggling to decide whether he values his daughter or his wealth more. In the end, it shows Isaac's better nature prevailing, but not before his torn conscience has offered further evidence to support the very antisemitic beliefs the novel claims to reject. Nor does the book present as problematic Aymer's refusal to use Isaac's pen, as if sharing the tool will physically contaminate Aymer somehow.



Drawing heavily on Robin Hood mythology (which, like Ivanhoe, relies on a criticism of Prince John and a valorization of King Richard that doesn't always match the historical record), this section lays the blame for the proliferation of English outlaws directly at the feet of the unethical and ineffective Norman ruling class. The order and peace of the outlaw band critiques lawless Norman society.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 4

All this time, Prince John and Waldemar Fitzurse have been entertaining Norman nobles at York, working them into a frenzy in support of Prince John's impending coup. The day after Torquilstone falls, Maurice de Bracy arrives not just with the bad news of Front-de-Boeuf's death, but that Richard I has returned to England disguised as the Black Knight. Having been magnanimously freed by King Richard, De Bracy refuses to oppose him in any way on Prince John's behalf. He and Fitzurse rapidly begin making plans to avoid Richard's wrath.

Pointing out that their attempts to escape will likely prove futile and that their only hope of safety lies with helping him to seize the throne, Prince John cajoles both men to stay on his side. He declares that he has no violent intentions against Richard I; he will be satisfied with his brother's peaceful imprisonment. Fitzurse protests that the only safety lies in killing the rightful monarch. De Bracy refuses to participate or to allow Prince John to employ his mercenary band directly against the king. Finally, seeing no alternative, Fitzurse accepts the task of eliminating the threat Richard I poses, leaving De Bracy and his mercenaries to guard Prince John.

Prince John cannot maintain power and control in England through his own virtue or his leadership skills; he must beg, bribe, and cheat his way into power. His poor example of leadership both models and enables the abuses of power practiced by the Norman nobility. Once de Bracy confirms what readers have long suspected—that the Black Knight is King Richard—they are invited to look back and directly compare his actions—which are brave, strong, concerned with justice, and directed toward protecting others—with John's.



Events in the book have already portrayed Prince John as an incompetent leader at best and a cowardly and immoral one at worst. His lack of personal ethics and morals trickles down throughout the kingdom in the reign of terror that the Norman noble class which supports him has carried out. When faced with the prospect of King Richard's return, despite John's attempts to encourage Richard's captors to keep him imprisoned, he decides to take the low road and eliminate the competition rather than making himself a better leader.



No sooner has Fitzurse left, however, than Prince John makes it clear to De Bracy that he intends to betray Fitzurse. Although he tacitly ordered Fitzurse to get rid of Richard, Prince John now asserts that he ordered the advisor not to harm a hair on his brother's head, insinuating deadly penalties for disobedience. De Bracy's refusal to do the necessary but unforgiveable task positions him to replace Fitzurse. Prince John dismisses De Bracy, who leaves imagining his future glory as High Marshall of England. Intuiting that De Bracy's loyalties lie only with himself, Prince John quietly makes arrangements for his loyal servants to keep an eye on the mercenary.

As John's inner circle crumbles, the limits of his freewheeling abuse of power, ungrounded in legal principles or any sort of ethical code, become clear. And because he himself behaves in traitorous ways, his advisors cannot—and should not—trust him. Without justice and order, the book suggests here, any government—and the people it governs—is doomed to collapse. Importantly, this is a lesson which applies equally to any era of history, not just the book's medieval setting.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 5

Now the tale returns to Isaac, who stops some four miles short of the Templar Preceptory of Templestowe, exhausted by his furious pace of travel. He stays at the house of Nathan Ben Samuel, a Jewish physician, who treats Isaac's nervous exhaustion and shares more bad news. The head of the Templar Order, Lucas de Beaumanoir, is at the preceptory. In contrast to the worldly, ambitious, and avaricious knights of the Order, Beaumanoir has a zealot's passion for purity and moral rectitude. He's unlikely to be moved by bribes and, to make matters worse, people say he values the death of a Jewish person as highly as the death of the Templars' avowed enemies, the Muslim forces who have seized Jerusalem from the crusaders. He especially distrusts the alleged witchery of Jewish medicine.

Isaac's friend, Nathan Ben Samuel, introduces the third volume's main antagonist in his description of Lucas de Beaumanoir. While thus far the book has criticized its antagonists (Prince John, Maurice de Bracy, Sir Brian) for not having a strong moral code or sense of ethics, Beaumanoir runs to the other extreme. His devotion to a narrow and excessively legalistic moral code—one which remains tainted by a good deal of pride and worldly ambition for the future of the Templar Order—makes him a bad and cruel leader in other ways. Importantly, as a uniquely powerful international organization, the growth and power of the Templar Order under Prince John in England also threatens King Richard's rightful rule.



Be that as it may, Isaac insists, he must do what he can to rescue Rebecca. Nathan Ben Samuel suggests that Isaac try to appeal to Sir Brian privately; despising the Jewish people, Beaumanoir can hardly be expected to take pity on Isaac's or Rebecca's plight. With gratitude, Isaac bids his friend farewell.

Yet again, Rebecca and Isaac find themselves dispossessed, both as native English subjects under oppressive Norman rule (although it doesn't say so explicitly, the Grand Master's French name implies his alignment with the Norman oppressors) and as Jewish people.



The Preceptory of Templestowe is a large, well-maintained, and heavily guarded structure that Isaac hesitates to approach, since his religion makes him an object of scorn and his wealth a target of extortion to those within. Meanwhile, Lucas de Beaumanoir paces a private courtyard with his friend and advisor, Mountfitchet. Age and the hard life of a soldier have not dimmed Beaumanoir's noble bearing or his fiery, zealous devotion to the religious and martial ideals of his Order. Only a little extra lambskin leather and finer wool thread distinguish his plain garments from those worn by the lower ranks.

The character of the Templar Grand Master contrasts and rebukes the profligate excesses of the Prior of Jorvaulx; Aymer wears silks and furs while Beaumanoir's garments remain austere, despite his position in the Order and the vast wealth which the Order commands. The book appreciates Beaumanoir's convictions and casts him as a man of conscience, even as it argues that his extremely narrow and unmerciful beliefs morally compromise him in the end.



Grand Master Beaumanoir expresses his heartsick disgust over the state of the English Templars and their excessive vanity, idleness, gluttony, and sexual indulgence. He describes a dream in which the Order's founders exhorted him to purify it by slaying all its sinners. Mountfitchet suggests that mercy should temper Beaumanoir's justice, but Beaumanoir insists that the Templars cannot ignore the existential threats they face. Despite their powerful friends, they have many enemies willing to seize on their wickedness as reason to oppose their power.

The book celebrates King Richard as a good monarch on the whole, in part because he balances a love of life—expressed in his appreciation for good food and wine and song—with a concern for honor and valor and justice. Thus, while Beaumanoir's attitude initially seems like a necessary corrective to the vice-filled lives of the English clergy—at least those who come from the ranks of Norman nobility, like Aymer and Albert Malvoisin—it strays too far into legalism from mercy to become a viable model of leadership in any era.



A squire enters the courtyard; his humble attitude and clothing impress Beaumanoir. The squire announces that a Jewish man named Isaac has arrived at the gate asking to speak with Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert. Noting that no knight of the Order should be entertaining visitors without his superiors' permission, Beaumanoir thanks the squire for the intelligence and asks him to bring Isaac to the courtyard instead.

Without strong leadership from Albert de Malvoisin, Sir Brian has freely indulged his desires, even when they contradict the rules of his monastic and chivalric codes. His individual excesses both parallel and contribute to the current state of lawlessness in England that grows from its own lack of firm and competent leadership.



Declaring his aversion for Jewish people, Beaumanoir warns Isaac not to say a word except in answer to his questions. He demands to know Isaac's business with Sir Brian. Afraid to anger the Grand Master by showing Sir Brian in a bad light, Isaac hesitates, then hands over Aymer's letter. Beaumanoir reads, with growing rage, Aymer's suggestion that Sir Brian ransom Rebecca before Beaumanoir can find out, then use the money for debauchery with Aymer himself.

As much as Beaumanoir expresses his distaste for Jewish people, it seems like he might rightfully blame the perpetrators of Rebecca's kidnapping (and its attempted coverup). And they have committed or plan to commit many sins against their religious vows and the chivalric virtues the Templar Order stands for—protection of the vulnerable (especially) women, chastity, and poverty.



Then Beaumanoir, seizing on Aymer's description of Rebecca as a "second Witch of Endor," demands to know whether his daughter practices medicine. Isaac confesses that she does. The Grand Master alleges that she heals not through skill but with witchcraft and vows to burn her at the stake, just like someone else recently burned her teacher. Then he orders the squire to drive Isaac from the preceptory.

Beaumanoir quickly pivots, as the book itself so often does, to blaming Jewish victims for the wrongs they suffer. The Witch of Endor appears in the Hebrew Bible as a figure who tries to use black magic to undermine the will of God. By invoking her in this moment, Aymer means to suggest stereotypes found throughout medieval Christian theology that suggest women are inherently devilish and dangerous. But the Grand Master takes the title literally, thanks to his belief that all medicine that Jewish people practice involves black magic.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 6

Albert de Malvoisin, Preceptor of Templestowe and brother of baron Philip de Malvoisin, is just as corrupt and worldly as Sir Brian de Bois-Guilbert, except he hides it better. Beaumanoir summons Albert and demands to know why he allowed Sir Brian to bring a woman—and a “Jewish sorceress” at that—into the preceptory. Albert knew nothing of Rebecca’s arrival before this moment, but, desperate to assuage Beaumanoir’s rage, he claims that he took Rebecca to *protect* Sir Brian from defiling himself with her.

Somewhat comforted by Albert’s claim that Sir Brian hasn’t yet acted on his lust, Beaumanoir considers that Sir Brian may deserve more pity than blame for being led astray by Satan. Mountfitchet adds that it would be a terrible blow for the Order to lose a knight of Sir Brian’s caliber. Beaumanoir muses that executing Rebecca should break her spell and atone for Sir Brian’s sins. He begins to make arrangements to bring her to trial on trumped-up charges.

Albert goes to warn Sir Brian about Beaumanoir’s plan; he finds Sir Brian fuming over Rebecca’s latest rejection. Sir Brian curses what he calls the hereditary obstinacy of “her race.” Albert replies that Sir Brian has brought this on himself through his own obstinate insistence on wooing a Jewish damsel instead of a Christian lady. He begins to agree with Beaumanoir’s belief that Rebecca has bewitched Sir Brian. As if to prove the point, Sir Brian begins making plans for her escape as soon as he learns about the impending trial. But Albert coolly points out that Sir Brian can only escape with his honor, position, and life intact by sacrificing Rebecca. Women, he maintains, are “frail baubles” compared to a man’s ambition.

Sir Brian partially reconciles himself to accept the situation, acknowledging that he’s unwilling to risk his rank and honor for Rebecca—especially considering her repeated rejections. But, as Albert leaves to prepare the judgement chamber, Sir Brian muses that he cannot completely abandon Rebecca to her fate. He still loves her.

Once again, the book claims that everything the corrupt Norman noble class touches falls subject to abuse. Albert de Malvoisin’s deceit magnifies the gravity of his wickedness. And the fact that he needs to protect Sir Brian to protect himself shows part of how Prince John has been able to build a successful Norman coalition despite his personal failings. Any noble (or monk) who faces consequences from the rightful authorities has a vested interest in removing them from power.



Although Beaumanoir seems relatively sincere in his insistence on chastity and religious purity, Mountfitchet emphasizes Sir Brian’s importance to advancing Templar plans. His reaction shows how difficult it is to separate worldly and spiritual concerns, especially in groups like the Templars, who have one foot in the church and the other in European politics. And Rebecca remains the helpless and innocent victim at the center of all these conflicts.



The strength of Sir Brian’s affection for Rebecca begins to strike others as odd, and the Templars begin to believe their own trumped-up charge of witchcraft. In a way, Sir Brian’s continued affection suggests that he embodies the chivalric ideal better than de Bracy, who dropped his courtship of Rowena after just a little bit of pushback from her (and King Richard). But the fact that his insistence borders on obsession and victimizes Rebecca calls into question whether chivalry is a force for good or whether it just disguises evil. Albert’s insistence that Sir Brian coldly abandon Rebecca certainly suggests that he views chivalry as a tool of convenience rather than a true moral code.



Faced with a stark choice, Sir Brian’s priorities come into focus. His obsession with Rebecca may not be as powerful as his thirst for power. Even his appeal to chivalric honor has more to do with maintaining his image to the world than with actually having a moral code.



Meanwhile, Mountfitchet encourages Albert to find fitting grounds to condemn Rebecca as a witch. Only this, he insists, will assuage Beaumanoir's anger and allow the Templar Order to move on from the scandal with its power and honor intact. And, he suggests, Beaumanoir will richly reward Albert for his compliance. Albert concludes that he can bribe testimony from some of his brother's servants who escaped Torquilstone with Sir Brian.

Shortly after the noontime bells, Mountfitchet and Albert fetch Rebecca from her room to answer for unnamed offenses before the preceptory's judge. As courageous as ever, Rebecca follows them willingly into an improvised courtroom, where someone in the crowd presses a scrap of paper, unnoticed, into her hand as she passes.

VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 7

The Templar knights sit arranged by rank in the improvised courtroom, joined by curious locals. Beaumanoir remarks to Mountfitchet about the downcast and ashamed aspect of Sir Brian, who stands in a corner of the hall, distractedly tracing lines on the floor with his sword. Then Beaumanoir addressed the crowd, outlining the grave charges against Sir Brian, who has broken several of the Order's rules. He deserves to be excommunicated and driven from the Order, unless he was driven to his crimes by enchantment. Several witnesses testify to the lengths Sir Brian went to protect Rebecca when they escaped Torquilstone, exaggerating their accounts to the crowd's great delight.

Albert testifies about Sir Brian's arrival with Rebecca, carefully seasoning his account with suggestive comments about the knight's unusual—perhaps enchanted—state of mind. Then he receives his own penance for allowing an unbelieving woman within the preceptory walls. Then Beaumanoir turns his attention towards Rebecca's conduct, calling first on Sir Brian's testimony. Sir Brian asserts that he won't participate in the sham trial, and Beaumanoir takes his reticence as further evidence of bewitchment. A disabled peasant named Higg testifies to Rebecca's healing skills. Beaumanoir assures him that it's better to be bedridden than to court damnation by consorting with Jewish medicine.

Even in the Templar Order, allegedly committed to upholding both chivalric virtue and Christian morality, vice and corruption run rampant. The Order—even its more righteous and less sinful members, like Beaumanoir and Mountfitchet—care more about power and reputation than upholding virtues like justice and truth.



The personal and political machinations and deals that the Templars are carrying out all refer to Rebecca. Though Rebecca is innocent of the Templars' sins—and far braver and more upright in her faith than any of them—the Templars nevertheless consign her to bear the burden of their lust, self-protection, political ambitions, and rigid and unmerciful prejudice.



Sir Brian is still clearly struggling with his feelings for Rebecca, and the conflict between these and his worldly ambitions (which depend on retaining his status as a Templar knight). Beaumanoir interprets Sir Brian's struggle in the way that best suits his own goals, however, pointing toward the essential injustice and corruption that arises when those in charge put their ambition and reputation above all else. The charges also dramatize the vulnerability of women in this male-dominated society; although Sir Brian has committed crimes against his Order and his God, the victim—Rebecca—will pay.



Despite presenting themselves as representatives of God on earth, the Templars show little sign of mercy or honesty in this trial. Albert lies directly, and Beaumanoir callously and piously informs a poor peasant that a life of chronic illness and suffering is better than acknowledging the humanity or skill of a Jewish person. In drawing attention to Higg's disability, the book highlights the weakness of the Templars' case: his incomplete cure suggests that Rebecca's powers remain natural, not magical.



Beaumanoir finally asks Rebecca to testify, threatening to forcibly remove her veil so that the court and its audience can see her face. She complies while still begging the rights of her maidenly modesty, and her strength of character impresses Beaumanoir despite himself. Appreciation for her beauty ripples through the crowd. Even the two men who Albert has bribed to testify against her feel their resolve weaken when they see her face, but a stern look reminds them of their duty. Templeton glosses over their testimony, noting that a modern court would consider half of it immaterial—Rebecca’s exotic clothing, her Hebrew prayers, and her great beauty—and the other half impossible, like the tale of her ability to pull crossbow bolts from men’s wounds with magic.

Yet again, the Templars’ willingness to resort to violence belies their claim to moral superiority over Rebecca just because they are Christians. She demonstrates what true moral uprightness looks like and shows more courage than her allegedly chivalric captor, Sir Brian. Templeton inserts an aside here which works to excuse both his medieval characters and modern readers from complicity in the trial, suggesting that modern standards would discount much of the testimony. In this way, he tries to gloss over a moment which should give modern readers pause, for the forces of self-interest, dishonesty, and persecution still operate in the world.



Beaumanoir demands that Rebecca answer the charges against her. In a calm voice, she asserts the futility of begging for his pity, or of contradicting clearly fabricated evidence. Invoking God as the judge, she appeals to Sir Brian, calling on his honor as a knight and his morals as a Christian, to confirm that the accusations are false. With a tortured look on his face, Sir Brian hisses, “The scroll!” and for the first time Rebecca looks at the paper he put in her hand earlier. It tells her to “Demand a champion!” Still maintaining her innocence, Rebecca appeals to the Normans’ “fierce laws” and demands trial by combat, trusting God to provide a champion for her.

Earlier, in her debate with Ivanhoe, Rebecca expressed doubt in the value of chivalry, claiming that it encouraged violence and domination rather than virtue. Her experiences with Sir Brian tend to confirm this belief. And the fact that she can demand a champion to decide her fate and overrule any ostensible justice a trial might provide also raises questions about Norman customs. But when her appeal to Brian’s sense of nobility and obligation fails, she can only ask for the question to be settled with violence. The theory of judicial combat is that God will favor the knight fighting for the side of right and truth, therefore allowing him to win.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 8

Rebecca’s profound dignity moves even the cold-hearted Beaumanoir. But he will only offer pity and forgiveness if she “confess [her] witchcraft” and convert to Christianity. She refuses. Asserting that he could, if he wished, rightfully ignore the requests of a Jewish woman, Beaumanoir turns to the crowd and asks who will represent the Templars in the contest. One of the preceptors nominates Sir Brian, who has no choice but to accept. Beaumanoir gives Rebecca just three days to find a champion. Only Higg, grateful for her doctoring and feeling guilty over his testimony, proves willing to show sympathy for a Jewish person, and accepts the task of taking a message to Isaac. Rebecca scribbles a note and hands it to him along with money to hire a horse.

Rebecca’s appeal to the customs of chivalry rests on shaky ground; doubly disenfranchised as an English native (rather than a Norman) and a Jewish woman, she must depend on Beaumanoir’s sense of honor. In this case, chivalry comes through for her, but the precarity of her situation suggests that it is not a reliable source of morality and justice. This becomes especially apparent when Sir Brian must fight for the Templars rather than for Rebecca (which was clearly his plan)—to save face with the order, he accepts the task even though it almost certainly condemns her to death.



Higg finds Isaac and Nathan Ben Samuel on the road a mere quarter mile from the preceptory, anxiously awaiting news of the trial. After taking one look at the scroll, Isaac faints dead away, and he remains too upset to talk while Samuel reads the letter for himself. It explains the trial’s resolution and instructs Isaac to seek help from Ivanhoe. Although he is still too weak to fight, Rebecca hopes he might have a willing friend.

A rematch between Ivanhoe and Sir Brian would put chivalry to the test, just as their first match made a claim for Saxon superiority over Norman ambition. Although both men have worldly honor and success in battle, Ivanhoe truly embodies the virtues of knighthood, while Sir Brian uses them disingenuously, playing the role out of self-interest.



Samuel reminds Isaac that King Richard loves Ivanhoe and hates the English Templars; he might decide to intervene. Renewed with this hope, Isaac rides for Rotherwood while Samuel returns home. They leave Higg in the road, cursing their avarice, since they didn't pay him for his services. Although he's been able to pocket the money Rebecca gave him, he considers it insufficient reward for the damnation his religion tells him to expect for helping rather than hating Jewish people.

Although this chapter mainly sets up the third volume's main contest—between the truly virtuous chivalry of Ivanhoe and Sir Brian's insincere playacting—it closes on an antisemitic note. Higg's expectation of a better reward seems to grow from common beliefs about Jewish wealth. And, although he's grateful for Rebecca's help (and impressed by her beauty), he can't help but fall prey to the religious prejudices of his age.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 9

The evening of the sham trial, Rebecca sings her prayers, which end by recalling God's promise to lead the Israelites from bondage in Egypt. After a quiet knock, Sir Brian enters. He explains that he expected the role of champion to fall to a lesser knight within the Order and planned to take the field in her defense (in disguise, of course). Now he sees only one way to save her from death and himself from dishonor: running away together to Palestine. Sir Brian loves Rebecca more than anything but his overwhelming ambition. He will sacrifice everything but that out of love for her. He warns her that she faces certain death if she forces the challenge, since he believes that neither Ivanhoe nor King Richard—the only knights he fears—are available.

Rebecca's ongoing, active practice of her faith contrasts sharply with the book's Christians, who by and large practice their faith in a self-serving way. Sir Brian's membership in the Templar Order, for example, gives him access to power and wealth. He's already shown that he doesn't feel compelled to fulfil his vow of chastity, and now he expresses disbelief that God could actually control the outcome of the judicial combat. In this way, he associates religion with power rather than truth and justice. And, in terms of the book's exploration of chivalry, Sir Brian remains deeply conflicted, torn between doing the right thing (standing up for Rebecca) and his worldly ambition.



Rebecca refuses. She insinuates that if Sir Brian truly loved her, he would protect her without hope of reward. His selfishness points towards his inability to rule his own passions. Unable to hope for succor from mankind, Rebecca consigns herself to God, and she promises Sir Brian that she faces death more willingly than dishonor and her resolve will never weaken. Sir Brian wishes that she had been born a Christian or he had been born as a reviled Jewish man so they could easily be together. Rebecca replies that she prefers to be persecuted than to be a persecuting Christian person whose evil actions belie their religious beliefs.

Rebecca makes a final appeal to Sir Brian's sense of chivalry—as a monk he should value truth and honesty; as a knight he should protect the vulnerable; as one who claims to love her, he should value her life and safety more highly. But she recognizes that his failures stem from an inability to practice self-control, and so she quickly throws herself on the mercy of God, not a fellow human. Her genuine faith makes her stronger and braver than the book's best knights; and she guides her life by the precepts of her religion rather than twisting her religion to suit political ambition or worldly persecution.



Still, Sir Brian can still hardly tear himself away from Rebecca and he wonders aloud how she has enchanted him with her feminine wiles. Still attracted by her beauty and courage, he begs her to forgive him so they can depart as friends. Rebecca forgives her captor. She sees nobility in him, even if his mind is an overgrown garden where weeds of pride and willfulness choke out the flowers of his better nature. Acknowledging her insight, Sir Brian withdraws.

Sir Brian continues to cast love as a powerful spell which saps his manly strength and resolve. But Rebecca reveals the secret of her fortitude and inner power to Sir Brian, and it has nothing to do with being a woman. Instead, she practices the self-control which Sir Brian and others lack. Where he cannot rule his passionate feelings for her, she tames her own feelings for Ivanhoe (even if she cannot root them out entirely). Where he cannot forgive himself for betraying her, she forgives him.



Albert Malvoisin waits impatiently for Sir Brian in the hallway. He grows more impatient when he realizes how deeply conflicted Sir Brian is about his feelings. Sir Brian declares that he will refuse to fight, or fight as Rebecca's champion. Albert reminds him that either will earn him shame and imprisonment at best. It requires great effort on Albert's part, but he tenuously convinces Sir Brian of his blamelessness in the matter of the challenge, which Beaumanoir holds responsibility for allowing. And, with careful flattery and mention of his rivals, Albert rekindles the knight's fighting spirit as well.

Brian shows himself to be exactly as Rebecca has just alleged – noble in some of his sentiments but not in control of himself and unsteady in his actions. In a way, his internal conflict shows him in a better light than Albert de Malvoisin, who worries more about maintaining the reputation (and might) of the Order than about truth, justice, and mercy. The ease with which he rekindles Sir Brian's fighting spirit points toward chivalry's limitations: as a set of customs, it is inherently neutral and can be used for good or bad ends.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 10

Now the tale backtracks necessarily to trace the adventures of King Richard (once again disguised as the Black Knight), who took Ivanhoe to a nearby priory where he could continue to recuperate. The two spoke privately for a while before the Black Knight, accompanied by Wamba as a guide, prepared to set forth for Coningsburgh and Athelstane's funeral. He plans for Ivanhoe to join him there, after he's had a few more days to recover. But no sooner has King Richard left than Ivanhoe orders the prior to give him a horse. He has a premonition of approaching evil, besides which, Rebecca's medicine is uncommonly effective. The reluctant prior eventually lends him a horse and, with Gurth acting as squire, the young knight sets out.

Although readers and a select few men (Ivanhoe, de Bracy, Prince John, and Prince John's closest advisors) now know the Black Knight's identity, he reassumes his disguise both to protect himself until he can raise an army and because—as the book implies here and will later state outright—he enjoys a life of knight-errantry. A king should not risk his life in this way, since the wellbeing and fate of the kingdom depend on his own safety. This—plus their personal friendship—animates Ivanhoe's worried pursuit.



Meanwhile Wamba and King Richard ride merrily through the forest. Wamba now has a real sword at his side, despite being a "fool"; Templeton assures readers he wasn't so much actually witless as prone to an anxious, irritable restlessness in both body and mind that made it often difficult for him to attend to any task—or thought—at hand for long. Together, the companions sing love-songs to pass the time.

Accepting Wamba (once called "witless" but now thought capable of handling a sword) thanks to his brave actions at Torquilstone and before shows Richard's ability to judge a person by their character rather than their title. This bodes well for Saxon interests, since the Normans' actions in Richard's absence haven't shown them in a good light.



Eventually, they fall to discussing Locksley and his woodsmen. Wamba shares some proverbial wisdom with King Richard. If you entertain a Saxon with a full wine-pitcher or walk in the woods with a full purse, you'll quickly find your vessels empty. King Richard expresses shock at Wamba's suggestion that Locksley and his companions are thieves. Wamba replies that they are, even if they strive to keep a clean balance sheet with Heaven by balancing out robberies with good deeds. But they're not the worst danger of the wild places; Philip Malvoisin's followers are far more violent and dangerous.

Evidently, King Richard doesn't consider the woodsmen's pillage of Torquilstone theft, so he's surprised to find such allegations leveled at men whom he considered to be paragons of fairness and justice. It's clear that, although he's been disposed by his own brother, he doesn't yet fully grasp the degree of corruption of which Norman nobility are guilty. Wamba draws his attention to this, too, foreshadowing the impending restitution of Saxon rights.



When King Richard boasts that he fears no man, Wamba relieves him of the bugle, worried that he might need to call for backup. Soon, Wamba spots a potential ambush, and just as he warns Richard, arrows rain down on them from a nearby thicket. Richard charges into the thicket and attacks the ambushers, six or seven armed men under the command of a knight in blue, who mortally wounds Richard's horse. Wamba sounds the bugle as Richard braces his back to an **oak** tree to face his attackers. The knight in blue prepares to charge, intent on pinning Richard, but cannot after Wamba hobbles his horse's legs.

Just then, Locksley, the Cleric of Copmanhurst, and several of their companions burst into the clearing. They help the Black Knight (King Richard) subdue his attackers. He demands the identity of the knight in blue, who reveals himself as Waldemar Fitzurse. Richard takes Fitzurse aside and demands to know the meaning of the attack; Fitzurse confesses that Prince John ordered it. Although Fitzurse proudly and pointedly refuses to beg Richard to spare his life, Richard lets him go, giving him three days to leave England forever. Then, turning to Locksley, he orders the woodsmen to let Fitzurse leave unharmed, revealing himself to them as King Richard.

The woodsmen bow to their king as he pardons their misdemeanors and thievery. Locksley confesses that he is none other than Robin Hood of Sherwood Forest, the "King of Outlaws." Wamba mutters that the mice will play when the cat's away, causing King Richard to note his presence with surprise. Wamba proudly explains how he helped by hobbling Fitzurse's horse. Then they hear the Cleric (whom most stories of Robin Hood call "Friar Tuck") fall to his knees in prayer, begging forgiveness for fist-fighting with his sovereign. Richard not only grants forgiveness but names him warden to the royal forests of Warncliffe. And as the company prepares to ride, two men appear.

VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 11

The newcomers are Wilfred of Ivanhoe and Gurth. King Richard greets them as himself, not the Black Knight, and cheerfully explains the outcome of Fitzurse's treasonous attack. Ivanhoe chides Richard for risking himself in knight-errantry when the fate and wellbeing of the kingdom depend on his life; Richard points out that Ivanhoe disobeyed him by following him instead of recuperating at the priory. Besides, he feels confident in his disguise, which remains necessary until his supporters have finished preparing to ride with him against John.

When Wamba sensibly relieves Richard of Locksley's bugle, he suggests that a certain foolhardiness may lie at the root of chivalry. Likewise, while the book generally celebrates King Richard's chivalric spirit, it does occasionally offer evidence that this might be a weakness, too.. The debate about the value of chivalry continues, unresolved. And, as ever, an important component of the debate revolves around how well a knight does or does not embody chivalric virtues. By assuming a disguise to lay an ambush, the blue-clad knight shows himself in an unchivalrous light.



Locksley and his men render aid to the Black Knight, suggesting that for all his martial prowess and personal excellence, Richard I cannot successfully rule England without embracing the Saxons to a greater degree than his predecessors. Fitzurse attacked Richard in what amounts to an inglorious assassination attempt; his refusal to beg for his life shows that he understands the severity of this breach of chivalric conduct, which favors knights competing openly and fairly. In response, Richard gallantly spares his life.



The Cleric of Copmanhurst is technically guilty of Fitzurse's crime—an attack on the rightful king, even though Richard was disguised at the moment. But, showing characteristic good humor and fighting spirit, King Richard forgives him not just for that offense but for the other extremes to which Norman abuses of power drove him—such as thievery and poaching. He then begins to reassert his royal rights and to set things in his kingdom back to order by placing the cleric in charge of the royal deer—the implication being that Richard has the right to dispose of them as he wishes, even if that means willingly allowing them to be poached.



Ivanhoe's worry does not constitute a critique of chivalry in itself, but it does suggest that there are limits to chivalry's utility and benefit in the world. The king risking his life exceeds these boundaries because the wellbeing and livelihood of everyone in the kingdom depends on the king. The abuses that Prince John and the other Norman nobles perpetuate during Richard's absence on Crusade prove as much.



Ivanhoe, well aware of the futility of trying to dissuade the strong-willed King Richard, holds his peace, as Richard turns to Robin Hood and asks what the outlaw can provide for a meal. Only, Robin Hood answers somewhat shamefacedly, poached venison. Richard takes the news in good cheer, and the company prepares to meet at one of the outlaws' camps. Richard seems to be in a better mood having an adventure in the forest than he would have been retaking his rightful throne attended by his nobles; novelty and adventure are the joys of his life, and he possesses the character of a knight errant more than a king.

Because all deer in the royal forests belong to the king, Robin Hood openly admits his guilt. But, in light of his support—and all too aware of the vicious Norman rule which necessitated it—Richard forgives him, just as he forgave the Cleric. The Saxons are beginning to find that their Norman overlord is welcoming and treating them well, confirming Richard's suitability for the throne. Templeton's aside here confirms and amplifies the critique Ivanhoe made of his sovereign and friend a moment before; although the book generally paints Richard in a good light, his devotion to a life of chivalry had real historic consequences, which Templeton cannot deny. Of his 10-year reign, Richard only spent about six months in England; the rest of the time saw him on various military campaigns, including the disastrous Third Crusade and attempts to regain his family's traditional territory in France. His absence—and the excessive taxes he levied to support his armies—contributed to a period of unrest in England.



Under the shade of a large **oak** tree, the woodsmen-outlaws share a hearty meal with King Richard, their awe for their rightful sovereign soon replaced with cheerful conviviality. Robin Hood becomes anxious to end the feast before one of his men can accidentally insult the king; he has one of his men sneak into the forest and blow Philip Malvoisin's call on a bugle. The woodsmen jump up and take their arms, then swiftly disperse into the forest in chase. With the clearing emptied, Robin Hood confesses the ruse to Richard, who feels a flash of annoyance before recognizing the wisdom of the outlaw's action.

Seated under the symbolic oak and sharing a meal, Robin Hood and King Richard demonstrate what a unified Saxon-Norman country might look like. Still, the book cannot usher in a golden age of English identity yet—that would be contrary to the historical records on which it is based. And while Richard has been in a forgiving mood up to this point, now that he's revealed himself, he has a duty to uphold the law and custom.



As King Richard grudgingly prepares to break off his adventures and ride for Coningsburgh, Robin Hood assures him that the outlaw band will keep an eye on the forest roads and assist if the king encounters any other ambushes. Shaking hands and promising not only royal pardon and friendship, but a relaxing of the harsh laws that drove Robin Hood and his companions to their current state of anarchy, Richard departs. His untimely death, Templeton informs readers, prevented him from following through on these promises. And if readers wish to learn about Robin Hood's fate, they can read it in other books.

Having made peace with Robin Hood and his Saxon outlaws, King Richard prepares to mend bridges with other, more important and less friendly Saxons, like Cedric. The work of unifying the kingdom will not happen overnight but will require ongoing effort and compromise. Unfortunately, as Templeton informs readers, Richard will not see this work through, since he died within five years of his triumphant return to England.



The stately and ancient fortress of Coningsburgh sits on a picturesque hill. In Templeton's time, a thick wall will surround it, built long after King Richard's day. A plain black banner, without a coat of arms because the Saxons haven't yet adopted heraldry, signifies the castle's state of mourning, and everyone within bustles about preparing for the funeral feast. Inside the gates, local peasants and minor Norman nobles help themselves to the feast being laid out; peddlers, minstrels, bards, returned crusaders, jesters, and jugglers mill around the castle-yard as Richard, Ivanhoe, Gurth, and Wamba arrive. A steward greets them and ushers them inside with all due solemnity.

As the book draws toward its happy conclusion—a moment of unity anticipating the eventual reconciliation of Saxon and Norman elements of English culture—Templeton's informative asides become more frequent. This one pointedly remarks on the ways the past influences the present, since early 19th-century readers (and modern 21st-century readers for that matter) can still visit this castle, although it looks different today than it did in King Richard's era. Ironically, Templeton's description of the castle also demonstrates the limits of his own historical approach; although well into the 19th century the castle was widely believed to have been built by the Saxons, modern archaeology has determined that it was likely built by the Normans in the 11th century.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 12

As the steward leads King Richard and Ivanhoe up the precipitously steep stairs and into the castle, Ivanhoe covers his face to prevent being recognized before Richard can reconcile Cedric to his son. Cedric, seated at the head of a band of old Saxon lords, greets Richard as the Black Knight, whom he recognizes from the tournament. After Richard carefully returns Cedric's Saxon greeting, Cedric shows him and Ivanhoe to the chapel, where a group of local monks pray for Athelstane's soul with a zeal born of superstition and gratitude for the large donation made in Athelstane's honor by his mother.

Ivanhoe and King Richard reassume their disguises, but although their faces are hidden, they cannot obscure their noble characters. Richard continues to demonstrate his fitness to be king of England by talking to Cedric in Saxon. This not only shows that he knows the language (a bit of poetic license on the book's part; no contemporary evidence suggested that Richard was fluent in Saxon and most modern historians doubt that he could understand the language at all) but that he respects Cedric's heritage—and by implication, that he values the Saxon population generally. Readers should pay attention to the aside about the monks' avarice; it foreshadows exciting events to come.



Ushered by Cedric, King Richard and Ivanhoe pay their respects to Athelstane's mourning mother. She thanks Richard (still disguised as the anonymous Black Knight) for freeing her son from Torquilstone, then bids them to enjoy the castle's hospitality. Next, Cedric shows them to another room where Rowena leads some maidens in funeral hymns while others embroider Athelstane's funeral pall and arrange the flowers for his bier. The young ladies attend to their tasks with seriousness but little sadness.

Preparations for Athelstane's funeral suggest that few, other than his mother and Cedric, will truly miss the man. Whereas the entire nation longs for the return of King Richard, Athelstane seems forgettable, and this suggests that Cedric's plans to try and put him on the throne were doomed from the start.



Finally, Cedric shows them to a room set aside for guests with “slight connection” to the deceased. But before he can take his leave, King Richard demands the reward Cedric promised his rescuer. Then he reveals his identity. Cedric refuses to bow to a Norman, but rather than becoming angry, Richard agrees that he has no right to Cedric’s homage until he has proved himself an equal friend to Saxons and Normans alike. Then King Richard names his reward: he wants Cedric to forgive his son. Ivanhoe steps forward and throws himself at his father’s feet. Cedric grants Ivanhoe full forgiveness but commands him to stop dressing and behaving according to Norman customs. And he warns his son not to speak of marrying Rowena yet, since she must complete two years’ mourning for Athelstane.

Then, as if summoned by his name, Athelstane himself, dressed for burial, stumbles through the door. He tells the astonished party an incredible tale: Sir Brian did indeed knock him unconscious but did not kill him. He recovered consciousness in a nearby abbey whose monks seemed dismayed at his survival, since it meant they wouldn’t be imminently receiving large donations from his family in his honor. The monks have kept him half drugged and locked in the abbey’s cellar for days while praying over an empty coffin at the castle. Only by luck—a somewhat drunk monk forgot to lock the cellar door—did Athelstane escape, find his horse, and ride back to Coningsburgh.

Cedric encourages Athelstane to immediately challenge Richard for the English throne. But Athelstane’s recent near-death experience and imprisonment have given him some clarity. He no longer cares to pursue his claim to the throne, nor does he want to waste English blood in civil war. He’s well aware of Rowena’s disdain for him. He’s ready to renounce both, offering his loyalty to King Richard and giving Rowena to Ivanhoe himself, but during his lengthy soliloquy, Ivanhoe, Rowena, King Richard, and the rest have all disappeared. At length, Wamba explains that Isaac appeared in the courtyard with a message that sent Ivanhoe for his horse. No one knows where Richard went. Shrugging, Athelstane prepares to dig into his own funeral feast.

Cedric’s assumption that these guests, with their “slight connection” to Athelstane, are Norman proves mostly correct when King Richard reveals himself and Ivanhoe. When Richard refuses to take offense at Cedric’s defiance, he shows himself to be a just and reasonable king who understands and regrets the abuses Saxons have suffered under Norman rule. The conditions Cedric places on Ivanhoe’s restoration suggest that he still tends to look more toward the past than the future. Whether this constitutes beneficial Saxon strength or self-defeating obstinacy remains unclear. In either case, Cedric’s inflexible attempt to live in the past suggests the impossibility of full Saxon restitution.



Athelstane’s sudden and seemingly miraculous resurrection threatens the tentative peace between Richard and Cedric; the Saxons still (or yet again) have a claimant to the throne. His incredible story suggests that corruption and moral rot are more widespread than it first seemed; even the monks of the nearest Saxon monastery place their greed above the good of the country or the freedom of a nobleman. Their attempt to trick Athelstane into believing he’s in purgatory recalls anticlerical stories from the Middle Ages where corrupt clergy lie in similar ways either to gain wealth or access to their victims’ wives.



Athelstane claims that he returned to life a changed man, no longer saddled with royal ambitions. But his excuses recall earlier behavior that already suggested he was unfit to rule—he’s more concerned with eating and drinking than with leading, he lacks fighting spirit and the bloodthirstiness to match the Normans’ chivalric emphasis on fighting, and he doesn’t even want to force Rowena into an unhappy marriage. Thus, his acceptance of Richard confirms the foregone conclusion (which the facts of history force on the book) that Richard will one day hold the throne. And it confirms Richard’s right—both by birth and by his excellent character—to fulfill the role of king.



VOLUME 3, CHAPTER 13

Meanwhile, at the Preceptory of Templestowe, crowds gather to watch the judicial combat, anxious and bloodthirsty. The fight will take place on a field adjacent to the preceptory where the Templars train and host tournaments; for this reason, it is already outfitted with galleries and benches. At one end of the field sits a throne from which Beaumanoir will direct the proceedings; at the opposite end, a stake stands ready to burn Rebecca to death should her challenger lose. Four Black men enslaved by the Order stand ready to carry out the sentence. In their foreignness—for few if any in medieval England had ever seen a non-white person—they seem diabolical to the crowd.

Rumors of devilish circumstances fly through the crowds; a young minstrel clad in green (later identified as Allan-a-Dale) overhears two monks—one of whom turns out to be the Cleric of Copmanhurst—discussing Athelstane's recent return from the dead. The sound of bells tolling in the nearby church silences their conversation.

Soon the gates of the preceptory open and a procession of Templars approaches the field. Grand Master Beaumanoir looks splendid in his austere garments, while Sir Brian seems pale, distracted, and full of emotional turmoil. Mountfitchet and Albert de Malvoisin ride beside him. Four black-clad wardens lead Rebecca, clothed only in a simple white dress, to the field. Even stripped of her finery, her courage, resignation, and beauty inspire sympathy in the most hard-hearted and bigoted onlookers.

After completing a circle of the tournament field, the Templar grandees arrange themselves on their platform. Rebecca's guards convey her to a chair placed near the stake and although she shudders when she first sees it, within moments, she regains control of her emotions and sits down with impressive calm. Albert de Malvoisin formally delivers Rebecca's challenge to Beaumanoir, who demands that Sir Brian swear before God that his quarrel is "just and honorable." Albert replies that Sir Brian already did, thus neatly avoiding the conflict that was sure to arise if Beaumanoir tried to make Sir Brian publicly agree with the Templars' charges against Rebecca.

The availability of tournament grounds ready to receive a crowd of anxious spectators suggests that the Templars' motivations in the world are at best mixed between religious devotion and a desire for chivalric adventure. Given that readers already know how morally compromised Sir Brian, Albert de Malvoisin, and Sir Brian are, the way that they set the stage for their mockery of justice merely emphasizes their hypocrisy and abuse of power. Their use of enslaved Black people to do their dirty work confirms it, too.



Templeton has pointed out the superstitious nature of medieval England at several points; by placing superstitious rumors in the mouths of the crowd, the book attempts to create some distance between the bloodthirsty prejudices of its medieval characters and its 19th-century and modern readers, suggesting a view of history that tends toward enlightenment and progress.



The last time readers saw Sir Brian, Albert de Malvoisin was certain that he'd helped the knight get over his infatuation with Rebecca and regain his fighting spirit. His appearance in the parade suggests otherwise. In contrast to his pallor and distress, Rebecca enters the lists just as brave and beautiful as ever; she shows what happens when a person truly believes what they claim to believe and truly acts in a righteous way.



Rebecca's halting approach to the stake reminds readers that she is, after all, a human being, not just an empty paragon of virtue. Her courage and steadfastness don't come without effort. But by mastering her own fears, she demonstrates the greatness available to anyone—like Sir Brian, or even perhaps readers—who learns to master their own emotions. Albert acknowledges (to readers, if not to Beaumanoir) that Sir Brian will not willingly swear before God that his cause is righteous because he knows it isn't. Still, his overpowering ambition and thirst for power outweigh his interest in the truth.



A herald introduces Sir Brian and announces the challenge. When, after several moments, no champion appears for Rebecca, Beaumanoir sends the herald to ask if she expects one. She replies that God may still deliver her, and Beaumanoir decrees that he will wait until the hour of noon. If no one has come by then, he will declare her guilt and proceed with her execution. While Rebecca patiently waits, an anguished Sir Brian offers one final time to rescue her; unwilling to accept his proclamations of love and respect in light of being kidnapped and exposed to danger because of his lust, Rebecca refuses yet again.

Just as the restless crowd seems about to give up hope of a champion appearing, a knight thunders up to the tournament field on an exhausted and sweaty horse. Naming himself openly as Wilfred of Ivanhoe, he formally accepts the Templars' challenge. In a hollow voice, Sir Brian tries to protest that he will not fight a knight so recently wounded, but Ivanhoe refuses to back down, and needles his opponent with the memory of their past clashes, all of which Ivanhoe won. Beaumanoir declares Ivanhoe's right to fight if Rebecca accepts him as her champion; she does, but not without concern for his health. Throwing himself on the mercy of God, Ivanhoe prepares to face Sir Brian despite his wounds and his horse's fatigue.

Sir Brian and Ivanhoe take their places and wait for the herald's signal. On the first charge, Sir Brian predictably strikes down both Ivanhoe and his exhausted horse. Less expectedly, however, although Ivanhoe's lance barely touches Sir Brian's shield, he too falls from the saddle. Ivanhoe regains his feet almost instantly and quickly places his foot on Sir Brian's chest and his sword at Sir Brian's throat. He asks the Templar to yield, but Sir Brian remains silent. Begging him to spare Sir Brian's life, Beaumanoir declares Ivanhoe the winner. Then he descends into the lists and removes Sir Brian's helmet only to discover the once fearsome Templar lying dead, a victim of his own warring passions. Looking towards heaven, Beaumanoir declares that the result cannot be anything but the clear will of God.

Readers know that Ivanhoe—and maybe even King Richard—are at this very moment heading toward the tournament grounds; Rebecca does not and must rely on her own courage and resilience to face the increasingly likely possibility of her death. Her equanimity contrasts sharply with Sir Brian's distress, proving once again that she is the better, braver person, even though she finds herself in this vulnerable position.



When Ivanhoe arrives, his horse's state of exhaustion and his own recovering strength place the judicial combat squarely into the hands of divine providence. In a fair fight, he and Sir Brian are more evenly matched (although he's already defeated Sir Brian twice). But in judicial combat, God joins the side of the righteous. Sir Brian's attempts to delay the fight implicitly acknowledge his own lies and weakness of character; on the wrong side, he feels doomed to lose. Conversely, wholly trusting in his own superior sense of right and wrong, Beaumanoir greets the arrival of such an obviously weak champion with delight. By setting up the conflict in this way, the book comes as close as it ever will to indulging in the sort of miraculous and marvelous events that typically occur in medieval romances.



Although the book attempts to posit a rational explanation for Sir Brian's collapse—claiming that nervous exhaustion killed him—the fact that he dies in the course of judicial combat cannot help but suggest the possibility of divine intervention. Regardless of what exactly gave Ivanhoe the victory, this moment asserts the reordering of England in several important ways. A Saxon has defeated an ignoble, abusive Norman once and for all. Truth has triumphed over lies. An innocent victim has been vindicated. And for all his faults, Beaumanoir acknowledges his defeat.



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After a moment of shocked silence, Ivanhoe asks Beaumanoir to declare whether he won the match squarely. Beaumanoir replies that he did, declares Rebecca a free woman, and forfeits Sir Brian's belongings to Ivanhoe. Ivanhoe replies he wants nothing of Sir Brian's and the Templars should bury him quietly, but with dignity. Just then, King Richard and a party of armed knights thunder into the lists. After briefly chiding Ivanhoe for taking on the challenge in his weakened state, Richard declares Albert de Malvoisin under arrest for treason. Beaumanoir asserts that he alone can punish Templars, and his men face the king in challenge. But after a moment's standoff, he and the rest of the Templars bow to Richard's will and retreat.

Isaac crushes Rebecca in an ecstatic embrace. He wants to thank Ivanhoe instantly, but Rebecca doesn't trust her ability to keep her emotions in check. Only when she points out the presence of King Richard—who, Isaac fears, might try to extort money from them as punishment for financing Prince John—does Isaac willingly leave the lists.

While the crowd cheers for King Richard, the Earl of Essex catches Ivanhoe up on recent developments. Prince John's supporters abandoned him, and he delivered himself into Richard's custody. Richard greeted him warmly, then "suggested" that John join their mother (imprisoned elsewhere in England) until Richard's angry supporters could forget his treason. Ivanhoe worries that King Richard's mercy invites future coup attempts, but Essex hopes that the harsher punishments handed down to John's supporters will quell dissent. De Bracy and Waldemar Fitzurse escape with banishment, but Philip and Albert de Malvoisin are executed.

King Richard's popularity among the people ends Cedric's dreams of Saxon restoration once and for all. Moreover, with Athelstane and Rowena now both dissenting to his fond wish for their marriage, he has no hope of unifying the Saxons anyway. Eventually, he must sadly conclude that Athelstane is, as Wamba put it, "a cock which would not fight."

With Sir Brian's death, Prince John has lost his last key supporter—Richard has warned off both de Bracy and Fitzurse, and Front-de-Boeuf died at Torquilstone. Nothing prevents King Richard from revealing himself to the assembled crowd and reasserting his rightful place as king of England. He wastes no time continuing to correct wrongs which began back when Ivanhoe scored a Saxon victory over Sir Brian in the tournament and which continue at an ever faster pace now that Ivanhoe has killed the Templar. Beaumanoir's assertion of power suggests just how poorly John has ruled—no one seems to respect the absolute authority of the king anymore.



Rebecca's reticence reminds readers that she still has romantic feelings for Ivanhoe; it requires heroic (but not superhuman) efforts for her to keep her impossible desires in check. And her discussion with her father reminds readers of the still-precarious situation they face; even in a reordered and just England, as Jewish people, they remain dependent on the goodness and mercy of the powerful for protection.



Although the book somewhat alters facts to provide narrative tension and closure (King Richard never traveled in disguise; Prince John surrendered several months later, and in France) it largely follows history. This careful balancing act recalls Templeton's assertion that historical fiction is a powerful genre because its vividness can invite the kind of interest which dry history cannot. Richard demonstrates his gallant, chivalrous spirit in forging Prince John, and the necessary resolve to be king in punishing the Malvoisins.



Although he clings to his Saxon identity (remember that he just reconciled with Ivanhoe on the condition that Ivanhoe never wear Norman-style clothes again), even Cedric must eventually accept the idea that the restoration of England's rightful inheritance—both Saxon and Norman—rests on finding a way forward together.



Finally, only Cedric's characteristic obstinacy lies in the way of Ivanhoe and Rowena's marriage, and it eventually gives way to Rowena's cajoling, his natural pride in his son, and the continued offer of friendship he receives from King Richard. The fact that King Richard attends the wedding greatly reassures the Saxons that they will more likely attain their just rights by aligning themselves with Richard than by opposing him. Thus, the wedding of Ivanhoe and Rowena both joins young lovers and promises a future of Norman and Saxon unity in England. The seeds of this new society sprout in Cedric's lifetime, with freer friendships and marriage alliances between the groups, although it won't reach maturity until the reign of Edward III when the mixed Saxon-Norman pidgin, English, becomes the official court language.

Two days after the wedding, Rebecca visits Rowena. She enters the room with an attitude of respect untainted by fear or obligation, and she throws herself at Rowena's feet, begging Rowena to thank Ivanhoe for risking his life on her behalf. Rebecca and Isaac plan to leave England for Grenada; they expect greater security in the court of a Muslim king than a Christian one, even though King Richard loves their benefactor Ivanhoe. She cuts off Rowena's objections, noting that she will never fully understand the prejudices Rebecca and her father face.

Rebecca asks to see Rowena's face, and blushing intensely, Rowena removes her veil. Her beauty momentarily takes Rebecca's breath away, but, regaining her customary equilibrium, she promises to remember Rowena for many years. And she presents the bride with a diamond necklace and earrings. Rowena protests about the cost of the gift, but Rebecca insists, noting that the wealth held by Jewish people throughout Europe means nothing compared to the influence—and prejudice—of the European nobility. She only wants Rowena to know that greed does not drive all Jewish people.

Asking Rowena to tell Ivanhoe that she goes away intent on living a life of devotion to her faith and to the care of the poor—and in a voice that betrays many more thoughts than she voluntarily expresses—Rebecca bids Rowena farewell. When Rowena tells Ivanhoe about this exchange, it makes a deep impression on his mind.

King Richard's diligent pursuit of Cedric's support and loyalty proves him a worthy king for Saxons and Normans alike, and his presence at Ivanhoe's and Rowena's marriage foreshadows the unified English identity which will develop in later centuries and lead to the power and prestige the nation enjoyed in the 19th century and beyond. This culminating moment invites the novel's 19th-century British readers to feel pride and emotional investment in the lives of their ancestors. And at the moment of the wedding, it seems like the world of England has been fully restored.



But not everything has been made right. On the one hand, the novel finds itself constrained by history; it cannot give Rebecca and Isaac an easy, happy ending when history clearly shows that Jewish people faced ongoing persecution throughout the period and beyond. About a century after the events in this book, a later English king would expel every Jewish person from England. On the other hand, Rebecca gains her depth and emotional impact from her equanimity in the face of trial and difficulty. Her choice to leave England allows her to remain in control of herself, rather than allowing herself to be continually subjected to external circumstances. In this way, she maintains her profound dignity and power.



Throughout the book, Rowena has served to counteract and correct stereotypes about Jewish people. Where they are considered greedy, she has been generous. Where they are considered self-serving, she has risked herself for others. Where they are considered deluded in their religious beliefs, she has shown herself to be the most faithful worshipper and most upright human being in the book. Her gift to Rowena underlines these claims and rebukes Rowena's suggestion that she convert.



Just as when she faced the stake with courage—but not without fear—Rebecca leaves England and relinquishes her feelings for Ivanhoe voluntarily, if not easily. And the book teasingly suggests that Ivanhoe may have indeed harbored more feelings for his lovely benefactress than he would have admitted.



Rowena and Ivanhoe live together for many happy years. And readers should not, Templeton insists, wonder if Ivanhoe remembered Rebecca more frequently than Rowena might have liked. Ivanhoe rises through the ranks at court, his ascent stopped only by Richard I's premature death, which condemns Ivanhoe to be a forgotten name, and, ultimately, just a "tale."

In the end, Ivanhoe never fully resolves the debate about the value of chivalry, but its reliance on historical fact forces it to acknowledge that, at least in King Richard's case, an inability to put the good of his people and his kingdom above his own thirst for glory led to disaster for the king and his people. But although Templeton suggests here that Ivanhoe's fate points toward the ultimate emptiness of chivalry, the fact that his honor, bravery, and nobility have suffused the book which bears his name argues otherwise.





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